

BOUTAHRI PRODUCTIONS

THE COLLECTORS

A Multiverse Limited Series

Written & Created by

YOUSSEF BOUTAHRI

15 Episodes | 70-90 Minutes Each

Hollywood Screenplay Format

"From one weakness was born infinite power."

"The evil you cannot see is not in power. It is in the
architecture."

A bridge between THE DEVIL YOU DON'T KNOW and THE FINAL WAR

Production Style: Denis Villeneuve / The Russo Brothers

Score: Hans Zimmer

Universe: The Perfect Joseph Multiversal Saga

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PROLOGUE

THE BOYS: LAST STAND

(Four Years After the Fall of Vought)

EXT. TIMES SQUARE, NEW YORK CITY — DAWN — FOUR YEARS LATER

The city breathes differently now.

Manhattan in early February. Pre-dawn, the sky a bruised pewter, the kind of cold that has weight and intention. Steam from grates. The mechanical sigh of a garbage truck turning a corner three blocks north. The distant percussion of a sanitation crew hitting metal against concrete — the rhythm of a city doing what cities do in the hours before they have to perform themselves for anyone.

The billboard above 42nd Street: a VOUGHT AD once lived there. The license ran for eleven years. What's there now is nothing — not a replacement, not a different brand, not a sign. Just metal frame, rusting at the rivets, the mounting bolts still holding but the surface empty. The city can't agree what should go there instead. Every proposal triggers a public comment period. Every public comment period generates ten thousand responses and no consensus. The frame rusts. The empty space persists.

There's something in the emptiness that people feel without being able to name. A relief that has a sadness in it. The absence of Vought — its certainty, its colors, its performed invincibility — left a shape behind. You don't see the shape. You feel it, the way you feel a tooth that's been pulled. The place where something enormous was and no longer is.

CLOSE ON: The street below the billboard. Six-fifteen AM. A COFFEE CART fires its first shots of steam. The VENDOR, fifties, a man who's been doing this on this corner for eighteen years, pours without looking — muscle memory, his hands knowing the cup placement, the pour, the lid snap.

He's talking to himself about his daughter's recital. It's on Thursday. She's playing the cello. She was afraid she'd forget the fingering in the third movement, and he told her what his father told him about the third movement of anything, which is that by the time you reach it, your body knows it even when your head doesn't.

The world has decided to be ordinary. It has been working very hard at this for four years.

INT. BROOKLYN APARTMENT — HUGHIE'S KITCHEN — CONTINUOUS

Small apartment. The square footage of a man who lives alone and hasn't accumulated the things that rooms accumulate when someone else is in them. One mug on the drying rack. One plate. A single kitchen towel folded in thirds, hanging from the oven handle.

The apartment is clean in the way that reveals effort — not the careless cleanliness of someone who doesn't notice mess, but the deliberate cleanliness of someone who needs the external world to stay within certain parameters. Ordered surfaces. Stacked books with their spines aligned. A coffee maker that has been cleaned more recently than coffee makers typically get cleaned.

HUGHIE CAMPBELL (mid-30s now, the same jaw, the same slight frame, but different behind the eyes — the eyes of a man who has processed something enormous and arrived on the other side changed rather than broken, which is a different outcome than it sounds) stands at the window with a mug of coffee and watches the street below.

He is always watching the street. He doesn't know he does it. His therapist — he has a therapist, he got a therapist eighteen months ago and it's the second best decision he's made since 2019 — pointed it out in session four. He thought about it for a week. He told her she was right. He kept watching the street.

His phone on the counter. Seven unread texts from his father. He will read them. He always reads them. He replies within twenty-four hours, always, without exception. His father never mentions the delay because his father understands, now, what the delay means – it means the morning costs something to get through and Hughie is getting through it before he picks up the phone.

On the wall opposite the window: a framed photograph. Not posed. Taken at the kitchen table of the second safehouse, the one in Red Hook that smelled like mildew until Frenchie found the source behind the radiator. In the photo: Annie laughing at something off-frame, her whole face in it, not performed. MM with his reading glasses pushed up on his forehead. Kimiko mid-sign, hands in the motion, the blur of it. Frenchie caught with his eyes closed because he blinked at the wrong moment, and the blink looks exactly like him.

Butcher is in the photo. In the back. Half out of frame the way he always positioned himself in photos – present but sideways, committed but angled, always maintaining what looked like an exit that he never actually took.

Hughie looks at the photo for exactly three seconds. He's counted. He started counting somewhere around month six, without meaning to. The count stabilized at three. He doesn't know what happens if he looks longer. He hasn't tried.

He looks back at the street.

HUGHIE

(to himself, quiet)

Four years.

He finishes the coffee. He puts on his jacket – the gray one, the one Annie bought him for his birthday three years ago that she said looked serious without looking like he was trying to look serious. He has a nine AM meeting with

the Office of Supe Affairs. He has a nine AM meeting with the Office of Supe Affairs every Tuesday. He stopped hating it around month eight. Now it's just Tuesday.

INT. ANNIE JANUARY'S APARTMENT - SAME TIME

Larger apartment. Two mugs hanging by the sink — the second one has been there longer than Hughie has been staying here, because Annie is someone who prepares space before she knows what she's preparing it for. Two mugs, both used, one with a ring of this morning's tea inside it.

ANNIE JANUARY — STARLIGHT in another life, in a name that belongs to the years before, though she still occasionally catches herself almost-answering to it, the way you almost answer to a name that stopped fitting — sits cross-legged on the living room floor with a stack of funding proposals and a red pen and the specific, alert posture of someone whose mind is fully engaged with something that is also exhausting.

She marks a line. She marks a number. She turns a page. She drinks her tea without looking at the mug, the gesture automatic, the mind elsewhere and also completely here — the particular dual-presence of a person who has learned to operate in bureaucratic reality while maintaining a simultaneous awareness of the larger world the bureaucracy is supposed to serve.

The Supe Rehabilitation Initiative. Her project. Three and a half years in, two major funding battles, one Senate hearing where she spent four hours explaining why the word 'rehabilitation' did not presuppose wrongdoing, one restructuring, and a current operating budget that is 12% less than it was eighteen months ago due to a discretionary spending review that was not specifically targeted at her program and nonetheless specifically affected her program.

She reads. She marks. She drinks the tea. She has done this every morning for four years and the document changes and

the tea stays the same and the morning light hits the window at the same angle it always does and she is, beneath all of it, still here. Still doing this. The slower version of the fight. The version without a single dramatic moment. The version that accumulates.

INT. MARVIN'S HOUSE — QUEENS — DAWN

MARVIN 'MOTHER'S MILK' MILK (40s, his years in his shoulders but the shoulders steady — the earned steadiness, not the assumed kind, the kind that comes from deciding to be steady rather than from never having been tested) stands in the hallway outside his daughter's room.

He does this. Most mornings. Sometimes she's still sleeping and sometimes she's already up, but either way there's a moment — a hallway moment, before the day — where he stands here and just listens. The specific sound of a twelve-year-old sleeping: the deep, uncomplicated breathing of someone whose body is working hard at growing and doesn't worry about it.

Janine is twelve. She knows what her father did. Some of it. The version he's given her in pieces, calibrated to what she could hold at seven, what she could hold at nine, what she can hold now. The calibration is an ongoing project that he thinks about more than he discusses with anyone. His therapist helps. Monique helps, when she's willing to. Janine herself helps, which is the part that costs him the most — the way his daughter processes information he gives her in ways that are more sophisticated than he prepared for.

She asked him once, two years ago: Dad, were you a hero?

He said: I was on a team with some people who made choices I'm still thinking about.

She said: That sounds like a yes.

He didn't correct her. He looked at the ceiling for a moment and he didn't correct her and that was the best he could do that day and he thinks, most of the time, that it was enough.

INT. KIMIKO'S STUDIO APARTMENT — QUEENS — DAWN

The apartment of a woman who has learned that possessions are weight and has chosen which weight to carry. Spare. Clean lines. A punching bag in the corner with the wraps hanging from the hook beside it. Books in Japanese and English arranged without a visible system that is nonetheless a precise system — she could find any book in under four seconds without looking.

KIMIKO MIYASHIRO (30s, the stillness she carries now belonging entirely to her — chosen, not imposed; quiet, not silenced) sits at a small desk by the window. She is drawing. Not writing — she doesn't write for herself, she never has. Drawing is different. Drawing is the thing that started when she was very small and had no other language and which she never gave up because language, even when you have it, sometimes isn't the right tool.

The page: Frenchie. His face from memory — and this is the thing about memory when it's keeping something safe: the face is less precise than it was, the specific proportions slightly softened by time, edges that used to be sharp becoming approximate. But the expression is exact. The look he got when he found something beautiful in something nobody else had noticed. Slightly lifted eyebrows. A quality of attention that was almost reverence.

She draws the expression first. Then she builds the face around it.

She stops. She looks at the drawing for a long time. The morning light.

Then she turns the page. She starts again. A second version. Slightly different angle. The same expression.

THE BOYS: LAST STAND — FOUR YEARS AFTER VOUGHT

ACT ONE: THE WEIGHT OF AFTER

INT. OFFICE OF SUPE AFFAIRS — WASHINGTON D.C. — DAY

Government-gray building in the District. Fluorescent lights doing what fluorescent lights do in government-gray buildings, which is illuminate everything and flatter nothing. The specific smell of institutional carpeting and recycled air and coffee from a maker that needed descaling two months ago.

ANNIE sits across from COMMITTEE CHAIR HENDERSON (60s, a man who came up through intelligence, pivoted to policy, and has arrived at this specific moment in his career having developed the rare and professional skill of being genuinely sympathetic without being surprised by anything). Beside Annie: HUGHIE, a yellow legal pad in front of him, three lines of notes in his handwriting that he hasn't looked at since writing them.

Three other committee members. Recording devices. A pitcher of water with condensation on the outside and nobody has touched it since it was poured.

HENDERSON

The new V-derivative compounds. We're getting reports from six cities in the last eight weeks. Small-time operators – not Vought-scale infrastructure, not organized distribution – but the formula's recognizable. Our people used the word 'lineage.'

HUGHIE

Lineage.

HENDERSON

Like it's a family tree. The compound is descendant from Vought's base V. But modified. The modifications are consistent across all six cities, which means either one source or one blueprint.

ANNIE

Vought's dead. Neuman's dead. Homelander's been gone four years. So who's maintaining the tree?

Henderson slides a folder across the table. It contains a photograph – surveillance quality, taken at a distance, processed through three rounds of digital enhancement that have not helped as much as one would hope. A figure in shadow. What's identifiable: height. The particular set of shoulders. The absolute, deliberate stillness of a person who has decided that stillness is their primary strategic advantage.

Hughie opens the folder. He looks at the photograph. His face changes – not dramatically, not theatrically, but in the specific way that faces change when they recognize

something they hoped they wouldn't have to recognize. Very small. Just enough.

HUGHIE

(very quiet)

Where was this taken?

HENDERSON

That's where it gets complicated. The surveillance system that captured this image belongs to a dimensional monitoring station. Earth-adjacent. The kind of station that tracks movement between dimensional layers.

ANNIE

(very still)

He's not on our Earth.

HENDERSON

He hasn't been on our Earth. Not this one. For at least eighteen months based on our monitoring data. What he's been doing in the interim...

He sets his hands flat on the table.

HENDERSON

...we don't know. That's the part that keeps me up.

CUT TO:

INT. THE OUTER DARK — EPSTEIN'S DOMAIN — SIMULTANEOUS

The chandelier turns. It always turns — three rotations per minute, the prism catching the light from a source that has no obvious origin and distributing it across the mahogany and the crystal and the walls in fragments of refracted color that are beautiful and are also, if you look at them long enough, slightly wrong. Beautiful is useful in this room. Wrong is also useful.

JEFFREY EPSTEIN — rendered by Bill Skarsgård, unhurried, occupying his chair at the head of the table with the proprietorial ease of a man who has never experienced a space that didn't eventually arrange itself around him — holds his wine glass by the stem. He turns it a fraction. A fraction more. Not drinking. The glass is a prop he doesn't need for its stated purpose.

Across from him, at the far end of the table, a holographic projection. Not a clean projection — dimensional feeds are never clean, there's always interference from the layered reality between the source and the receiver — but recognizable. A man in a suit. The suit is the Homelander suit. But wrong. The colors too dark, as if whoever dressed this version understood the iconography but decided to remove the light from it and leave only the shape.

The voice that comes through has the wrong frequencies. Slightly compressed, like a signal that has traveled very far.

HOMELANDER VARIANT

(through the projection, voice distorted)

Six years. I've been patient for six
years.

EPSTEIN

(turning the glass, not looking up)

Six years isn't patience. Six years is waiting. The difference between the two isn't duration. It's understanding.

HOMELANDER VARIANT

Enlighten me.

Epstein sets the glass down. He places it precisely at the position it was before he picked it up. Then he looks at the projection for the first time in this conversation.

EPSTEIN

Patience is when you understand that the outcome you want requires conditions that don't yet exist, and you accept the time required to create those conditions not as a cost but as a component. Waiting is when you experience that same time as loss. One of those states produces good work. The other produces resentment.

(a beat)

EPSTEIN

I've been patient. You've been waiting. That's the difference between what I've built and what you've been experiencing. Tonight, the conditions become sufficient.

He stands. He moves to the side of the table — not toward the projection, not away from it. To a position he chose before this conversation began.

EPSTEIN

The compound is ready. The resurrection protocol is ready. The chamber is ready. I want you to understand something before I open the door, because once I open it I cannot close it and I will not.

(he looks at the projection)

EPSTEIN

What you want back is a version of him that was manageable. What we will get is something else entirely. Something that the original couldn't have been, because the original had limits that the compound will not. I spent eighteen months getting to this moment because I needed to understand what we'd be making before we made it. The understanding took that long. Are you following me?

HOMELANDER VARIANT

I understand. I want him back.

EPSTEIN

(quietly)

What you want and what we'll have are different things. I want you to know

that. I want you to know I know that.
And I want you to know I've made the
decision anyway, because the thing
we'll have is exactly what the next
phase of this requires.

He picks up the glass. He turns it once more.

EPSTEIN

Open the chamber.

CUT TO:

INT. EPSTEIN'S DOMAIN — THE RESURRECTION CHAMBER — NIGHT

A room that shouldn't exist but does. The way that a lot of things in Epstein's operation exist: quietly, deliberately, without announcement, because announcement is for people who need witnesses.

Walls of obsidian. Not metaphorically obsidian — actual volcanic glass, panels of it, fitted with the care of a craftsman who understood that the material absorbs light rather than reflects it. The room has no visible light sources but is lit, somehow, from somewhere within the surfaces themselves. It is the light of a room that has decided to be present.

In the center: the chamber. A structure that a person encountering it cold would struggle to categorize. Coffin-shaped but not coffin-sized — wider, taller, built for something more than storage. The material of its walls is a translucent composite whose specific composition is on no public record and is on only one private record which Epstein keeps in his head and nowhere else. The lid is sealed. The readouts on the surrounding equipment report:

INTERNAL PRESSURE — STABLE. COMPOUND INTEGRATION — 94%.
SECONDARY MATRIX — ACTIVE.

And then: SOURCE: OUTER DARK. DENSITY: UNMEASURED.

That last line gives the LEAD TECHNICIAN something in the vicinity of constant low-level distress, which he manages with the professionalism of a person who has learned that distress is something you process after the work is done.

THREE TECHNICIANS move around the chamber with the controlled efficiency of people who have run this simulation enough times that the physical procedure is routine. The bodies know the steps. It's what comes out at the end that keeps them quiet.

Epstein stands at the observation window. Watching.

LEAD TECHNICIAN

Compound integration at ninety-four
percent. Secondary matrix holding. Dark
compound saturation at—

(he hesitates, looking at his readout)

LEAD TECHNICIAN

Sir, the dark compound readings are
still climbing. We projected a ceiling
of—

EPSTEIN

(not looking away from the chamber)
I know what we projected.

LEAD TECHNICIAN

The projection was a safety parameter,
sir. If the saturation continues past—

EPSTEIN

(quiet, absolute, final)

Continue.

The technician continues.

The liquid in the chamber changes. Not a dramatic change — the kind of change that happens slowly and then is sudden, the way tides turn. The color deepens. The light-absorption of the obsidian walls responds to it, intensifying. The readouts climb past the projected ceiling as though the ceiling were a suggestion.

And then: something moves. In the chamber. A hand. The specific, purposeful movement of a hand that has decided to exist again. Fingers, pressing against the interior. Then the heel of the palm. Then the particular, measured force of a man deciding that surfaces which contain him should no longer contain him.

The chamber opens.

HOMELANDER rises from the liquid that is not quite liquid. His eyes are closed. The compound drips from him — the V1 base, the dark compound overlay, the thing that the outer dark contributed that the readouts couldn't name. It all drips from him. He stands.

He opens his eyes.

CLOSE ON THE EYES. This is where the difference lives — not in the jaw, not in the proportions, not in the hair or the stance. In the eyes. The same blue. But the quality of them is different from anything this face has ever expressed. Not empty. The opposite of empty. Too full. A quality of depth that has no horizon in it — the way deep water is

still not because there's nothing below but because what's below doesn't need to surface.

He looks at the ceiling of the chamber. He looks at it for a long time. He is learning the room. He is learning his body. He is learning what has changed and what hasn't.

Then he looks through the observation window at Epstein.

What passes between them across that glass is not gratitude. Not recognition in any warm sense. It is an assessment. The precise, unhurried look of a man at the thing that brought him back from somewhere he didn't choose to leave, making the calculation of what is owed and what the owing means.

HOMELANDER

(voice low, something new in its register
— a frequency below the frequency,
something the observation equipment picks
up as interference)
How long?

EPSTEIN

(through the intercom)
Four years, two months, eleven days.

Homelander processes this. He's very still. The specific, loaded stillness of someone adding up what four years means.

CLOSE ON his right hand, flat against the chamber wall. The wall — not fragile, not insubstantial, a material tested to withstand forces that most materials never encounter — begins to crack. Not from impact. He hasn't moved. From proximity. From whatever is inside him identifying the wall's structural weakness and noting it the way a thought notes something, without effort, without intention.

The crack spreads. Then stops. He didn't do anything. It stopped because he noticed it and noticed was enough.

Epstein, at the observation window, takes one step backward. It is involuntary. He controls his face completely — what's happening behind his face is not available to the room — but his feet move, one step, and the step is not calculated.

This is the only moment in the entire series in which Epstein's body betrays what his face does not.

HOMELANDER

(still looking at Epstein, measuring)

Good. Four years is long enough.

CUT TO:

ACT TWO: THE LAST AFTERNOON ON EARTH

EXT. NEW YORK CITY — MULTIPLE LOCATIONS — DAY

MONTAGE — the final four hours. Not tragic montage — the ordinary kind, which is worse:

CENTRAL PARK. February sun, thin but real. A DOG chases a frisbee with the absolute commitment of dogs — no strategy, no future, the entire universe compressed into the arc of the throw and the run toward it. A WOMAN reads on a bench, her scarf unwound so her face gets the sun. A MAN eats a sandwich methodically, watching pigeons with the attentiveness of someone who has nowhere else to be and has decided this is where he wants to not be. An adequate decision. The pigeons don't care. The sun comes and goes behind clouds that aren't threatening anything.

A FIRE ESCAPE IN BROOKLYN. Two teenagers. A BOY and a GIRL, both sixteen, both having a conversation that matters enormously to both of them and neither of them can say directly. The thing that happens at sixteen when the thing you feel is real but the words for it aren't quite there yet so you talk around it, both of you talking around it, and the talking around it is the conversation. The city below them. The street. Ordinary.

A BODEGA in Washington Heights. Radio playing cumbia. A CAT on the counter, positioned precisely between the register and the bags of plantain chips, refusing to move. The OWNER has been trying to relocate the cat for four years. The cat's opinion on this remains consistent. A CUSTOMER buys a coffee and pats the cat on the head and the cat tolerates it and the owner says sorry and the customer says no, it's fine, I like cats.

The city. Being the city. Doing what cities do. Which is: contain more human experience per square foot than any single mind can hold, and hold it, and go on.

INT. SUPE AFFAIRS OFFICE — CONFERENCE ROOM — AFTERNOON

Hughie has the photograph enlarged. Digital enhancement, three iterations. He's had it run through SHIELD's borrowed facial-recognition substrate — Fury gave them provisional access eighteen months ago and they've used it twice, this being the third time.

The result confirmed what everyone in the room already knew the moment they saw it.

MM sits at the corner of the conference table, arms crossed, weight in the crossing — the body language of a man doing the hard work of thinking with everything he has available to think with. His face is doing the MM thing, which is nothing visible and everything happening.

MM

(without preamble)

He was in the Cosmic Vault. I watched
them close the door. The lock engaged.
I was there.

HUGHIE

You watched them close a door. That's
not the same thing as watching him stay
behind it.

MM

(a warning in it)

Hughie.

HUGHIE

(not backing off, but not aggressive)

I'm not blaming you. I'm not saying
it's your fault. I'm saying that
watching a door close is what happened.
The assumption that what's behind a
door stays behind it is not the same as
watching it stay there. And now we have
a surveillance photograph of him
somewhere that has cameras, which means
he's somewhere.

ANNIE

We need to get this to Fury. The full
file. Today.

HUGHIE

(a beat, careful)

Fury's not on this Earth.

ANNIE

I know. I said we need to get it to him. Getting something to someone is not the same as it being easy.

MM unfolds his arms. He puts his hands on the table.

MM

How long do we have?

ANNIE

(looking at the photograph)

If the surveillance timestamp is accurate, this was taken six weeks ago. So whatever's already started has a six-week head start.

The room. The photograph. The specific quality of silence that attends the moment when people realize that the thing they've been trying to prevent has already begun.

EXT. EARTH'S ATMOSPHERE — HIGH ORBIT — SAME TIME

The QUINJET. Drifting at the boundary of what atmosphere means. Navigation lights doing their slow blink against the black of orbital space, a patient green pulse against the infinite dark.

Through the forward screen: Earth. The curve of the Eastern Seaboard visible from this altitude, the cloud systems over the Atlantic, the thin precise line where atmosphere becomes not-atmosphere. The planet from up here is the most

beautiful and most terrifying thing – beautiful because it's the only one, terrifying for the same reason.

BILLY BUTCHER – not dead, not exactly, not anymore, in the sense that 'not exactly dead' has become the relevant category for several people in his immediate circle – watches the planet through the forward screen. He has been watching it for six hours. He does this.

The Quinjet doesn't belong to him. It belongs to an Avengers emergency-response program that was formally dissolved three years ago and whose physical assets were folded into a SHIELD subdivision that doesn't officially appear on any organizational chart. He found it in a dimensional storage bay during an operation that he's never debriefed properly because the debrief would have required explaining a number of things he prefers not to explain to anyone with a title.

He uses the Quinjet as a place to think. He doesn't tell the team this. They know anyway.

He is drinking tea. Nobody who knew him before the four-year mark would believe this. He is drinking tea from a proper mug, watching Earth, trying to locate – for approximately the six-hundredth time – the specific internal change that allows a person to stop. Not stop moving. Stop the particular mode of forward-motion that is actually a form of flight. He hasn't found it yet. He suspects it requires something from him that he hasn't given.

He is thinking about this when the PROXIMITY ALARM fires.

A sound he hasn't heard outside of drills in two years. He is at the console before he finishes the recognition, the body moving on its own program.

He looks at the screen.

COMING FROM THE SURFACE: a contact. Moving upward. Speed: three thousand meters per second and accelerating. Fast – faster than anything that should be moving through

atmosphere without burning. The thermal signature of its transit is not the signature of combustion. It's a different kind of heat. A generated heat. A heat that comes from within rather than from friction.

A figure. In a cape. The wrong shade of red — darker than it should be, the exact shade wrong in a way that takes a second to locate and then can't be unlocated. The wrong proportions. The—

Butcher is at the navigation controls before the thought completes itself.

BUTCHER

(clipped, controlled, everything locked
down behind the voice)

No. No, no, no.

EXT. EARTH'S ATMOSPHERE — CONTINUOUS

HOMELANDER rises through the atmosphere. He's not flying. The distinction matters: flight implies direction, intent, destination — a vector, a point of arrival. What he's doing is rising. The way pressure rises. The way things rise when the container stops holding them.

Below him: New York City. The island of Manhattan from this altitude, surrounded by water, geometrically distinct, the grid of it visible from space. Central Park a rectangle of not-gray in the gray. The bridges threading across the water.

He rises past the cloud layer. He rises past the upper atmosphere. He hovers at the boundary.

He looks down.

CLOSE ON HIS EYES. Still. The deep-water stillness. No expression in the traditional sense — what's there instead

is something that has moved past expression into something older. The stillness of a thing that has spent a very long time in the dark and is now in the light and is assessing what the light means.

Four years in wherever Epstein kept him. Not in a facility, not in anything with walls in the traditional sense. In the outer dark. In the specific non-place of dimensional in-between, where time is not a constant and experience is not a standard sequence of events. He doesn't know what happened to him there. He knows it as a duration only because Epstein told him the duration.

He was not a man built for grief. He was not made for the experience of loss. He was made for need, and for the frustration of need, and for the specific response to frustrated need that nobody ever named correctly because naming it correctly would have required admitting what they had created.

He doesn't scream. He doesn't announce himself. He doesn't compose a speech.

He simply begins.

EXT. NEW YORK CITY — RAPID SEQUENCE — CONTINUOUS

It takes eleven minutes. Not because he moves slowly — he does not move slowly — but because he is not optimizing for efficiency. He is processing something that has no name and the processing looks, from the outside, like this:

AN OFFICE BUILDING ON AVENUE OF THE AMERICAS. The glass front. He doesn't touch it. He looks at it and it goes — the physics of it collapsing inward rather than outward, the glass not shattering but simply ceasing to be a surface, and the building behind it exposed like a cross-section in an architectural drawing. People running. He watches them run. There is nothing in his face while he watches. Not satisfaction. Not anger. Not pleasure.

Something that has moved past all of those into a register that doesn't have a name.

THE BROOKLYN BRIDGE. He lands on the main span. His weight on the bridge surface – the surface registers this and the surface deforms, the asphalt pressing down, the steel beneath it registering the load. He walks to the main cable. He puts his hands on it. The cable, which was designed to hold a weight orders of magnitude beyond what any object should have, responds to his hands the way cables respond when the force applied exceeds their design parameters. Not a dramatic failure. A precise one. The cable lets go of what it was doing.

The bridge holds – the redundant systems, the remaining cables, the structure's engineering taking over. But the span changes shape. The center drops. The city looks at it from the banks. People stop. People pull out phones. People don't know what they're seeing yet. They will in a moment.

THE STREET. He lands in the intersection at 34th and 7th. The street deforms – the pavement taking the impact of landing, the crater not deep but precise, his feet exactly where they are. He stands in the intersection. Around him: the city has begun to understand what's happening. The evacuation instinct kicking in, the movement away from rather than toward, the human knowledge that certain things require distance.

He stands in the intersection and looks at the city with the specific, exhausted attention of a man who has been waiting for something for a very long time and has finally arrived and doesn't quite know what to do with the arrival. Then: laser eyes. Wide aperture. Maximum.

Then all of it.

INT. QUINJET – HIGH ORBIT – CONTINUOUS

Butcher watches on the forward screen. Not with the distance the altitude provides – the sensors are close enough, the feeds detailed enough, that there is no distance. He sees it all. The thermal bloom spreading across Lower Manhattan. The communication feeds going dark by neighborhood, by district, then by borough, the infrastructure failing in a sequence that follows the thermal spread. The altitude that was supposed to be perspective becomes something else: a record. He is recording this.

KIMIKO appears in the hatch to the cabin. She's been here since this morning – she found the Quinjet three weeks ago, found Butcher in it, registered the information without commentary, and has been coming back periodically since because she made a calculation about where she wanted to be if something happened and this was the calculation.

She looks at the screen. She reads the readouts – she can read them now, three years of dealing with SHIELD tech. She looks at what the screen is saying.

She looks at Butcher.

He doesn't have to explain anything. She was there when it started. She was there for all of it.

BUTCHER

(very still, voice on rails)

Get MM. Get Hughie. Get Annie.

Whoever's closest to a roof or a clear
aerial approach. I'll hold the orbit.

She's already gone. He's already entering new coordinates.

EXT. EARTH – LOW ORBIT – TWENTY MINUTES LATER

The QUINJET, stationary. Below: the Eastern Seaboard. What is left of it. From this altitude, the thermal bloom is a visual fact – an area of orange and white against the dark of the November coast that has no natural analog. It looks like a new light source. It is one.

Inside: the whole team. Different arrival times, different routes, the same result – everyone here, in the Quinjet, in orbit. Hughie at the forward window with both hands on the frame. Annie in the co-pilot seat, her hands in her lap, the light in them not fired because there is nothing here to aim at from this distance and the measurement of that fact is one of the things she's currently processing. MM standing at the side wall, arms crossed, his face doing the precise nothing that is doing the most it can do in this moment. Kimiko by the hatch. Soldier Boy in the rear cabin, not welcome, present, because there was nowhere else to go and he knows it and isn't saying it.

And Butcher. At the controls. His hands on the navigation panel, not flying anywhere yet, just – having something to hold.

They watch through the forward screen as the thermal bloom expands. As the communications go dark. As the thing they spent four years rebuilding becomes, from this altitude, very small.

HUGHIE

(not a question, a fact)
He's not going to stop.

ANNIE

No.

MM

(trying the weight of it)

We can go back down. We have the
compound from Frenchie's batch. We
have—

BUTCHER

(quiet, not unkind)

And do what, Marvin. We go back down
and do what.

MM

Fight.

BUTCHER

(not dismissing it, just)

With what we have. Against that. How
many seconds does the fight last.

MM doesn't answer. The answer is on the screen.

Nobody says what they're all thinking because saying it is
the last step before it becomes a fact rather than a thing
they're considering. On the forward screen, the thermal
bloom expands. The Atlantic coastline is changing its
shape. That sentence is not a metaphor. The Atlantic
coastline, measurably, is changing its shape.

Annie says it. She is the one who says it. Her voice is
flat and certain and costs her something.

ANNIE

We can't go back down.

CLOSE ON MM's face. The specific expression of a man who
has organized his entire existence — every decision, every

sacrifice, every year, every morning in the hallway outside his daughter's room – around the principle that you go back in. That you don't stop. That the fight is the thing. Arriving at the moment where the principle meets something it can't resolve, and having to stand there.

He sits down. He puts his hands on his knees. He looks at the floor.

Outside, below, the Earth burns.

EXT. EARTH ATMOSPHERE – CONTINUOUS

HOMELANDER at the edge of the thermosphere. He has stopped. Not because he's finished. Because he has arrived somewhere inside himself that the activity doesn't reach – somewhere the motion of destruction doesn't penetrate, and being present to that place requires him to stop.

He looks down at the planet. The atmosphere from up here: thin, blue, a specific fragility visible in the way the light catches it – the edge of the atmosphere is a color that has no name and can only be seen from this altitude and it is the most beautiful thing in the solar system and it is very thin.

He has laser eyes that can reach the surface from here. He knows this. He tests the knowledge the way you test the weight of something before you pick it up.

He fires.

CLOSE ON HIS FACE while he does it. His expression is not rage. Not satisfaction. Not grief, not joy, not triumph. It is something that has no name in any language that was made for human experience. Something that might, if you observed it long enough, resolve into the specific emptiness of a thing that has done the thing it was made for and doesn't know what to do with having done it.

His voice, barely above a whisper:

HOMELANDER

(trembling — not with weakness, with the weight of it, with something that has been building since before he understood what it was building toward)
I have become... a God.

The final pulse.

From space it looks like a sunrise in reverse. Light drawn inward, the atmosphere displaced, the planet's surface rearranging itself the way water rearranges when you drop something heavy. The wave front moving outward from the impact zone at speeds that physics textbooks have a notation for.

On the Quinjet's forward screen, the image goes white.

Then black.

Hughie covers his eyes. He doesn't cover them to protect against the light — the light is manageable at this distance and the screen has filters. He covers them because this is one of those things a person should not have to see without doing something with their hands.

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. QUINJET — CONTINUOUS

Silence. The kind that comes after something enormous. Not the silence of absence — the absence is enormous, is everywhere, is the content of the next several years of all their lives. The silence of a system shutting down. The silence of everything that preceded this moment having just ended.

Nobody speaks for a very long time.

Butcher's hands on the navigation panel. He began the coordinate change before the pulse — operating on instinct, because instinct is the only thing faster than thought, and thought in this moment would have stopped him. The nav screen:

DESTINATION: EARTH-15600. DISTANCE: 847 DIMENSIONAL UNITS.
TRANSIT TIME: 11.3 HOURS.

He didn't ask anyone. He just began.

After a long time — a time that doesn't resolve into minutes in memory, that exists in memory as a single prolonged moment — MM speaks.

MM

(barely audible)
My daughter.

BUTCHER

(quiet, very quiet)
I know.

MM

She was in Queens, Billy. She was at school. She was—

BUTCHER

(jaw working, something behind his eyes)
I know.

Kimiko moves. She crosses the cabin without sound and sits beside MM. Not close — at a distance that says: I'm here.

Only that. Nothing else is being offered or implied. Just: I'm here, and I will be here, and that is the only thing I have to give right now.

It is enough.

Annie has her face turned away from the screen. She is breathing with great deliberateness – each breath a separate decision, a separate act of will. Each one taken. Each one succeeding.

Hughie reaches across the gap between their seats and takes her hand. She holds it. She doesn't turn back to look at the screen. She just holds his hand and breathes.

The Quinjet moves through dimensional space. Away from what was Earth. Toward whatever comes next.

"THE COLLECTORS"

A BOUTAHRI PRODUCTIONS MULTIVERSE EVENT

BLACKOUT.

EPISODE ONE

"THE SPACE BETWEEN"

(70 Minutes)

INT. QUINJET — DIMENSIONAL TRANSIT — DAY (TIME UNDEFINED)

The windows show dimensional space. Not stars — stars are a fixed-space phenomenon, specific to universes that have settled into their geometries. What the windows show is the seam between realities: light folded back on itself, color that exists at wavelengths the human eye wasn't designed to see and is seeing anyway, the visual experience of traveling through the architecture that contains all possible worlds.

Beautiful. In the way that places become beautiful when you have no other option than to look at them.

The team. Eleven hours in. Various configurations of stillness:

KIMIKO has claimed the starboard bench in a cross-legged posture that suggests she has been very still for a long time and that the stillness is not passivity but a form of work. Her eyes are open. She is watching the dimensional space through the port window without watching it — looking at a thing without seeing it, which is a different mode of attention, the mode of someone who has gone to a place inside themselves that is more useful right now than the external world.

HUGHIE is at the forward console trying to read something on a tablet and not reading it. The words are registering but not landing. He's read the same paragraph six times. He knows he's read it six times because he counted the attempts. He stops trying and puts the tablet down.

ANNIE sits upright in the co-pilot seat, her posture a maintained thing — she's been maintaining it for eleven

hours, because letting herself slump would feel like surrendering to something she's not ready to surrender to. Her light is quiet inside her. She can feel it, the way she always can – the electromagnetic warmth of it, just beneath the surface. She doesn't fire it. There's nothing to fire it at. The not-firing of it costs nothing and also costs everything.

HUGHIE
(to the window, to nobody)
Eleven hours.

ANNIE
Eleven hours, twenty-three minutes.

HUGHIE
Are you counting?

ANNIE
My internal clock is very accurate
since the upgrade.

A beat. Neither of them says anything else. The window does what it's doing with the dimensional light. They watch it.

INT. QUINJET – REAR CABIN – SAME TIME

BUTCHER, alone. He's been in the rear cabin for two hours. Nobody has knocked. They know when Butcher goes somewhere alone he's doing something specific with the alone, and interrupting it is not the thing.

He's sitting on the floor. Not dramatically — not slumped against the wall in the posture of despair that this moment would seem to require. Pragmatically, the way a person sits when their legs go and there's nothing to do about it and the floor is available. His back against the equipment locker. His legs in front of him.

In his hand: a bottle. Scotch, from the Quinjet's emergency supply kit, which he found two weeks ago and has been leaving in the kit since then. He has taken it out three times. He has not opened it once.

He holds it now. He looks at it. The label is a brand he knew in the years when he drank anything that was available, which was the years before he decided that available wasn't a sufficient criterion. He holds the bottle and he looks at it and he engages with the having of it without the opening of it.

Then he puts it in the overhead locker. He closes the locker. He sits back down on the floor without it.

This is the hardest thing we have seen Billy Butcher do. In a series that will contain a number of hard things.

INT. QUINJET — FORWARD CABIN — CONTINUOUS

MM is holding his phone. He has been holding his phone since they left the surface. There is no network. There is no signal. The phone is doing nothing. He knows it is doing nothing. But it has a photo on the lock screen. Janine, age eleven, at her school assembly, wearing the shirt she had been campaigning for for four months. The shirt has a graphic of a planet on it. She is pointing at the planet like she is introducing someone to a friend.

He holds the phone because the phone has her face on it. That is the entire reason.

SOLDIER BOY sits in the rear-most seat with the expression of a man who is at the wrong funeral — not unfamiliar with

funerals, not unhappy to be among humans, but profoundly aware that this particular collection of people has not chosen him and that he has not earned the right to their grief. He sits there with this awareness and doesn't try to do anything about it.

KIMIKO signs to nobody visible from where she's sitting. The signs are small, private. Then she stops. She looks at her hands.

INT. METH LAB / TRAILER — EARTH-2397 — DAY (PARALLEL)

CRASH CUT — different world. The specific, institutional-quality fluorescent of a portable laboratory inside a converted trailer. The smell of chemical solvents and careful work. Surfaces immaculate in the way that surfaces are immaculate when the person maintaining them is a professional and the professionalism is the only discipline keeping everything in order.

CLOSE ON: thick-framed reading glasses. Perched on a nose that belongs to a man whose relationship with his own face is one of professional detachment — he knows what it looks like, he has made no effort to manage that appearance, it is neither advantage nor disadvantage, it is the face he operates with.

WALTER WHITE (60s, post-Heisenberg in the sense that a man is always post the worst version of himself, even when the worst version was the version that made him extraordinary, even when he carries it with him the way water carries minerals — invisibly, until it doesn't) stands at his chemistry bench and does not look up when the trailer door opens.

He is finishing a reduction. A reduction requires attention. The door opening does not require attention. These are different categories. He has spent years sorting things into these categories and does not intend to reclassify them now.

JESSE

(from the door, apprehensive in the specific way of someone who has news they know the recipient won't like and is therefore delivering it at an angle)

Mr. White. We got a — there's a situation.

WALTER

(not looking up)

Jesse. I'm at a critical stage of the reduction. I need exactly four more minutes. Whatever the situation is, it will persist for four minutes.

JESSE

Yeah, I know, but the situation is kind of atmospheric. Like, literally atmospheric.

Walter takes off his glasses. He cleans them on his sleeve — the gesture that means something has qualified for his full attention and he is preparing to give it. He puts the glasses back on. He looks at Jesse.

Jesse's face tells him everything he needs to know about the category of situation.

He turns the burner down to hold and goes to the door.

EXT. TRAILER — CONTINUOUS

He steps outside into what should be New Mexico afternoon. Clear sky. Sun at the correct angle for the time of year.

The sky is the wrong color.

Not dramatically wrong – not purple, not green, not on fire. Wrong in a more disturbing and harder-to-describe way: slightly too red at the western horizon, the particular red of a sunset but occurring three hours before sunset. Slightly too flat in the zenith – the sky color too uniform, as if someone had applied it without reference to how sky colors actually distribute.

A photographed sky. Not a sky.

Walter looks at it for forty-five seconds. He is a man who looks at things for exactly as long as the looking requires. Forty-five seconds is what this requires.

Then he goes back inside. He turns the burner off. He goes to a different part of the trailer – a cabinet that is not part of the laboratory, that contains ordinary items, one of which is a phone he has never shown to Jesse and never mentioned. He takes the phone out. He dials from memory.

It rings twice.

WALTER

(into the phone, controlled, the specific vocal quality of a man choosing each word before releasing it)

It's me. I need to talk to you about the atmospheric anomaly. I'm assuming you've seen it. Yes. I'll be there in forty minutes.

He hangs up. He looks at Jesse, who is looking at him the way Jesse has always looked at him when the secret phone comes out.

WALTER

Mind the reduction. Do not touch the temperature controls. Do not open the secondary valve. Do not have a conversation with anyone about anything while you're doing it.

JESSE

I can literally just watch a thing—

WALTER

(already putting on his jacket)
Jesse.

JESSE

Yeah?

WALTER

Watch the reduction.

He goes. Jesse watches him go. He looks at the reduction. He looks at the sky through the window. He looks at the reduction again.

JESSE

(to the reduction)
Okay. You and me.

CUT TO:

INT. QUINJET — DAY — CONTINUOUS

The navigation ping — a sound different from the alarm, lower, informational rather than urgent. They're approaching. The dimensional transit is almost complete.

Butcher has come forward from the rear cabin. He doesn't explain where he's been. Nobody asks. He stands at the forward console and looks at the approaching screen and his face does what it does, which is not much that's visible and a great deal that isn't.

BUTCHER

(to nobody in particular, to the screen,
to the fact of it)

Right, then.

CLOSE ON THE QUINJET SCREEN: EARTH-15600. Orbital scan. Blue and white and brown. The proportions slightly different from their Earth — the ice caps marginally smaller, a different cloud pattern over the Pacific — but recognizable. A planet. Alive. Its atmosphere: clean. No thermal bloom. No wrong colors.

A world going about its Tuesday.

The team assembles at the forward windows. Nobody announces it. No one says come and look. But bodies drift forward, one by one, until all of them are here. Kimiko from the bench. MM, phone still in hand. Annie from the co-pilot seat. Soldier Boy, uncertain, standing at the back of the cluster because the back is the only position available to him.

They look at the planet. This planet that is not their planet. This intact thing, below them, not knowing what is coming toward it from dimensional space and not needing to yet.

HUGHIE presses his palm flat against the forward screen. Not dramatically. Not as a statement. Just — contact with a

surface. Something to press against. Something solid that pushes back.

The planet holds the light below them. Behind them, the dimensional space they came through. Between the two: whatever they do next.

They go down.

ACT TWO: EARTH-15600

INT. QUINJET — ATMOSPHERIC ENTRY — CONTINUOUS

Re-entry. The Quinjet was calibrated for their Earth's atmospheric density — Earth-15600's is marginally different, and the difference is enough to matter. The entry angle is wrong. Butcher corrects. Corrects again. The Quinjet shakes with the kind of authority that makes you question everything attached to the wall.

MM

(gripping his seat)
Butcher.

BUTCHER

I see it.

MM

What are you seeing?

BUTCHER

I'm seeing the problem. I'm also
correcting it. Both things are
happening simultaneously.

The shaking intensifies. Through the window: cloud layer.
Then below the cloud layer: the Eastern Seaboard of a
different United States, lit by mid-morning sun, intact.

SHIELD HARBOR SECURITY DRONES catch them immediately. The
formation is standard – delta, five craft, the S.H.I.E.L.D.
insignia rendered in that particular shade of blue that
every person who has ever dealt with SHIELD can identify
from a distance.

HARBOR CONTROL

(over comms, professional, unimpressed)
Unregistered Quinjet variant entering
Earth-15600 airspace. We're tracking
you on approach. Transmit credentials
and stated purpose immediately. Non-
compliance will be interpreted as
hostile approach.

BUTCHER

(finding the right channel on the third
try)
Yeah. Hi. Listen. We've come a very
long way and under unusual
circumstances and I'd prefer to do this
without anyone firing anything at
anyone, so I'm going to transmit an old
code and I need you to take it to
whoever's in charge. Not whoever
handles unauthorized entry – whoever's
actually in charge.

HARBOR CONTROL

We don't process verbal requests
without—

BUTCHER

I know. Transmitting now.

He transmits. A code from seventeen years ago. A SHIELD priority channel from a protocol called WINTER GARDEN that was formally dissolved when the organization it served was restructured in the wake of something nobody officially described at the time.

A code that should not exist. In any system. On any record. The kind of code that lives only in the memories of people who were in certain rooms during certain conversations.

Pause. Longer than standard processing. Then a second pause, longer than the first.

Then a different voice. Quieter. From somewhere that is not harbor security.

NICK FURY

(over comm, the voice of a man who has been waiting for something — not this, but something — and is in the process of recalibrating what something means)

I'm going to need you to land that thing very carefully, Mr. Butcher. And then I'm going to need a complete debrief. Starting with the question of where your Earth is.

BUTCHER

(after a beat, the beat of a man deciding what to say to an old ally he hasn't spoken to in years, across a dimensional divide)

That's the debrief.

Silence on the channel.

Then Fury, quieter:

FURY

Bay Seven. Security will stand down.

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — BAY SEVEN — CONTINUOUS

The landing bay: vast, purpose-built, the architecture of an organization that constructs for durability rather than impression. Composite floors. Equipment racks with the labels faded from use, not time. Ceiling high enough that large aircraft feel addressed rather than contained.

AGENTS at a careful distance — six of them, positioned at the perimeter, hands not on weapons, professional posture that communicates readiness without menace. The distinction between the two is something SHIELD trains for.

NICK FURY stands at the bay entrance. Eyepatch. Long coat. The absolute stillness of a man who has had enough practice with the arrival of catastrophic information that the information itself no longer changes his posture. He reads faces. He's reading the ramp.

The Quinjet settles. Not gracefully — the entry angle has thrown off the calibration, and the landing compensates for a drift that's been accumulating for the last forty minutes, so the final touch is not so much a landing as an emphatic decision to stop moving. But it stops.

The ramp extends.

BUTCHER first. Then KIMIKO. Then MM, the phone finally in his pocket, his hands free. Then ANNIE and HUGHIE together, close enough that their arms are almost touching. Then, last, SOLDIER BOY, in the specific posture of a man attending an event he was not invited to and is now attempting to occupy as little space as possible.

Fury looks at all of them. He reads what he sees in the time it takes them to walk from the ramp to where he's standing. This takes approximately twelve seconds. Fury uses all twelve.

He looks at Butcher.

FURY

(not a greeting, an acknowledgment – the distinction is the difference between a door opening and a door already being open)

You got out.

BUTCHER

Most of us.

The weight of that. Fury processes it. He looks at the group again. He counts what's there and doesn't count what isn't.

FURY

Come inside.

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY – BRIEFING ROOM – LATER

Real coffee. Fury's first instruction when they entered – not a briefing order, not a protocol, but: make the coffee real. Someone went to get it. It arrived. Fury made a point of the coffee in the way that a man who doesn't do gestures makes a point of a gesture: it is both itself and a statement.

The statement: I understand what you've been through. The coffee is the only acknowledgment this conversation will have time for, but it's here.

MM has the phone on the table in front of him. He's stopped looking at it. Left it there.

Fury at the head of the table. Standing. He doesn't sit at briefings unless he's chosen to.

FURY

Give it to me in five sentences.

BUTCHER

Epstein resurrected Homelander with a compound we'd never seen before. The new version has no power ceiling that we could detect. He took the planet apart in forty minutes. We got out. That's five.

FURY

(a pause that is recalibration rather than hesitation)

What do you mean by 'no power ceiling'?

ANNIE

I mean I put everything I have into a barrier in the upper atmosphere. Full output. The most I can generate. He went through it like it wasn't there. It didn't register as a cost. He didn't slow down for it.

Fury looks at her. For a long time. This is not the look of a man who doubts her — this is the look of a man updating his model of the world to include a data point that changes what the model can project.

FURY

(quietly, to himself first, then to the room)

Homelander at theoretical maximum, with an outer-dark compound amplification. Compounded.

BUTCHER

That's our read.

FURY

There's one thing that can track a power signature at that level across dimensional space. It will find us eventually, and probably sooner than we'd prefer.

HUGHIE

What thing?

Fury pauses. Just long enough.

FURY

Thanos.

The word in the room. A word with specific mass.

Soldier Boy, from the corner of the room where he's been determinedly occupying the least significant space available:

SOLDIER BOY

(flat)

Who is Thanos?

HUGHIE

(closing his eyes briefly)

Oh God.

MM

Cosmic-level threat. Infinity Gauntlet.
He snapped half of all living things
out of existence.

SOLDIER BOY

He did what.

MM

Snapped. Half of everything. Then it
got reversed. But the point is—

SOLDIER BOY

He snapped his fingers and half of
everything—

BUTCHER

(cutting through)

The point is we have bigger problems
than we came here with. Which is saying
something.

Fury looks at the group. At the individual costs written in
each face. At the specific quality of people who have been
through something and have not yet had time to process it
because the something immediately produced a next thing.

FURY

Get some sleep. Real sleep. We brief
again in six hours.

(he looks at Butcher)

FURY

I have quarters ready. I had them ready
three days ago.

BUTCHER

(after a beat)

You knew we were coming.

FURY

I knew something was coming. I set
aside the possibility it was you.

He goes out. The room. The coffee. The team, in the strange, suspended quality of people who have landed somewhere that is not their destination but is, for now, the only place there is.

ACT THREE: THE FIRST NIGHT

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — MM'S QUARTERS — NIGHT

MM sits on the bed. The room is standard facility — functional, clean, neutral. The bed has been made with SHIELD's habitual precision. He hasn't gotten under the covers. He's sitting on top of them.

He picks up his phone. There's a connection here — the facility has a network. The phone, for the first time in eleven hours, has a signal.

He holds it. He looks at Janine's picture on the lock screen. He tries to calculate the probability that she was not in New York today. She had a field trip coming up. He can't remember if it was this week. He can't remember if her school was in session. He can't—

He puts the phone face-down on the nightstand.

He can't call until he knows. He can't not call until he knows.

He lies back on the bed, still dressed, and looks at the ceiling, and waits for morning.

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — ANNIE & HUGHIE'S QUARTERS — SAME TIME

Larger than the single rooms — Fury's read of the situation, what they've been to each other, the practical logic of two people in one room rather than two people alone in two rooms.

Hughie is at the window. Annie on the bed, seated, her shoes off, her feet pulled up. Neither of them is sleeping.

HUGHIE

(to the window)

My dad texted me seven times this morning.

ANNIE

I know.

HUGHIE

(a beat)

He was in Scotland. For my uncle's thing. He was going to be gone all week.

Annie closes her eyes. She holds this for a moment.

ANNIE

(very quiet)

Scotland is fine.

HUGHIE

Yeah.

Silence.

HUGHIE

Annie.

ANNIE

Yeah.

HUGHIE

The barrier you put up. In the
atmosphere.

ANNIE

(before he finishes)
It didn't work. I know.

HUGHIE

You held it for nine minutes at maximum
output. That's—

ANNIE

It wasn't enough.

HUGHIE

I know. But it was nine minutes. You
gave nine minutes of yourself to every
single person on that planet.

She opens her eyes. She looks at the ceiling.

ANNIE

(after a long time)

I should have given them more.

HUGHIE

You gave everything you had.

ANNIE

(not argument, just fact)

It wasn't enough.

He comes away from the window. He sits beside her on the bed. He doesn't argue with her. He just sits next to her in the not-enough and lets it be the thing they're both sitting next to.

After a while she lies down. He lies down beside her. The lights dim on their own — facility program.

He looks at the ceiling in the dark. She does too.

Eventually, one of them is asleep. Then the other.

FADE TO:

EXT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — PERIMETER — 3 AM

BUTCHER walks the perimeter. He's been doing this for two hours. Not security patrol — he's not checking for vulnerabilities, not running assessments. Just moving. His body doing something so his mind can do something else.

The facility perimeter: a chain-link fence with monitoring equipment, a cleared zone, the specific quality of a secured space in the middle of the night. Cold. The kind of

cold that has been cold all day and has settled into the ground and the air and the surfaces. He walks in it.

He thinks about the planet. He thinks about what forty minutes means. He thinks about all the specific, particular humans who were in those forty minutes – all the people who were at whatever their Tuesday morning equivalent was, the coffee, the hallway, the phone call they were about to make. The full accumulation of them.

He doesn't cry. He doesn't have access to that at the moment. What he has access to is the walking and the cold and the specific, ongoing project of not opening the bottle that is in the overhead locker on the Quinjet.

He walks.

He thinks: we're going to fix this. We're going to find a way. That's what comes next.

The thought has the quality of a decision made in the absence of information. He knows that. He makes it anyway.

He turns the corner of the perimeter. The facility lights from the southeast. The sky above. Not quite the right stars.

He keeps walking.

END OF EPISODE ONE

EPISODE TWO

"EARTH-15600"

(75 Minutes)

ACT ONE: THE LAY OF THE LAND

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — CAFETERIA — MORNING

Day two. The team navigates the facility breakfast with the specific etiquette of people who are guests in a place that is also a workplace — aware of systems they haven't learned yet, careful not to occupy territory with too much confidence.

MM eats standing up, at the counter by the window, watching the activity in the facility's main yard through the glass. He has spent the last four hours — since 3 AM, since the moment his phone told him there was a connection available — trying to reach Monique. No answer. He left a voicemail that took him four attempts to record. He has not called Janine directly because he needs to know something before he knows what to say to Janine.

KIMIKO is the only one who seems to have slept. She moves through the cafeteria with the easy orientation of someone who assessed the space thoroughly last night and has filed the information. She gets food. She sits. She eats. She watches the SHIELD agents who are watching her.

KIMIKO

(signing to Frenchie, who is not here; she signs anyway, the way some people talk to themselves)

CLOSE ON HER HANDS: THE COFFEE IS TERRIBLE. SORRY IN ADVANCE.

FRENCHIE is not here. The signing is private, a habit, a form of thinking in a language that belongs to the two of them.

She eats the terrible coffee anyway.

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — FURY'S OFFICE — MORNING

Fury's office: organized in the specific way of a man who works from this desk regularly and whose organization is functional rather than aesthetic. Files. Screens. A single photograph on the desk facing him — not visible to anyone sitting across from him, which is a deliberate choice about what belongs to him.

BUTCHER sits across from the desk. Fury sits behind it. Between them: the file on the outer-dark compound. The real file — not the sanitized version that would go to a committee.

FURY

We've been tracking the outer-dark compound through dimensional monitors for eight months. Not the source — the signature. Every time it's used at scale, it leaves a resonance in the dimensional barrier. Like a sound that doesn't stop.

BUTCHER

Eight months. You've known about the compound for eight months.

FURY

(evenly)

I've known about a compound. The specifics of what Epstein built — what he did to Homelander — that's new information. I knew the outer-dark material was moving. I didn't know it was being weaponized at this scale.

BUTCHER

Could have warned us. On our Earth.

FURY

(a beat — not defensive, just accurate)

I tried. Three times in the last six months. The dimensional communication arrays on your Earth had been compromised. Messages weren't getting through. We traced it back to — we traced it back to Epstein's network. The communication disruption was deliberate. He didn't want you warned.

Butcher absorbs this.

BUTCHER

He disabled our ability to receive warnings.

FURY

And then he did the thing he didn't want you warned about. In that order.

Butcher looks at the file. He looks at the compound diagrams. He looks at the readouts from the dimensional monitors.

BUTCHER

Can it be countered?

FURY

That's the question I've had our people on for the last week. The short answer is: possibly. The honest answer is: not by anyone we currently have.

BUTCHER

(a beat)

But someone you don't currently have.

FURY

(looking at him)

There's a chemist on Earth-2397. Our dimensional monitors flagged his work six weeks ago — not because he's a threat, because his work is extraordinary. He's been running an independent operation. What he's done with organic compound synthesis is—

BUTCHER

Who is it?

FURY
(a very specific pause)
His name is Walter White.

Butcher looks at the file for a moment.

BUTCHER
That's the meth cook.

FURY
That's the most extraordinary organic
chemist I've encountered in thirty
years of working with people who do
extraordinary things. The meth is a
sideline.

BUTCHER
(drily)
It's a notable sideline.

FURY
It is. And it's not relevant to whether
he can give us a counter-compound.
What's relevant is whether he's
willing. And whether we can find the
leverage.

BUTCHER
(looking at the file again)
What's his motivation?

FURY

His atmosphere is wrong. His sky is the wrong color. He's already made the connection between the dimensional disruption and Homelander's activity – he's too smart not to. He doesn't have the full picture, but he's working with what he has.

BUTCHER

(standing)

Meaning he's already motivated.

FURY

We go to him tomorrow. I want you in the room when we talk to him. You read people.

BUTCHER

(at the door)

I read a particular kind of people.
He's a particular kind of people.

FURY

That's why I want you there.

ACT TWO: THE NIGHT BEFORE THE THANOS QUESTION

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY – RESEARCH WING – NIGHT

ANNIE has found a workspace. Not assigned – she found an available room and set up in it, because having a place to

work is the thing that makes a space habitable for her, and habitable is necessary.

She is drafting a dimensional communications protocol. Not because anyone asked her to — because the problem that Fury described, the communication arrays being compromised, is a problem she can look at technically while the emotional weight of the last forty-eight hours finds whatever level it's going to find.

She works for two hours.

HUGHIE appears in the doorway.

HUGHIE

I found a thing.

ANNIE

(not looking up)

What kind of thing?

HUGHIE

A good thing. Or at least a not-bad thing. I was going through the facility directory and this Earth has a version of our communications network that's not compromised. If we use the SHIELD relay and the right dimensional frequency—

He puts a tablet on her desk. She looks at it.

ANNIE

(quietly)

You found a way to reach our Earth.

HUGHIE

I found a way to receive a signal from
whatever is still broadcasting on our
Earth. I don't know what's
broadcasting. But something might be.

She looks at the tablet. She looks at him.

ANNIE

That's—

HUGHIE

It might not be anything. The carrier
might be automated. Maintenance
broadcasts, emergency systems that are
still running on power reserves.

ANNIE

(already pulling up the frequency data)
Or it might be something.

HUGHIE

It might be something.

They work. They set up the receiver array. The facility's
equipment is calibrated for dimensional monitoring but not
optimized for this specific frequency. They spend two hours
adapting it.

At the end of two hours: signal. Faint. Fragmented. Coming from the dimensional coordinates of their Earth.

A carrier wave. Not a voice, not a message — just the evidence of a signal source. Something, on what was their planet, still broadcasting. Still putting out a signal into dimensional space.

CLOSE ON ANNIE'S FACE. She stares at the readout. She stares at the number confirming the frequency, the coordinate, the fact of it.

ANNIE

(very quiet)
Something's still there.

HUGHIE

(looking at the readout)
Something's still there.

They look at the readout. The signal pulses. Weak. Persistent.

CUT TO:

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — BRIEFING ROOM — THE NEXT MORNING

The full team. The Thanos briefing. Fury at the front, a dimensional map projected behind him, the power signature tracking data marked in amber dots across multiple Earth-coordinates.

FURY

Thanos's primary interest in this dimensional cluster is power acquisition and cataloguing. He becomes aware of extraordinary power signatures automatically — his sensory range at full capacity extends across approximately forty Earth-equivalents. Homelander's current power level is registering across that entire range.

SOLDIER BOY

So he'll come here.

FURY

He'll come here eventually. The question is whether he comes as a threat or as something we can work with.

BUTCHER

Work with. You're suggesting we work with Thanos.

FURY

I'm suggesting I've worked with Thanos before, under specific conditions. He's not a simple threat. He has a logic. The logic is flawed and has resulted in catastrophic outcomes, but it's a logic. Logic can be engaged with.

MM

(not convinced)

He snapped half of everything out of existence.

FURY

And we brought it back. And in the interim I had seventeen conversations with him and learned more about how he thinks than I have about most strategic threats I've encountered. I'm not endorsing his worldview. I'm saying: he can be a factor in our favor if we approach this correctly.

Annie raises her hand. Not a school-hand – a specific, directional gesture.

ANNIE

I found a signal from our Earth last night. Something's still there. Something is broadcasting a carrier wave.

The room.

FURY

(very still)
What kind of signal?

ANNIE

A dimensional anchor signal. Automated, maybe. Or something with enough power to maintain a broadcast through what happened. I don't know which yet.

FURY

(slowly)

A dimensional anchor. That would mean—

ANNIE

It means something is still holding a fixed point in dimensional space where our Earth was. Something created a structure robust enough to survive what Homelander did.

The room processes this.

HUGHIE

Is that our Earth surviving? Like, is there an Earth to go back to?

FURY

(measured, careful)

It means there's a location to go back to. What's there is what we're going to need to find out.

END OF EPISODE TWO

EPISODE THREE

"HEISENBERG IN THE MULTIVERSE"

(75 Minutes)

ACT ONE: THE CHEMIST

INT. WALTER WHITE'S TRAILER LAB — EARTH-2397 — DAY

The lab as Walter's laboratory: immaculate. Not sterile-immaculate — the immaculateness of controlled use, where every mark on every surface has a reason and no surface has any mark without a reason. Three monitors running compound analysis simultaneously. The outer-dark V-derivative sample that SHIELD couriered over — sealed, labeled, approached with the care Walter gives to things that interest him and the things that interest him have a way of being significant.

He looks at the sample the way he looks at most things that interest him: the way a chess player looks at a position they haven't fully mapped yet but can feel the architecture of.

JESSE sits in the corner on an overturned crate. He has eaten a breakfast burrito from the truck that parks on the access road. He is watching Walter. He has been watching Walter for seventeen years, on and off, with varying degrees of attention and clarity and sobriety. He knows most of Walter's expressions. The current one — the one where the reading glasses are slightly lower on his nose and his focus is inward more than outward — this is the expression that means Walter is about to say something that sounds like it's describing a problem but is actually already the solution.

JESSE

(carefully)

So. You're looking at the stuff.

WALTER

(not looking up)

I'm analyzing the compound. Yes. That's what I'm doing.

JESSE

And what's it — what are we seeing?

WALTER

(a pause for the word to be precise)

We're seeing something that should not be chemically possible. Which means that one of the laws I've been operating under is wrong, or that the compound was produced under conditions that those laws don't account for. I'm working out which.

JESSE

Based on the like, vibes—

WALTER

(finally looking up)

Jesse. There are no vibes in chemistry.

JESSE

Based on your face—

WALTER

Based on the molecular analysis. The outer-dark material is operating as a resonance amplifier. It's taking the base Compound V signal — which is already broadcasting at a frequency beyond what human biology should be capable of — and multiplying it by a factor that I don't have a label for yet. The compound V host is essentially receiving a signal that should be inaccessible at any power level human technology has been able to produce.

JESSE

Okay. So the signal.

WALTER

Is being transmitted through a material from outside observable physics. Which is why the laws I've been using are insufficient. Yes.

JESSE

(after a moment)

Can you counter it?

Walter takes off his glasses. He cleans them on his sleeve. He puts them back on. He looks at Jesse.

WALTER

In theory: yes. What the amplifier is doing can be undone by a frequency that cancels the resonance. You're not

disrupting the power — you're
disrupting the connection between the
outer-dark material and the biological
receiver. Like cutting a wire rather
than removing the engine.

JESSE

(getting it)
So it's possible.

WALTER

It's theoretically possible.
Practically: it would require six weeks
of development time, equipment I
currently don't have access to, and a
test subject willing to participate
knowing that there's a meaningful
probability of the process being lethal
to them.

JESSE

(a beat)
So you can do it.

Walter stares at him.

WALTER

That is not what I said.

JESSE

It's what you said in long form.

Walter looks at Jesse for a moment longer. Then he looks back at the compound.

WALTER

Get me Nick Fury's direct line.

JESSE

I don't have Nick Fury's direct line.

WALTER

Find it.

JESSE

(standing, already calculating)

How am I supposed to find Nick Fury's-

WALTER

(already back to the monitors)

Jesse. You tracked a cartel chemist across three states using only a physical description and a bar napkin. You have a talent for finding specific humans. Use it.

ACT TWO: THE MEETING

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — FURY'S OFFICE — LATER

Walter White sits across from Nick Fury and places a single sheet of paper on the desk. The paper contains a molecular

diagram in Walter's handwriting – cramped, precise, annotated in a personal notation system that is partly IUPAC chemistry and partly something Walter developed during the operation that nobody else uses or can read.

BUTCHER stands at the wall. Not sitting – he assessed the room when he entered and chose the wall. His function in this meeting is to read Walter, and you read people better from a position that isn't participatory.

FURY

(looking at the diagram)

What am I looking at?

WALTER

A counter-resonance compound.

Theoretical at this stage. Applicable to the power signature you've been tracking with a confidence interval of seventy-eight percent based on current modeling.

FURY

Seventy-eight percent isn't a hundred percent.

WALTER

No. And I want to be transparent with you about why, because I've found that people in positions of authority frequently prefer a false hundred percent, and I don't provide those.

Fury looks at him. Waiting.

WALTER

The outer-dark component is operating outside any chemistry I've encountered in my career, which has included things I would prefer not to enumerate in this context. I'm modeling it from observed effects rather than from first principles, because I don't have access to the first principles. The seventy-eight percent reflects the limit of what observation without direct source analysis can tell me. It might be higher. It might be lower. Seventy-eight is the honest number.

FURY

(a long beat)

What do you need to improve it?

WALTER

Time. Equipment. And access to the full dimensional monitoring archive — specifically the atmospheric resonance data from the last eighteen months. There may be residual signatures in the barrier data that would give me the frequency I need.

FURY

You'll have all three.

WALTER

The timeline is six weeks if I have what I need. Five if the archive contains what I think it might.

FURY

We'll need to buy time with what we currently have while you work.

WALTER

The compound the French chemist has been developing – Frenchie?

FURY

Yes.

WALTER

It targets the wrong mechanism. He's disrupting the power output. I want to disrupt the resonance that generates the amplification. The distinction is significant – it's the difference between hitting the amplifier and getting between the amplifier and the source. Frenchie's compound is the hammer. What I'm building is the key.

Fury looks at the diagram. He looks at Walter.

FURY

Mr. White. I read your file.

WALTER

(not turning)

I assumed.

FURY

The full file. Not the sanitized
version.

WALTER

(after a beat)

There is no sanitized version of my
file, Mr. Fury. What happened happened
in full view of anyone who was paying
attention.

FURY

I want you to know: what you did, what
you became — I've worked with worse men
for lesser reasons. And the chemistry
produced results.

A long pause. Walter at the door. Something happens in his
posture — not visible precisely, but present.

WALTER

(quiet, without the usual armor — just for
a second, just because it's the honest
thing)

That is not actually comforting.

FURY

No. But it's true.

WALTER

(a very long pause)

Yes. That's exactly the problem with
it.

He goes out.

Fury and Butcher look at the door.

BUTCHER

He'll do the work.

FURY

I know. What was your read?

BUTCHER

He's not working for us. He's working
against the compound because the
compound offends him professionally.
We'll get what we need out of that.
Just don't try to manage him.

FURY

(a slight smile)

Duly noted.

ACT THREE: THE DEEP DIMENSION

**INT. ATLANTIAN DIMENSION — THE DEEP'S COURT — DAY —
INTERCUT**

THE DEEP (Kevin Moskowitz, without the helmet, because the helmet doesn't fit in the low-ceilinged antechamber and also because he has decided that ruling without the helmet suggests a certain casual mastery) sits on what he has designated as a throne. Prior to his arrival, it was a decorative shell approximately four feet tall. He has added cushions.

He is wearing robes. The robes came from a dimensional trade arrangement he doesn't fully understand the terms of, involving the exchange of three recipes he claimed were 'ocean cuisine' (they were mostly things involving sea salt) and the rights to a phrase he made up that the other party, inexplicably, found culturally significant.

His AIDE — a human named Gregory who arrived here through a genuinely complicated series of dimensional accidents and has decided this is where his life is now — approaches.

AIDE

Sir. S.H.I.E.L.D. is attempting to establish contact through the dimensional relay. They say it's urgent. They say it's about Homelander.

The word. Even here. Even in this dimension with its cushioned shell and its robes.

Something moves through the Deep's face that is under all the trappings — something real, something specific, something that has his actual name on it. He is not as large as he made himself in the Seven. He knows this. He has known it for a long time. What he does with the knowing is the ongoing project.

DEEP

(quietly)

How urgent is urgent?

AIDE

They said: everyone.

The Deep looks at his court. His dimension. His shell-throne and his robes and the three dolphins who have followed him here and whom he has designated as an Official Honor Guard despite their general indifference to the designation.

DEEP

(to the nearest dolphin)

I'm going to need a few days.

The dolphin makes a sound that conveys complete disinterest in this information.

DEEP

(to the aide)

Tell them I'll be there in four hours.
And ask if they have access to
saltwater.

AIDE

They're a land facility, sir.

DEEP

(with the specific resignation of a man
who has been accommodating insufficiently

aquatic environments for his entire professional life)

Fine. I'll manage.

He takes off the robes. Underneath: a very nice fleece vest. He has been wearing the fleece under the robes this entire time.

He goes.

ACT FOUR: RYAN

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — PERIMETER — NIGHT

Butcher alone outside. The night. The wrong stars. His comm.

FURY

(over comm)

I have information about Ryan.

Butcher goes very still.

BUTCHER

Where is he.

FURY

Safe house. Earth-3311. He was with the emergency relay team when it happened. He got out.

A pause.

BUTCHER

He saw it.

FURY

(carefully)

He saw all of it. He's alive, Billy.
He's physically unharmed. He's not —
he's carrying it.

BUTCHER

(quietly)

He's alive.

FURY

He's alive.

BUTCHER

(after a very long pause)

Bring him here when it's safe to move
him.

FURY

You sure?

BUTCHER

(without hesitation)

Yeah.

He ends the comm. He puts the device in his pocket. He stands outside in the wrong-starred night for a very long time.

He is still alive. He is still alive.

Butcher says nothing. Does nothing. Just stands there with this information for a while, the way you stand with something enormous before you're ready to carry it inside.

END OF EPISODE THREE

EPISODE FOUR

"THE DEEP END"

(75 Minutes – Finale Cliffhanger)

ACT ONE: THREE WEEKS IN

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY – RESEARCH WING – NIGHT

Three weeks. The team has found a rhythm – not peace, which would require resolution, but rhythm, which only requires repetition. Butcher reads compound files. Kimiko runs drills in the facility gym that the SHIELD trainers observe with professional respect and personal alarm. MM has reached Monique. Janine is alive. He had that phone call in corridor B, standing with his back against the wall, his voice not quite holding, and he has not spoken about it to anyone. He didn't need to.

FURY has given them access. Real access – not supervised, not monitored in any way they can detect, not the guarded kind. The kind that means he read each file, thought about each person, and made a specific decision about what each one could be trusted with.

This is, for Fury, equivalent to several different categories of compliment.

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. CONTAINMENT BLOCK – LEVEL 7 – SAME TIME

The door. SHIELD containment doors are engineered to specific tolerances. Level 7 is maximum security – not for threats to the facility, but for threats to the dimensional stability around the facility. The door has no handle on

one side. The door was not designed to be opened from the inside.

The ALERT LIGHT above the door: green. Has been green, without interruption, since the facility was commissioned.

CLOSE ON the light. It flickers. Once. Holds green. Flickers again. Longer this time.

A GUARD at his station twenty meters down the corridor notices. He watches. He reaches slowly for his comm.

The light goes red.

The door — which has no handle on one side — opens from the inside.

A hand on the door frame. A hand wearing a ring on the index finger. White-gold. The ring is engraved with Nordic runes. Containment protocol required the ring be returned to her rather than confiscated; it's not a weapon, and she had made a very specific legal argument about cultural artifacts that the facility counsel had agreed with.

STORMFRONT steps into the corridor.

She is wearing the standard containment suit — gray, functional, the deliberate uniformity of a system that doesn't want its subjects expressing individual preference. Her hair is different from how it was. Standard procedure. Her face is different from how it was — years do that, containment does that, and she has processed whatever containment does to a person in her own private way.

Her eyes are exactly the same. The specific, focused, unhurried certainty of a woman who has been waiting for a long time and is now beginning to move.

GUARD

(hand moving toward weapon, voice controlled)

Stand down. Hands where I can—

STORMFRONT

(not aggressive — almost gentle, the gentleness of someone who has thought about this moment and decided on its tone)

I'm not going to hurt you. I want to be clear about that. I've watched your rotation for seven months. You've been consistently professional and you've treated me with appropriate respect. I remember things like that.

The radio on the guard's hip: static. Then silence. The static is not interference — it's the specific, deliberate absence of a frequency that was there a moment ago.

From down the corridor: sounds. Not the alarm — the alarm should be going. The alarm is not going. The sounds are doors. Doors opening. In the direction of the maintenance corridor.

She looks at the guard with something that is not quite pity and not quite warmth but contains elements of both in the proportions of someone who is sorry about the necessity of a situation while being entirely unsorry about her decision.

She walks. Not runs. Walks. Down the corridor, toward the sounds of opening doors.

At the end of the corridor: a figure. New to this story, familiar in a way that is immediately uncomfortable.

DR. EVIL stands in the corridor with the composed theatricality of a man who has been planning an exit for six months and wants to experience the exit properly. His suit is immaculate. His expression is one of genuine ceremony.

DR. EVIL

(with the tone of someone marking a significant occasion)

Welcome back to the board, Ms. Stormfront.

STORMFRONT

(walking past him)

Don't call me that. It's a name they gave me. I have my own name.

DR. EVIL

(following)

Of course. My apologies.

STORMFRONT

(not stopping)

And don't apologize for things you're not sorry for.

DR. EVIL

(a beat)

Also fair.

She walks toward the exit. He follows, adjusting his suit jacket, which had gotten slightly displaced.

ACT TWO: THE DISCOVERY

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — FURY'S OFFICE — CONTINUOUS

The security board alert comes in. Fury picks up the comm.
He listens for four seconds. He sets it down.

He looks out his window — the facility yard, the night, the
perimeter lights. He looks at it for a long time.

FURY

(very quiet, to himself, to the particular
frustration of a universe that keeps doing
what universes do)

Of course she did.

He picks up the comm again.

FURY

Lock down the perimeter. Alert Butcher.
Get me the footage from the last six
hours.

He stands. He goes to the window. He looks at the perimeter
fence.

Somewhere out there, in the dark, she's already gone.

**INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — BUTCHER'S QUARTERS —
CONTINUOUS**

Butcher's comm goes. He is awake — he is always awake at
this hour, this is not exceptional. He reads the message.
He sits up.

He looks at the wall for a moment. Then he gets dressed.

ACT THREE: THE DEBRIEF

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — WAR ROOM — LATER

The team, assembled, looking at the footage. The corridor.
The door opening. Stormfront stepping out.

And Dr. Evil.

MM

(staring at the screen)

Is that—

FURY

Dr. Evil. From the Austin Powers
dimensional cluster.

SOLDIER BOY

That's a real person?

FURY

(even)

Every dimension has its version of the
same archetypes. The Austin Powers
cluster had several. Dr. Evil is — the
comedy dimension framing is
unfortunate, and I understand why
people laugh, but he's not funny in any
practical sense. He's a competent
organizer with access to resources and
a genuine personal commitment to large-
scale destabilization.

HUGHIE

He and Stormfront.

FURY

Were apparently in contact for months before the escape. We're reviewing how. The short answer is she's smarter than our containment anticipated. The long answer is going to take us a week to fully reconstruct.

BUTCHER

Where are they going?

FURY

That's the question. Based on what we know of Dr. Evil's operational history: toward something. Toward a specific objective. He doesn't move without an objective.

ANNIE

And Stormfront. She has an objective too. She's always had objectives.

NATASHA

(from the doorway — she has appeared without announcement, which is her standard method of arriving at things)
Her objectives have historically been consistent with the ideology she's been committed to for the better part of a century. She'll be looking for a structure. A way to build something.

Everyone looks at Natasha.

FURY

(without surprise — he knew she'd show up)
Everyone, this is Natasha Romanoff.
She's been tracking Stormfront's
operational network for three years.

NATASHA

(to the room)
She's not the threat. She's the
resource. Whatever Dr. Evil is
building, she's the force behind it. He
organizes. She leads. The question is:
who are they building it for?

The room. The footage frozen on the screen. Stormfront and
Dr. Evil walking through the gap in the perimeter fence
into the dark.

BUTCHER

(reading something in the geometry of it)
They're not going to Homelander. He's
not the type to work under someone
else's roof.

NATASHA

No. They're going to Epstein.

SMASH CUT TO:

END OF EPISODE FOUR

EPISODE FIVE

"THE DEAD COME BACK WHEN THEY WANT TO"

(75 Minutes)

ACT ONE: 3 AM

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — BUTCHER'S QUARTERS — 3 AM

Butcher not sleeping. His baseline. The chair by the window rather than the bed — the specific choice of someone who has stopped pretending sleep is coming and has accepted that tonight is just more time to be awake in.

The tablet. The outer-dark compound files, which he's been through three times now and has started annotating in the handwriting he developed at fifteen to keep his father out of his journals. The handwriting has not changed in thirty years. He never saw any reason to change it once it worked.

The annotations are: questions. Page after page of questions. Some of them chemical — things he wants to ask Walter. Some of them tactical. Some of them things that start as tactical questions and drift, on the page, into something else. What is the compound doing to him. What does four years in the outer dark do to a person. What was there, in that place, that the dark compound has absorbed and amplified.

He writes: Is there still a person in there.

He looks at the question. Then he writes: Does it matter.

He looks at that for a long time.

A knock on the door. Not the SHIELD knock — shorter, lighter. He knows the rhythm of it.

BUTCHER

(flat)
Yeah.

Door opens. Kimiko. In the doorway.

She signs. Three signs.

CLOSE ON HER HANDS: COME. NOW. IMPORTANT.

He's up before he's thought it through. Kimiko doesn't use important unless she means important in the way that changes things.

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — MEDICAL BAY — CONTINUOUS

Medical bay: bright, clinical, three monitors running. THREE AGENTS at a careful perimeter distance with the posture of people who have been told not to interfere and are finding it very difficult.

On the bed.

A man.

He is connected to the monitors. Vitals present. Unusual — the biological markers reading at ranges the equipment doesn't have standard labels for, because the equipment was calibrated for human baseline and this is human baseline plus something that the equipment is registering as noise but isn't.

His face.

CLOSE ON HIS FACE.

Kimiko's drawing. The one from memory — the face less precise than the photograph, the edges slightly softened, but the expression exactly right. The look of a man who has found something beautiful in something nobody else was looking at.

His eyes are open. He is looking at the ceiling. Then his eyes move.

To Kimiko.

FRENCHIE.

His mouth starts to form something – a greeting, a joke, the beginning of something characteristically French and characteristically Frenchie – and then it stops, because Kimiko has crossed the room, and she is standing here, and the joke is not the right thing.

They look at each other. Very close. She does not sign. He does not speak. There is a conversation happening in the space between their faces that has been happening for years in the form of absence, and now it is happening in the form of presence, and the language it's in doesn't need to be translated.

Butcher, in the doorway. He watches.

He puts one hand against the door frame. He presses it there, hard. Same gesture as the medical bay a year ago, as the night of the Quinjet. The gesture he does instead of falling apart.

FURY

(quietly, from directly behind Butcher,
who did not hear him come)

He walked in from the east perimeter.
Two hours ago. On foot. No dimensional
signature – nothing we can track. He
went directly to medical. He lay down
on a bed. He waited.

BUTCHER

(not turning around)
How?

FURY

That's the question we're working on.
He has a dimensional residue that our
sensors can't categorize. He's been
somewhere. Whatever that somewhere was,
it sent him here.

BUTCHER

Has he said anything?

FURY

One thing. Before Kimiko arrived.
Before we'd told him she was here.

BUTCHER

What?

FURY

Tell her I'm fine.

Butcher absorbs this. He looks at Frenchie across the room. Frenchie is not looking at him — his attention is entirely with Kimiko, which is where his attention will be for some time.

Butcher looks at this for a moment. This thing: someone returning. Someone who shouldn't be here and is.

He turns away. He walks down the corridor. Not to his quarters — to the cafeteria. He makes tea. He sits by the cafeteria window. He drinks the tea.

He gives himself thirty seconds of something he doesn't name.

Then he drinks the rest of the tea and goes back to the outer-dark files.

ACT TWO: WHERE DID FRENCHIE GO

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — MEDICAL BAY — LATER

FRENCHIE, sitting up in bed now, a mug of something warm in his hands. Kimiko beside him. The agents have retreated to professional distance. The room is quieter.

MM is here. He came twenty minutes after Butcher, because the news traveled the way it travels — not announced, just known. He stands at the foot of the bed with his arms crossed. His face doing the thing.

MM

(measured)

Where were you?

FRENCHIE

(considering how to say it)

Somewhere. Between things. I don't have— there's no word for it that I know, and my vocabulary is very good. It was between. And things happened while I was there. And then I was here.

MM

Were you alive? While you were there?

FRENCHIE

(a beat)

I was present. Whether that's the same thing — I don't know. I had continuity. I knew who I was. I could think. I could feel. I was—

He stops. He looks at his hands. Then at Kimiko.

FRENCHIE

I was trying to get back. The whole time. I was trying to find the direction of back and go in it. And eventually I found it.

MM

(quietly)

And you came here. Not somewhere else. Here.

FRENCHIE

(with a small smile, tired but genuine)

I knew where Kimiko would be. I followed that.

MM looks at him. He uncrosses his arms. He nods, once, the nod of a man whose processing has arrived at an accommodation with an impossible fact.

MM

I'm glad you're here, man.

FRENCHIE

So am I. The coffee here is terrible,
but I'm glad.

MM

(a ghost of a smile)
Yeah. The coffee is terrible.

ACT THREE: THE STORMFRONT THREAD

EXT. EARTH-2397 — RURAL SAFE HOUSE — NIGHT

STORMFRONT and DR. EVIL in a location that is not a facility and not a headquarters and is therefore not visible to SHIELD's monitoring systems. A farmhouse. Genuinely rural — three hours from the nearest city, no visible landmarks, the kind of location you find when you've had six months to plan finding it.

A table. Maps. Not digital — physical maps, the old ones, the ones that don't leave digital traces. Dr. Evil is a man who believes in analog when the stakes are high.

STORMFRONT

(looking at the maps)
Epstein's timeline.

DR. EVIL

He wants the counter-compound research disrupted. He's tolerating the SHIELD

effort to develop it because he needs to know how close they can get. Once they have a meaningful success, he'll want it removed. Before they achieve delivery capability.

STORMFRONT

Why not disrupt it now?

DR. EVIL

He needs to understand what they've built before he removes it. Information first, then action. It's how he works.

She studies the map. She studies the SHIELD facility location. She studies the dimensional approach vectors.

STORMFRONT

And our role?

DR. EVIL

To be available when he's ready to use us. And to build something of our own in the interim. Not for Epstein. For the aftermath.

STORMFRONT

(looking up at him)

The aftermath of what?

DR. EVIL

(precisely)

Of whatever Epstein's designed. He's
designed the crisis and the resolution
and what comes after the resolution. We
need to be positioned for what comes
after what comes after.

She looks at him for a long moment. He meets her eyes. He
is telling the truth. She can tell.

STORMFRONT

He doesn't know you're planning for
after.

DR. EVIL

He thinks he's planned for everything.
Nobody plans for everything. Even
Epstein.

She looks at the maps again. Something settles in her face
— not quite a decision, but the precursor to one. The space
before committing.

STORMFRONT

Tell me what you're building.

He sits down. He begins to talk. She listens.

The farmhouse quiet around them. The night outside.

END OF EPISODE FIVE

EPISODE SIX

"THE TACTICAL"

(75 Minutes)

ACT ONE: THE WAR ROOM

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — WAR ROOM — WEEK FIVE — DAY

The war room has been lived in. Maps on every surface — not decorative, not organizational, genuinely worked-over maps with handwritten notations in four different hands. Trajectory projections for Homelander's dimensional movement, updated every forty-eight hours. The compound progress charts on the east wall, color-coded by Walter's instruction and nobody else's. Coffee rings on the table that SHIELD's cleaning staff have been asked not to remove.

Around the table: BUTCHER, FURY, CLINT BARTON (who arrived on day twenty via a method he hasn't fully explained and Fury hasn't pushed on, because some things are better not documented), ANNIE, MM, NATASHA, WALTER WHITE standing at the corner because he thinks better when he can move, FRENCHIE at the far end with his compound tablet.

The specific quality of a room full of people who are all very good at one thing and are trying to coordinate their very different things into a single direction.

FURY

Homelander's pattern over the past three weeks: he's moved through forty-seven dimensional coordinates. He's not destroying. He's cataloguing. Every location he visits, he leaves behind a

power signature — like he's marking territory. The signature is the outer-dark compound's resonance, broadcasting at a frequency our sensors can track.

CLINT

(leaning back in his chair)

Marking what? Who's in each location?

FURY

Powered individuals. Across all forty-seven visited dimensions, we've cross-referenced the locations with known powered-individual registrations. Every single one has at least one Class-4 or above resident. He's building a list.

ANNIE

Of people to eliminate.

FURY

That's our read. Based on what he did in the twelve hours before your Earth. He spent those twelve hours locating every powered individual he could find. Then he acted.

MM

(slow)

He's preparing a multiverse-scale move. Not one Earth. All of them.

FURY

Best current analysis: he's planning simultaneous action across six to eight dimensions. The outer-dark amplification gives him the range. He just needs the map.

NATASHA

How far along is the map?

FURY

Forty-seven of an estimated two hundred target locations. At current pace, he completes the map in four to five weeks.

The room takes that in. Four to five weeks.

BUTCHER

We get ahead of the catalogue. He's identifying what he wants to remove, so we find those locations before he finalizes his list. We pull the powered individuals out. We make the list useless.

FURY

That's a significant operation. It requires—

BUTCHER

More people than we have. I know. I have a list.

CLINT
(to Butcher, carefully)
Is Maeve on it?

BUTCHER
She's on it.

CLINT
She's been off-grid eighteen months.
Elena, I mean. She's been—

BUTCHER
I know where off-grid is for her. I'll
be back in forty-eight hours.

He picks up his jacket from the back of the chair.

FURY
(to the room, as Butcher goes)
While he's gone: Walter, I need the
compound update. Frenchie, the delivery
mechanism assessment. Natasha,
Stormfront's projected operational
timeline.

NATASHA
I'll need access to the dimensional
transit archive for the past six
months.

FURY

You'll have it by noon.

ACT TWO: MAEVE

INT. QUEEN MAEVE'S APARTMENT — EARTH-7742 — NIGHT

The apartment of a woman who has made specific choices about what she keeps. Not minimal from aesthetics — minimal from intention. Plants, real ones, requiring attention and alive. Books that have been read, not displayed. A television receiving three channels, one of which plays old films on rotation. The kind of quiet that has been actively cultivated.

QUEEN MAEVE — ELENA, in the name she uses here, in the name that belongs to the woman and not the brand — opens the door wearing someone's old gray sweater, holding a coffee mug with both hands, and looking at Butcher the way she looks at anything that has arrived without being invited: with the specific measuring patience of a woman who has learned not to react before she understands.

MAEVE

You found me.

BUTCHER

I find things. I've got a situation.

MAEVE

(not moving to let him in yet)
You always have a situation.

BUTCHER

This one's larger.

She studies his face. She's gotten very good at faces since she stopped managing her own. When you're not performing, you start reading.

She opens the door wider. He comes in.

The apartment around him: the plants, the books, the particular domesticity of someone who built this from scratch, specifically, out of intention. He looks at it. She watches him look.

MAEVE

Don't.

BUTCHER

Don't what?

MAEVE

The thing where you observe my apartment as if it means something you're going to use in your sales pitch. Just ask what you came to ask.

A pause. He sits across from her.

BUTCHER

Epstein resurrected Homelander with an outer-dark compound. New version. No ceiling on the power. He destroyed our Earth. We're on Earth-15600 with Fury,

building a counter-compound with Walter White.

(a beat)

BUTCHER

We need someone who's gone up against Homelander at full power and come out the other side. You're the only one.

Maeve holds her coffee. She looks at the window. She looks at the view: an ordinary street on an Earth that doesn't have Homelander. The kind of morning she has had for eighteen months and has been learning to let be enough.

MAEVE

I didn't come out the other side. I went in and got broken and what you're looking at is what broke pieces look like when they've been sitting quietly for a while.

BUTCHER

(not disputing this)

You went in. You knew what you were going into and you went in. That's not a small thing.

MAEVE

(after a moment)

If I come back. Does it change anything? Tactically — does having me there change what's possible?

BUTCHER

You're the only person alive who's been close enough to him at that level to understand how he moves when he's at full capacity. Not in theory. In practice. That changes everything about delivery range.

MAEVE

(quietly)

How many doses does the compound have?

BUTCHER

When Walter's done? Eleven. Maybe twelve.

MAEVE

And you need someone who can get within effective range how many times?

BUTCHER

Four. Four doses from close range. That's the model.

She sets down her coffee. She looks at the room. She looks at the life she built here – the plants, the specific light, the three-channel television – and she does the thing that is the hardest thing, which is knowing that you're about to leave something and looking at it fully before you do.

MAEVE

Two conditions.

BUTCHER

Name them.

MAEVE

My name. My actual name. Not Maeve. Not Queen Maeve. Elena, in every official context.

BUTCHER

Done.

MAEVE

And when this is finished — if we finish it — I come back here. No debrief cycle, no operational extension. I come back to this apartment and this life and nobody tries to turn me into a resource again.

BUTCHER

(without hesitation)

Done. Both.

She looks at him. She reads his face one more time.

She stands. She goes to a cabinet. She takes out a duffel bag — already packed. She has had it packed for three months. Not because she knew he was coming. Because she knew something was coming and she had learned not to be unprepared for something.

MAEVE
(shouldering the bag)
When do we leave?

ACT THREE: KIMIKO AND ANNIE

INT. OUTPOST — KIMIKO'S ROOM — NIGHT

Annie knocks. She waits — the duration of a considered wait, long enough to be respectful, not so long as to be a decision on Kimiko's behalf. The door opens.

Kimiko steps back. Invitation without words, which is sufficient.

Annie comes in. She sits on the floor. Kimiko sits across from her. The drawing desk between them, the current page not quite visible.

ANNIE
I wanted to check in. Not officially.
Not the team-leader version. I just—

Kimiko waits. She's good at waiting.

ANNIE
Episode Eight. The fight. You got
inside his response window three times.
I didn't say anything at debrief
because the debrief was tactical and I
was managing nine things and I—

She stops. She tries again.

ANNIE

I should have said thank you. Right there, in the room, in front of everyone. I didn't, and I'm saying it now. Thank you.

Kimiko looks at her. Then she signs.

CLOSE ON HER HANDS: FRENCHIE SAYS THE SAME THING ABOUT YOU.

ANNIE

(surprised)
About what?

Kimiko signs: YOUR BARRIER. THE ATMOSPHERE. HE SAYS:
WITHOUT THAT, THE ANCHOR NEVER HOLDS LONG ENOUGH. YOU MADE
IT POSSIBLE.

Annie goes still.

ANNIE

I didn't know I was doing that. I thought I was just — trying to stop him.

Kimiko signs: MOST OF THE IMPORTANT THINGS WORK LIKE THAT.

Annie looks at the drawing on the desk. She can see it now — it's her. In the atmospheric barrier. The light rendered

in Kimiko's lines as something both massive and specific, recognizable even in abstraction.

ANNIE

(very quiet)
Is that me?

Kimiko signs: IT'S WHAT HELD.

Annie holds this. She holds the drawing and what it means and what Kimiko is saying with it. Then she nods — the nod of someone who has received something they didn't know they needed.

ANNIE

Good night, Kimiko.

Kimiko raises a hand. Her version of good night, which contains the same warmth different words would.

Annie goes. Kimiko turns to a new page. She draws Annie again — the barrier, the light, the thing that held. She draws what it cost and what it accomplished.

She draws the space between trying and doing, which is also the space where the important things live.

END OF EPISODE SIX

EPISODE SEVEN

"THE ONES WE CARRY"

(75 Minutes)

ACT ONE: BECCA

INT. OUTPOST — BECCA'S ROOM — NIGHT

The room Butcher set up three weeks ago. A bed, a desk, a window. He set it up in an afternoon. He hasn't said anything about it to the team and the team hasn't said anything about it to him. This is one of the understandings that doesn't require language.

BECCA BUTCHER sits on the bed. She has been here four days. She is not dead in this continuity — the dimensional disruption that destroyed one Earth also cracked the barriers between others, and Fury's long-range monitoring found her in a dimensional corridor that existed between what was and what is. She came here not because Butcher asked her to. Because she has always known where she needs to be when things get serious.

Butcher sits in the chair by the door. The distance between the chair and the bed is the distance of a man who is learning — slowly, with effort, against his own instincts — how to be in a room with someone without filling all the space.

This is conversation seven. Each one has been longer than the one before.

BECCA

(looking at her hands)

Ryan's coming tomorrow.

BUTCHER

Yeah.

BECCA

How is he?

BUTCHER

(a pause that is the length of honest)
Not good. He watched everything. The whole thing. He was on a monitoring relay when it happened and he couldn't — there was nothing he could do and he watched it anyway.

BECCA

Like you.

BUTCHER

(a beat)
Not like me. I chose to be there. He didn't choose anything. He was just — there, when it happened.

BECCA

(gently)
People don't usually choose what they carry, Billy.

He doesn't answer. He looks at the floor. He has been working on the practice of not answering when the right answer isn't available to him yet.

BECCA

He'll want to fight. When he gets here.
He'll want to be part of it.

BUTCHER

I know.

BECCA

Will you let him?

BUTCHER

(a long pause — thinking it through
genuinely, not preparing a position)
He's not a child anymore. He hasn't
been a child since—

BECCA

He's still—

BUTCHER

He's still him. I know who he is. And
because I know who he is, I can't make
that decision for him. I tried to
protect him from choices once. I
thought that was the right thing. It
wasn't the right thing. It was the
thing I needed to do for me.

Becca looks at him. She looks at him the way she has always looked at him: seeing the thing underneath the version he's presenting, which is a skill she has had since the beginning and which is part of why being seen by her has always been both the thing he needs and the thing he can't entirely stand.

BECCA

(after a moment)

You've gotten better at knowing the difference.

BUTCHER

What difference?

BECCA

Between the thing that's right and the thing you need. You used to pretend they were the same thing. You're not pretending as much anymore.

He almost smiles. Something close to it.

BUTCHER

(dry)

That's not exactly what I'd put on a card.

BECCA

(the ghost of a smile back)

No. It's the other kind of compliment. The real kind.

ACT TWO: RYAN ARRIVES

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — LANDING BAY — THE NEXT DAY

A transport from Earth-3311. Small. Unmarked. The kind of craft that exists in the part of SHIELD's operational catalog that doesn't appear in the catalog.

The team has been told. Fury told them, not Butcher, because Butcher made one request before this: let me be in the bay when he lands. Alone.

The others have respected this. MM is in the cafeteria. Kimiko and Frenchie are in the gym. Annie and Hughie are in the research wing. Soldier Boy is — somewhere. Being Soldier Boy, which has its own geography.

Butcher in the bay. Alone.

The transport settles. The ramp extends.

RYAN BUTCHER comes down the ramp. Seventeen now. He grew — it happened in the past year, the sudden growth that surprises everyone including the person doing it, new height he hasn't entirely settled into, clothes that fit a month ago and don't quite fit now. He's wearing a jacket that belonged to someone he knew on Earth-3311. It's a little big.

He sees Butcher. He stops on the ramp.

Twelve feet of landing bay between them. Everything that has happened.

Butcher doesn't move. He waits. He lets Ryan decide what the twelve feet mean and what to do about it.

Ryan comes down the rest of the ramp. He walks across the twelve feet. He stops in front of Butcher.

He doesn't say what he prepared to say. He doesn't use the words he had — the ones he'd been working on since Earth-3311, the things he was going to say because they were true and they needed saying. He puts his arms around Butcher instead.

Butcher stands there for a second — the second of a man whose body is processing something his defenses are behind on. Then he puts his arms around Ryan. He holds on.

They stand like this in the landing bay for a while. The specific, unrepeatable weight of it.

Then Ryan, muffled:

RYAN

She's here?

BUTCHER

Yeah.

RYAN

(pulling back, looking at him — checking the claim, making sure)

She's actually here. She's okay.

BUTCHER

She's okay. She's up the corridor, second door on the left. She knows you're here.

Ryan closes his eyes. Opens them.

RYAN

Okay.

He goes. Butcher watches him go – the particular walk of a seventeen-year-old who has spent a week holding something enormous and is now, in this corridor, twenty meters from the thing that can absorb some of the weight.

FRENCHIE appears from somewhere. He has the talent of being nearby without being intrusive.

FRENCHIE

(quietly)

He looks like you. Around the eyes.

BUTCHER

(looking down the corridor)

God help him.

FRENCHIE

(a small smile)

Around the eyes, I said. The eyes are good.

Butcher looks at the corridor where Ryan went. The door at the end of it, already opening.

BUTCHER

(very quietly)

Yeah. He does.

ACT THREE: SOLDIER BOY AND BECCA – THE FISH

INT. OUTPOST — COMMON ROOM — 3 AM

The common room at three in the morning belongs to whoever can't sleep, which is usually one person because insomnia is a private experience. Tonight: SOLDIER BOY, on the couch, watching television. This Earth's television. A nature program about deep-sea biology. He has been watching it for two hours with total, uncomplicatedly genuine attention.

He is not pretending to watch it. He is watching it. The deep-sea fish are interesting. They have never done anything to him.

BECCA comes in. She is getting water. She sees Soldier Boy. She considers the room.

She gets her water.

SOLDIER BOY

(without looking from the screen)

You don't have to leave.

She pauses. She looks at the screen. A bioluminescent fish at two thousand meters, its light generated from within.

BECCA

(deciding to stay — the decision of a woman who has been through enough to know that the things we avoid are usually the things we should look at)

I know.

SOLDIER BOY

(gesturing at the screen)

They found a new species. Two thousand meters down. Never seen light that came from outside. So it makes its own. Been doing it a long time, apparently.

BECCA

(looking at the screen)

Bioluminescence.

SOLDIER BOY

They evolved in the dark. Grew their own light instead of looking for one.

A pause. The fish, on the screen, emitting its cold blue light in two thousand meters of black water.

BECCA

(sitting on the far end of the couch)

That's something.

SOLDIER BOY

Yeah.

They watch for a while. The fish does what it does. The deep pressure around it doesn't change what it is.

SOLDIER BOY

(very quietly, not looking at her)

I know I don't belong here. With them.
I know what I've done. I'm not under
any — I'm not confused about it.

BECCA

(a beat)
But you're here.

SOLDIER BOY

That's not the same as belonging here.

BECCA

No. But it's a start. Belonging usually
starts with just being somewhere long
enough to matter to people. Before the
feeling arrives.

SOLDIER BOY

(a very long pause)
I've been told I'm not naturally good
at things that require considering
other people.

BECCA

(bone-dry)
I can see that.

Something moves across his face. Not quite a smile. The
territory that used to be where smiles were, before that
territory got covered over.

They watch the fish glow in the dark. The deep water. The
pressure. The light.

BECCA
(eventually, standing)
Get some sleep.

She goes. He doesn't say anything. He watches the program for another hour. When he finally goes to his room, he falls asleep faster than he has in weeks. He doesn't examine why.

END OF EPISODE SEVEN

EPISODE EIGHT

"WAR OF THE WOMEN"

(75 Minutes)

ACT ONE: THE RAIN

EXT. EARTH-2397 – CITY RUINS – NIGHT

Four weeks after the team's arrival on this Earth. The city carries its damage the way cities carry damage – not dramatically, not obviously, but present in every surface, every façade with its wrong angles and its missing pieces, every street where the pavement has been repaired with different-colored material that hasn't faded yet to match.

Rain. The kind that doesn't clarify anything. Heavy enough to matter, too uniform to be interesting. Everything it touches gets heavier.

KATNISS EVERDEEN on a rooftop. Crouched behind a parapet, bow out, arrow nocked but not drawn, her attention split between the street below and the perimeter behind her. She carries her years the way she carries everything – efficiently, without unnecessary display. The arena taught her that weight is only a problem if you hold it wrong.

Beside her, two meters away: NATASHA ROMANOFF. Not in gear that signals anything. Dark clothes. Practical boots. The specific aesthetic of someone who needs to move faster than clothing typically allows and has calibrated accordingly.

The rain between them. They've been in this position for forty minutes. Comfortable silence of people who've established operational trust.

KATNISS

(eyes on the street)

You've fought someone like her before?

NATASHA

I've fought things with her structural profile. Power dominant, directional force, confidence in the outcome as a tactical asset.

KATNISS

That's not the same as having fought her.

NATASHA

(a beat of acknowledgment)

No. But what the profile types I've encountered all had in common: they were committed to an idea. Not an objective — an idea. An idea about what they are and what the world owes that. An idea makes you predictable because you can't revise it when the situation changes.

KATNISS

And she has an idea.

NATASHA

She has several overlapping ones. Which is worse, actually. Single-idea people are easier to read. She has a hierarchy of ideas and she reorders the hierarchy based on circumstances.

KATNISS

(after a moment)

What's at the top of the hierarchy?

NATASHA

Power structured by the people she believes should hold it. Not destruction – construction. She wants to build something. The destruction is just what she does with things that are in the way of what she's building.

Movement below. STORMFRONT's advance unit: not large, not theatrical, moving with the certainty of people who believe in who sent them.

KATNISS

Nineteen.

NATASHA

I count twenty.

KATNISS

(looking more carefully)

The one behind the truck. Yeah. Twenty.

NATASHA

Stormfront won't be with them.

KATNISS

I know. She waits. She finds what
you're not covering and comes from
there.

NATASHA

How do you know that pattern?

KATNISS

(looking at the street, not Natasha)
Someone I fought once. Long time ago.
Different kind of powerful. Same
approach.

NATASHA

Snow.

KATNISS

(a beat — the word still has weight, even
now)
Snow.

A pause. The rain.

NATASHA

How did you deal with it? When you
figured out his pattern?

KATNISS

I changed what I was protecting. So
what he was looking for when he went to

find what I was leaving exposed — it
wasn't there. I'd moved it.

NATASHA

What were you protecting instead?

KATNISS

(long pause, honest)

The idea that he couldn't win. Even if
he won. The idea that what he was doing
was still wrong, regardless of the
outcome. I protected that. I made sure
that was the thing he couldn't reach.

Natasha looks at her. A real look — not tactical
assessment. The look of recognizing something.

A nod. Not admiration. Comprehension.

Then:

LIGHTNING. Three streets east. From a direction they hadn't
covered.

Katniss releases the arrow before the thought. Muscle
memory from too many arenas.

ACT TWO: THE FIGHT

EXT. CITY RUINS — CONTINUOUS — FIGHT SEQUENCE

STORMFRONT comes from the direction they weren't covering.
The direction Natasha predicted she'd come from. The
prediction was correct. The prediction being correct didn't

make it preventable — she was already in motion when the prediction was confirmed.

Katniss's arrow: midair, Stormfront catches it. Not deflects. Her hand closes around the shaft. She holds it up. She looks at it. Then she looks at the rooftop.

Their eyes meet across the distance. The rain between them.

CLOSE ON STORMFRONT: the expression of a person who respects the shot, is annoyed by the shot, and has already made two tactical decisions while processing both.

She moves.

A FIGHT between three women who have each survived extinction-level events by their own specific choices is not a fight in any theatrical sense. It is a conversation in a language made of physics and attention and the particular courage that comes from having already lost the thing you were most afraid of losing and finding out you're still here.

STORMFRONT operates from certainty. Her power is directional, massive, comes from her like a point being made. She doesn't dodge — she moves through, past, over. She was designed to dominate and she moves like something designed. Every motion preceded by the certainty that it will work.

NATASHA operates from negation. She doesn't fight Stormfront's power. She fights Stormfront's attention. Every engagement redirected, absorbed, dissolved. She is making Stormfront fight the air. Three seconds here. Two seconds there. Never letting the gap close to where power matters. She's been doing this for thirty years and her body knows the geometry of it the way language knows grammar.

KATNISS operates from above and behind. Distance. Precision. Three arrows:

FIRST: Modified charge-tip. She fires at the water main behind Stormfront. The lightning discharge redirects into the main. The feedback loop sends Stormfront sideways to avoid it. Natasha is already where sideways leads. She costs Stormfront two seconds and her position.

SECOND: Standard shaft, different angle. Filed into the gap when Natasha moves — Katniss reads Natasha's movement and fires into where Stormfront will look when Natasha draws her attention. Stormfront catches this one too. It costs her the second arrow. It also costs her focus.

THIRD: Katniss waits. She waits for the specific moment when someone at Stormfront's confidence level makes the mistake of believing the pattern has established itself. She waits for the beat where certainty becomes assumption. She fires into that beat.

This arrow Stormfront does not catch.

The tip isn't lethal — it isn't designed to be. It's designed to disrupt. The electromagnetic pulse in the tip fires on contact. Stormfront's nervous system takes it as a system reset. For two seconds, every signal in her body misfiles.

She goes to one knee. For the first time in this scene. For the first time in possibly years.

She looks up at the rooftop. At Katniss.

CLOSE ON STORMFRONT: breathing. Not winded. Processing. Recalculating.

She rises.

STORMFRONT

(looking at Katniss — the tone of a woman
acknowledging a fact)

You're better than the reports.

KATNISS

The reports were written by people who
had reasons to underestimate me.

STORMFRONT

(a half-beat)

Were they? Or did you want them to
underestimate you?

A beat. Rain. Ruins.

From behind Stormfront, out of a shadow — NATASHA.

Stormfront doesn't turn. She felt her before she heard her.

STORMFRONT

(not turning)

I'd stop there.

NATASHA

(not stopping)

I know you'd like that.

What happens next happens too fast for the eye to hold. The kind of movement that occurs when someone at Stormfront's level decides a conversation is complete. The city block takes the cost of that decision. The decision costs one wall, most of a streetlamp, and a vehicle that was already destroyed but is now more destroyed.

When the air settles: NATASHA on the ground. Breathing. Ribs. Nothing broken. She's done the assessment before she's finished falling — old habit, decades-old habit.

KATNISS on a different rooftop than the one she started on, already nocking arrow four.

STORMFRONT: gone. Not defeated. Gone. On her terms. Her timeline.

NATASHA

(sitting up slowly)
Good news.

KATNISS

(across the distance, re-nocked, watching the skyline)
That was good news?

NATASHA

She left. She didn't have to. She could have finished this. She left because she has something larger in mind and we're not it.

KATNISS

We're the distraction.

NATASHA

We're the message. She wanted us to see that she came, she outmatched us, and she chose to leave. She's telling someone something.

KATNISS

(looking at the sky where Stormfront disappeared)
Who?

NATASHA

Epstein. She's demonstrating readiness.

Katniss lowers the bow. She looks at the city. Something moves across her face – the particular stillness of someone who has been hunted before and is feeling the sensation of being adjacent to a hunt that is larger than her.

KATNISS

(quietly)

Then what are we?

NATASHA

Collateral, so far. The question is what we become when she's done with the demonstration.

The rain. The ruins. The skyline where Stormfront is no longer visible but whose absence has a shape.

END OF EPISODE EIGHT

EPISODE NINE

"THE LAMPLIGHTER PROBLEM"

(75 Minutes)

ACT ONE: WHAT CAME BACK

INT. OUTPOST — SECURE CONTAINMENT — DAY

The chair is technically not restraint. There are no cuffs, no straps, no enforcement mechanism visible. But the room is arranged in the specific way of a room that has not forgotten what the person in the chair has done, and the arrangement communicates the option of restraint very clearly.

LAMPLIGHTER sits in the chair. He looks like himself — this is the disturbing thing, that someone with his history can simply look like himself, as if looking like yourself is something you get to do regardless of what yourself has done. He looks tired. He looks like a man who has been somewhere uncomfortable and has arrived here and is not sure this is better.

STARLIGHT — ANNIE — stands across from him. Her choice to bring him in. Not popular. She made it anyway. She's been making the unpopular choices lately and finding that the unpopularity doesn't mean they're wrong, and that this distinction is more useful than it used to be.

LAMPLIGHTER

(into the silence)

None of them want me here.

ANNIE

I know.

LAMPLIGHTER

Including you.

ANNIE

(after a beat — honest)

What I want is separate from what we
need. That distinction is the decision
I made.

LAMPLIGHTER

Very tactical.

ANNIE

I try to be. Where were you? Before you
came back.

A long pause. Something moves across Lamplighter's face
that is not the performance he usually manages.

LAMPLIGHTER

(quietly, looking at his hands)

Wherever I was, I saw everything I did.
All of it. In order. Not in pieces —
complete. Every choice, every
consequence, every person. I had a very
long time with it.

ANNIE

And?

LAMPLIGHTER

And I would prefer not to have come
back if coming back means carrying it.

ANNIE

But you're here.

LAMPLIGHTER

I'm here.

ANNIE

Why?

He looks at her. The long pause of someone forming a sentence that doesn't come easily to someone who has spent most of his life forming very different kinds of sentences.

LAMPLIGHTER

(with real difficulty, the difficulty of a man saying something true for what might be the first time)

Because whatever process returned me here didn't give me a choice about returning. It only gave me a choice about what to do once I was back. And I'm—

He stops.

ANNIE

(quietly, waiting)

What?

LAMPLIGHTER

I'm trying to be what I should have
been the first time.

Annie looks at him. She sits down. She looks at him at eye
level.

ANNIE

Okay.

LAMPLIGHTER

That's it?

ANNIE

That's it. You're trying to be the
thing you should have been. I believe
you. Now tell me about Epstein's
secondary lab locations, because that's
the practical reason you're useful to
this operation.

LAMPLIGHTER

(a beat — recalibrating to the directness)
Right. Yes. There are four that I know
of personally. Two I know from
operational secondhand.

ANNIE
(red pen on notepad)
Start with what you know personally.

ACT TWO: A-TRAIN

EXT. EARTH-2397 - SIDE STREET - DAY

A-TRAIN stops. He's been moving — running, at the speed that is technically below his maximum but still moves at the threshold of visible — for four hours. He stops in a side street. Nobody around. He puts his hands on his knees.

His breathing. It normalizes fast. Faster than a human body should normalize. The compound in him still doing what it does, even here, even in a dimension that isn't his.

He straightens. He looks at the street.

He has been on three different Earths in eight weeks. On each of them, his neighborhood existed. Different enough to matter — different storefronts, different corner geometry — but the same block, the same overall structure. The city organized around the same logic.

On two of them, there was a version of him. Famous. Recognizable. Fast.

On one of them, he wasn't there. The version of his neighborhood existed. His apartment building was there. His unit was occupied by someone else. A family. Children's drawings on the window.

That was the hardest one. The one where the absence had a specific shape.

His comm:

MM

(over comm)

A-Train. We have a position on a
secondary lab location from
Lamplighter's debrief. Need someone who
can confirm it fast.

A-TRAIN

How far?

MM

Twelve minutes at moderate. We need
four.

A-Train doesn't answer immediately. He looks at the street.
At this Earth that isn't his, this version of everything.

A-TRAIN

(into the comm)

Four. Give me the coordinates.

MM gives them. A-Train goes. The street, then not the
street.

Four minutes.

He pushes.

ACT THREE: HANK SCHRADER

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — INVESTIGATION ROOM — DAY

HANK SCHRADER stands at an evidence board that covers most of a wall. He has been here since six in the morning. It is now two in the afternoon. He has eaten a vending machine sandwich that he didn't taste because he was working while eating it, which is not the way sandwiches should be eaten but is how Hank eats them when something has his full attention.

The board: Epstein's network. Not the SHIELD version - Hank's version, which is the version built from the ground up by someone who doesn't know what SHIELD already has and therefore hasn't pre-filtered his analysis through their assumptions. His version is therefore incomplete in some ways and more complete in others.

FURY, passing in the corridor, stops.

FURY

(looking at the board from the door)
What is all this?

HANK

(not looking up from the thread he's following)
Epstein's network. Secondary and tertiary operational nodes. I mapped the dimensional routing from the transit records and cross-referenced against eleven atmospheric events over the past four years that nobody's connected. I found nine connections in six hours.

Fury comes in. He looks at the board. He looks at it the way he looks at things that cost him something to acknowledge.

FURY

That's Epstein's asset map for the last eighteen months.

HANK

Plus the four years before it. You want to understand the eighteen months, you have to understand the four years. He's been staging this for longer than anyone's been paying attention.

(pointing at a cluster of marks on the board)

HANK

These five events here — atmospheric anomalies, dimensional sensor artifacts, power signature spikes. Nobody catalogued them as connected because they were in different jurisdictions and the signatures were slightly different each time. But the underlying methodology is identical. Same timing pattern. Same approach to avoiding detection. I've read every file on Epstein this facility has. This is his handwriting. Literally.

FURY

(a beat)

Where did you come from?

HANK

Long story. Short version: I've been
after a chemist for a long time. He
ended up here. I ended up here.

(a dry look)

HANK

I'm not here about that anymore. He's
your asset. I get it. I'm here because
this—

He gestures at the board.

HANK

This is a conspiracy I can actually do
something about. And I don't walk away
from those.

Fury looks at the board. Nine connected events. The
decision tree Hank has mapped from them. The methodology
that is — he has to admit it — exactly right.

FURY

Can you find the other two?

HANK

(already turning back)
Give me until six.

FURY

(heading out)

I'll have someone bring you a real sandwich.

HANK
(without looking up)
Make it two.

END OF EPISODE NINE

EPISODE TEN

"THE HOMELANDER MULTITUDE"

(80 Minutes — The Invasion of Variants)

ACT ONE: 2 AM

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — DUTY STATION — NIGHT

The sensor board at 2:04 AM. The DUTY OFFICER — a career agent, twelve years of overnight shifts, a man who has learned to read the difference between sensor noise and signal with the precision of someone who has been wrong about that distinction before and absorbed the cost — stares at his readout.

Multiple contacts entering the upper atmosphere. Not one — many. The same signature, repeating, overlapping. The same biometric profile seventeen times. Each one fractionally distinct from the others the way photographs of the same person taken at different moments are fractionally distinct.

He reaches for the comm with the specific slowness of someone who wants to be absolutely sure before they say what they're about to say.

DUTY OFFICER

(into comm, controlled — barely)

Director Fury. I have seventeen contacts entering the upper atmosphere. All reading as — sir, they're all reading as the same power signature. Same biometric profile. All of them.

FURY

(over comm, the voice of a man who hasn't
been asleep)

I'm on my way. Wake everyone.

EXT. EARTH-2397 — THE SKY — MINUTES LATER

Seventeen HOMELANDERS descend through the atmosphere.

Not coordinated — each independent, arriving at their own angle and velocity, each one dropping through the cloud layer separately. From the ground, it looks like rain. A specific, terrible kind of rain.

Each one is Homelander. Each one is slightly wrong.

THE PRIMARY HOMELANDER — the one they know, the resurrected one, the one with the outer-dark amplification — arrives last. He lands in the boulevard and looks at what's coming toward him.

Sixteen versions of himself.

He looks at them with the expression of a man who was told this would happen and understood it intellectually and did not anticipate what the understanding would feel like as experience.

Sixteen variations on the same jaw. The same hands. The same fundamental wound, configured differently by seventeen different histories.

VARIANT-1: Taller, slightly. The cape a shade darker than any production team intended. Eyes that never got warm — not because they were hardened by something specific but because the warmth never developed. The version where there was no Ryan. No Becca. The version where the wound was present from the beginning and nobody was ever close enough to interrupt it.

VARIANT-7: No cape. Civilian clothes. Quieter than any of the others in a way that is, somehow, more disturbing than

the ones who broadcast power. The version where he spent a decade pretending to be ordinary and the pretending did something to him.

VARIANT-12: Visibly damaged. Something in his movement that suggests an injury that the compound couldn't fully repair, or that he chose not to let be repaired. The version where something happened that he decided should leave a mark.

They look at each other. The PRIMARY looks at all of them. This is a strange thing: to look at yourself from outside. To see the wound from every direction simultaneously.

VARIANT-1

(direct, no preamble)

How many did he send?

PRIMARY HOMELANDER

Seventeen including you. I counted from the sensor feeds.

VARIANT-1

Efficient. He's always efficient.

PRIMARY HOMELANDER

He doesn't do anything for a single reason. What did he tell you this was for?

VARIANT-1

He told us to find the one who survived and assess. His word. Assess.

PRIMARY HOMELANDER
Assess what?

VARIANT-7
(from the back of the assembled group,
quiet)
Whether you're still in control.

The boulevard. The city dark around them. Two AM.

PRIMARY HOMELANDER
(looking at Variant-7)
Control of what?

VARIANT-7
Of whatever he put in you. He needs to
know if it's running you or you're
running it.

PRIMARY HOMELANDER
(after a pause)
And if he decides it's running me?

VARIANT-1
(evenly)
We were given a second instruction for
that scenario.

ACT TWO: THE CONVERSATION

Three blocks away: BUTCHER, in a van, watching seventeen heat signatures on a thermal monitor. His face doing nothing visible and everything internal.

MM beside him. Natasha. Clint. The compound — current version, Frenchie's batch — ready.

MM

(looking at the monitor)
Seventeen of him.

BUTCHER

(not taking his eyes off the thermal display)
Seventeen.

CLINT

Are they — are they all the same power level?

BUTCHER

The sensors can't distinguish. Which is its own answer.

Back in the boulevard:

PRIMARY HOMELANDER

(looking at Variant-1)
We're not going to fight each other.

VARIANT-1

(a beat)
Epstein-

PRIMARY HOMELANDER

I know what Epstein wants. I'm telling
you what I want. We're not going to
fight each other. Not because of what I
am — because of what fighting each
other would mean.

VARIANT-7

(carefully)
What would it mean?

PRIMARY HOMELANDER

That we're still doing what we were
made to do. Performing strength for an
audience. Even when the audience is
Epstein and the stage is a boulevard at
two in the morning.

Silence.

Variant-12, who hasn't spoken, makes a sound that might be
agreement.

PRIMARY HOMELANDER

(to all of them, addressing something he's
been thinking about)

I want to understand something. Each of
us has a different story. Different
Earth. Different things that happened.
But the thing underneath — the thing
that drives all of it — is the same

across all seventeen of us. I can feel
it. Can you?

A pause. Seventeen beings with seventeen histories. The
same feeling in each of them.

VARIANT-7

(quietly)
Yes.

PRIMARY HOMELANDER

Why is it the same? Seventeen different
lives. Seventeen different outcomes.
The same thing underneath.

VARIANT-1

(after a long time)
Because the thing underneath the story
is what they made us. Before any of the
stories started. They made us for
something. And the making doesn't
change when the stories diverge.

The boulevard. The city. The rain that has started to fall
lightly.

PRIMARY HOMELANDER looks at the SHIELD building three
blocks away. He knows where Butcher is. He has known since
they arrived. He can hear his heartbeat from here. He can
hear all of them – their specific signatures, their
particular biological noise.

He looks at all his variants.

PRIMARY HOMELANDER

Go back to Epstein. Tell him I received his message.

VARIANT-1

That's all?

PRIMARY HOMELANDER

Tell him I said: I received his message. And I'm thinking about what I want to say back.

They go. Not immediately. Each one takes a moment — some more than others, the ones who found something in this meeting they didn't expect to find. The ones who are now carrying something they weren't carrying before.

One by one, they rise. They scatter. They go back through the dimensional seams.

The boulevard empty.

PRIMARY HOMELANDER alone in it.

He looks at the SHIELD building. He raises one hand. Not in greeting. Not in threat. In acknowledgment. The gesture of one person acknowledging another person across a distance.

Then he rises. He goes.

ACT THREE: AFTER THE MULTITUDE

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — WAR ROOM — LATER

The whole team. The footage of the boulevard – the seventeen Homelanders, the conversation they couldn't hear from three blocks away, the departure.

FURY

He dismissed them. He had seventeen versions of himself, sent by Epstein with instructions we don't fully know, and he dismissed them.

BUTCHER

He raised his hand. At the building. He knew we were watching.

ANNIE

He wanted us to know he dismissed them.

NATASHA

(looking at the footage)
He's separating from Epstein.

FURY

Or he wants us to think he is.

BUTCHER

(looking at the freeze-frame of the raised hand)
Both can be true. He might be genuinely separating and also know that showing us the separation is useful.

RYAN

(from the side of the room, quietly)
He's trying to tell us something.
That's why he made sure we saw it.

Everyone looks at Ryan.

RYAN

He could have had the meeting anywhere.
He had it in front of our building. He
dismissed them in front of our sensors.
He wanted us to see that he dismissed
them because it's the only way to send
us that information.

Silence.

BUTCHER

(to Ryan)
What's he sending?

RYAN

(thinking it through)
That there's something left. Something
that's still him, underneath what the
compound did. That whatever Epstein
made, it didn't make him completely.

FURY

(carefully)
Or that's exactly what Epstein would
want us to think.

RYAN

I know. But I think it's real.

Butcher looks at Ryan. Then at the freeze-frame. The raised hand in the boulevard.

BUTCHER

(very quietly, to himself)

So do I.

END OF EPISODE TEN

EPISODE ELEVEN

"WHAT WALTER BUILT"

(75 Minutes)

ACT ONE: THE SYNTHESIS

INT. WALTER'S LAB — EARTH-2397 — EARLY MORNING — WEEK SEVEN

The lab at the end of something. Not in disarray — the end of Walter's work never looks like disarray. But the bench has a quality that it didn't have before: finished. The quality of a surface that has held something and is now releasing it.

The compound: contained in a sealed transport vial on the center of the bench. It doesn't look like anything significant. It looks like a small quantity of slightly yellow liquid in a sealed container. Most things that change everything look like that.

JESSE sits in the corner. He has been here since midnight. He has eaten two convenience-store burritos and drunk one terrible coffee from the machine in the corridor. He has been watching Walter work.

He has watched Walter work for seventeen years, under conditions ranging from excellent to catastrophic, and he has never seen this exact quality in Walter's movements — the specific slowing that comes when the work is finished and the body hasn't caught up.

JESSE

(carefully)
Is it done?

WALTER

(still looking at the vial)

The synthesis is complete. The compound
is what I needed it to be.

JESSE

(sitting up)

And it'll work?

WALTER

(finally looking up)

It will work.

JESSE

(a beat — surprised that the answer was
that clean)

Wait. Really? Not like, probably? Not
another confidence interval?

WALTER

The confidence interval is ninety-one
point four percent. The update from
seventy-eight percent came last week
when I found what I needed in the
dimensional archive.

JESSE

Last week? You updated it last week and
you're only telling—

WALTER

(with the patience of a man who has answered this version of this question before)

I verified it last week. I told you when I had verified it and was satisfied with the verification. There's a difference.

JESSE

What changed? What did you find in the archive?

WALTER

The outer-dark compound left a specific resonance signature in the dimensional barrier sensors when it was first introduced into this cluster. An atmospheric event that nobody connected to anything – it looked like interference. It was actually the dark material broadcasting its own frequency as it integrated into the local physics. The precise frequency I needed to design the cancellation.

JESSE

You found the frequency in a sensor log.

WALTER

A sensor log from fourteen months ago that nobody had analyzed because nobody knew what to look for.

JESSE

(staring)

And you just — found it.

WALTER

I knew it had to exist somewhere in the monitoring data. The compound had to have announced itself when it arrived. Everything physical announces itself if you're looking for the announcement.

Jesse looks at the vial. He looks at Walter. Something in his face that is not the usual Jesse — something older, more specific.

JESSE

Mr. White.

WALTER

(picking up the vial, examining it)
Jesse.

JESSE

We did something good here. Like — actually good. Not complicated good. Not good-with-the-bad-part-you-have-to-acknowledge. Just good.

Walter looks at the vial for a long time. Then at Jesse.

WALTER

(quietly – not performing this, just saying it)

Yes. I think we did.

He sets the vial in the transport container. He picks up the comm.

WALTER

(into comm)

Fury. I need you in the lab. Bring whoever needs to understand what this does. I'll only explain it once.

ACT TWO: RYAN AND HOMELANDER – THE PARKING STRUCTURE

EXT. EARTH-2397 – PARKING STRUCTURE – NIGHT

HOMELANDER has been standing at the edge of the third level of this parking structure for twenty minutes. He chose the location: high enough for his sensors to operate, visible enough that the monitoring systems would find him, close enough to the facility that anyone watching would understand this was deliberate.

He is waiting. He could have made contact differently. He chose this: visible, patient, in a place where whoever came to meet him would come alone, because the structure makes group approach obvious from three different angles.

RYAN comes from the street level. He came alone. He told Butcher after, not before. Butcher is in a van 200 meters away. They have an understanding about what after means in this context.

Ryan is seventeen. He climbs the levels. He comes onto the third floor and sees Homelander at the edge and stops.

They look at each other across the structure.

The specific weight of this: Ryan, who lost his world.
Homelander, who ended it.

HOMELANDER

(after a long moment — first)
You look like her.

RYAN

People say I have his eyes.

HOMELANDER

Butcher's.

RYAN

Yeah.

HOMELANDER

You have her eyes.

Ryan doesn't answer. He's been preparing for this conversation for three years — since the day he understood that it would happen eventually, since the day he worked out who Homelander is and what Homelander was to him. He had words. He practiced them in his head in the months after.

He's not using the words.

RYAN

Why are you here?

HOMELANDER

(direct)

I wanted to see you. And I wanted to tell you something I can't tell you any other way.

RYAN

Tell me.

HOMELANDER

I've been moving through dimensions for months. I find things there. Versions of what I could have been. What I was. What I might have been under different conditions.

(a beat)

HOMELANDER

None of the versions are good, Ryan. I want to be clear about that. None of the paths produce something good. But some of them are different. Some of them tried. Some of them had-

He stops.

RYAN

(quietly, completing it)
Someone.

HOMELANDER

(looking away — honest)
Someone.

RYAN

You wanted to know if the trying makes
a difference.

HOMELANDER

(a beat)
Does it?

Ryan thinks about this. He takes the question seriously. He looks at the city below the structure — this Earth, this intact city.

RYAN

I think trying makes you a different thing during. I don't know if it changes what you are at the end. I think that might be a separate question.

HOMELANDER

Separate how?

RYAN

What you try to be and what you actually are. Both real. Both mattering. But not the same thing. You

can try to be something and fail to become it. The trying doesn't make you the thing. But it also doesn't make you nothing.

Homelander looks at him. He looks at this seventeen-year-old with Becca's eyes and Butcher's something.

HOMELANDER

Your mother taught you to think like that.

RYAN

She did. Butcher taught me to trust it even when it's inconvenient.

Almost — almost — a sound in Homelander's throat. Not quite a laugh. Something in that vicinity.

HOMELANDER

(after a moment)

The compound White built.

Ryan goes very still.

HOMELANDER

It will work. I can feel the dark compound — what it's doing, how it integrates. And I can feel the version of me that's underneath it. It's still there. It's—

RYAN

What's it like?

HOMELANDER

(a very long pause — the most honest this series has seen him)

Smaller. Quieter. Still wrong — still everything that was wrong from the beginning. But quieter. The outer dark amplifies everything, Ryan. Including the things I'd learned to push down.

Ryan absorbs this.

RYAN

(carefully)

Would you let us use it?

The question. The real question. The one he came here to ask.

Homelander looks at him. Silence.

HOMELANDER

(after a very long pause)

I don't know.

RYAN

That's not no.

HOMELANDER

(quietly)

No. It's not.

Ryan turns to go. At the edge of the level:

RYAN

(not turning back)

I don't forgive you. I want to be clear
about that.

HOMELANDER

I know.

RYAN

But I think — I think trying is its own
kind of thing. Even when it's late.
Even when it's too late for most of
what matters.

He goes. Homelander alone at the edge of the structure. The
city below. His hands.

He looks at his hands.

He closes them.

END OF EPISODE ELEVEN

EPISODE TWELVE

"WHEN GODS COLLIDE"

(80 Minutes — The Greatest Battle)

ACT ONE: THE MORNING

EXT. EARTH-2397 — THE FALLEN CITY — DAWN

The sky first. Before anything else, the sky: wrong. The clouds pressed low, abnormally dense, the color of the overcast shifting through gray into something with violet underneath. The meteorological effect of two power signatures at this scale operating in proximity. Static charge in the air. You can feel it in your teeth. The hair on your arms rises.

The fallen city below: quiet. The ruins have their early-morning stillness. What's left standing stands. What fell has fallen. The city has reached a steady state of damage that isn't going to get better or worse without effort.

CLOSE ON: boots on pavement. Walking. BUTCHER's walk — purposeful without hurry, the walk of a man who is not pretending to be calm but has arrived at a place past fear where something simpler and more durable lives. Something that isn't bravado. Something that simply is.

BUTCHER

(into comms, walking, low and steady)
Positions.

CLINT BARTON

(HAWKEYE, over comms – he sounds like someone who has done this before and has found his own version of that place past fear)

High twelve, northwest corner. I have visual on the primary objective and the secondary.

STARLIGHT

(over comms)

Southeast approach. Kimiko with me.

NATASHA

(over comms)

Southwest. Standing by. Maeve – Elena – is at the south perimeter ready to advance.

KATNISS

(over comms)

Overwatch. High. I can see all of you and the target.

FRENCHIE

(over comms – the specific professional quiet of a man who has prepared for this)

Six-point detonation array is set.
Compound in all eleven delivery units confirmed active. On your signal.

RYAN

(over comms – quiet, steady)

I have the backup dose. South approach.
Ready.

A pause. Butcher walking.

BUTCHER

Good. Hold quiet. When it starts you'll know.

EXT. THE FALLEN CITY — CENTRAL PLAZA — SAME TIME

HOMELANDER in the plaza. He arrived three minutes ago. He didn't approach — he arrived, the way weather arrives: not as a sequence of positions but as a presence that simply is where it is.

THANOS: beside him. Not a projection. In person, which is a different experience of Thanos than most people have had and have survived. The weight of him is different from Homelander's weight — where Homelander carries presence as something broadcast outward, Thanos carries his as gravity. A pull toward the center. The feeling of being in a system organized around something.

The Infinity Gauntlet: present. Not activated — he doesn't activate it for things that don't require it. The stones catch the dawn light.

They stand in the plaza not looking at each other. Both looking at the approaches.

Between them: the specific quality of two beings who have both been the most powerful thing in every room they've been in for their entire existence, now in the same room. Neither performing deference. Neither requiring acknowledgment. Something rarer: mutual recognition of scale.

THANOS
(without looking at Homelander)
Your people. They're moving into
position.

HOMELANDER
They're not my people.

THANOS
They were.

HOMELANDER
(a beat)
That was before.

THANOS
(a pause)
Before changes people differently
depending on whether the before was
chosen.

HOMELANDER
Mine wasn't.

THANOS
No. It rarely is. That's generally not
the relevant variable.

Homelander looks at the approach vectors. He hears Kimiko's
heartbeat from here. He hears Clint's breathing from
northwest. He hears Ryan — Ryan's heartbeat, which has been
something he knows since before Ryan could speak.

HOMELANDER

(quietly — not to Thanos, not to anyone
specifically)

They keep trying.

THANOS

(heard it anyway)

Yes.

HOMELANDER

Why.

THANOS

Because stopping requires accepting
that the outcome is determined. Most
beings cannot accept a determined
outcome while they still have capacity
for motion.

(a beat)

THANOS

I found it admirable for a long time.

HOMELANDER

And now?

THANOS

Now I find it admirable and sad. The
two aren't mutually exclusive.

Butcher walks into the plaza. He called an audible thirty seconds ago that he didn't put on comms because he knew what they'd say. He walks in alone.

He stops fifteen meters from Homelander. He has Walter's compound in his left hand – the full-capacity delivery unit, the green light active, the compound circulating at the frequency the sensors suggest might interrupt power above theoretical maximum.

Might. The word he's built everything on.

HOMELANDER

(seeing Butcher – something moving in his face that is not surprise, is not anger, is something older and harder to name)

You.

BUTCHER

(flat, present)

Yeah. Me.

HOMELANDER

You're going to try the compound.

BUTCHER

I'm going to try the compound.

HOMELANDER

White's version. Ninety-one percent.

BUTCHER

(a beat)

You knew about the compound.

HOMELANDER

I knew about it.

BUTCHER

(quietly, holding this)

And you're here anyway.

HOMELANDER

(after a very long pause)

I'm here anyway.

Thanos makes a sound. Something close to a laugh.

ACT TWO: THE BATTLE

STARLIGHT's light from the southeast — the signal — white and precise as a decision.

The battle begins.

THE FIRST TWENTY SECONDS: CLINT releases seven arrows. The release-to-flight is under a second per arrow — not fast for Clint, this is his controlled pace, the pace that leaves room for correction. Four standard, two containing compound capsules, one tracking payload.

Homelander intercepts five. Of the compound arrows: one absorbed, one capsule compromised. The compound barely registers before he burns it off.

FRENCHIE watching the readout from three blocks away. His tablet showing the effect: 4%. For eleven seconds.

Four percent. Eleven seconds.

He stares at the number. Then he grabs his radio.

FRENCHIE

(into radio, urgent and precise)

It works. The compound works. Four percent, eleven seconds, but it is not zero. Do you hear me? It is not zero.

ON ANNIE — STARLIGHT: the math. Four percent. But if enough doses, close enough—

KIMIKO is already moving. Her compound-enhanced speed — after four weeks working with SHIELD specialists and something Frenchie synthesized that improved her response time by 40% — allows her to operate inside Homelander's response window for exactly 2.8 seconds before he adjusts. She has timed this in training one hundred and seventeen times.

She delivers two compound charges from three feet away.

HOMELANDER goes still for two seconds. Not powerless — still. The compound creating something like a reset condition. His eyes blink. His hands flatten slightly.

In those two seconds: Natasha from the west, already in motion. Starlight from the east, light firing. Katniss's arrow from above — the modified charge tip, the one Seiko Toast helped design.

THEN THANOS ENGAGES and the math changes completely.

THANOS does not engage at full capacity. He has not engaged at full capacity in years. Full capacity is for existential threats. What's in front of him is not an existential

threat. What's in front of him is interesting, which is a different category.

He moves. Counter-clockwise. Three steps, pivot. Three steps, pivot. A pattern.

CLINT has been watching the pattern for six minutes from the northwest position. He has a theory. He almost always has a theory. His theories have a high success rate, which has not made him arrogant about them because his theories have also failed at moments that cost people he cared about, and he carries those failures.

He gets ahead of the pattern. He positions. He fires.

The arrow doesn't hit Thanos. It hits a damaged building at a precise angle that creates a resonant frequency at a precise decibel level that creates interference in the connection between the Infinity Gauntlet and its wearer. It's a sound. A specific sound. A sound that doesn't hit people but hits electronics.

And the Gauntlet is electronics, among other things.

Two seconds. Maybe three.

BUTCHER is there. He has positioned himself for this moment. He deploys the device: full Walter White dose, close range, in the window that Clint's arrow bought.

The effect: 4% becomes 31%. For nine seconds.

In nine seconds, every member of the team delivers everything they have. Nine seconds of everyone, in coordinated action, with compound coursing through the target at 31% efficiency.

It's not enough. Ninety-one point four percent is not one hundred percent, and the nine seconds are also three seconds shorter than the model predicted.

But the building doesn't fall. The plaza holds. They are all still alive. All of them. Not in perfect condition — Elena has two cracked ribs, Kimiko has a shoulder

dislocation she's already working back into place — but alive.

When the nine seconds end and Homelander returns to full capacity, he looks at Butcher.

Just looks.

HOMELANDER

(something undefinable in his voice —
registering something he hasn't registered
in years)

You hurt me.

BUTCHER

(blood at his lip, standing)

Four percent.

HOMELANDER

For nine seconds.

BUTCHER

It's a start.

The longest pause in the episode. The city quiet.

THANOS, beside Homelander, watches Butcher with the specific attention he gives to things he finds genuinely interesting. He has encountered very few things he finds genuinely interesting.

THANOS

(very quietly, to Homelander)

He's not afraid of you.

HOMELANDER

(also quiet)

No.

THANOS

Does that still matter to you?

HOMELANDER

(honest — the honesty of someone who has
stopped managing their own answers)

I don't know what matters to me
anymore.

He looks at Butcher. He looks at all of them — this
battered, standing, present collection of humans with their
compound and their arrows and their specific refusal.

He looks at Ryan, on the south approach with the backup
dose, who never got to use it.

He leaves. Not because he's been stopped. He leaves. On his
own terms, on his own timing. For reasons that will not be
clear until three scenes later.

Thanos watches him go. Then he looks at Butcher.

THANOS

He'll come back.

BUTCHER

I know.

THANOS

You'll be ready?

BUTCHER

We'll be here. That's not the same thing.

THANOS

(considering this)

No. It's not.

A pause. Thanos considers Butcher.

THANOS

I genuinely don't know whether I should help you or oppose you. Both have arguments.

BUTCHER

(without missing a beat)

Join the queue.

Thanos makes the sound again. Closer to a laugh this time. Certainty increasing.

He goes.

The plaza. The team, standing in it. Alive.

END OF EPISODE TWELVE

EPISODE THIRTEEN

"THE WEIGHT COMES DUE"

(75 Minutes)

ACT ONE: THE NIGHT BEFORE

INT. OUTPOST — VARIOUS ROOMS — NIGHT

Nobody calls it the night before. Calling it the night before would require naming what it's the night before of, and there is a shared, unspoken agreement that naming it would make it more specific than any of them are ready for it to be. But everybody knows.

You can see it in the coffee. The coffee is consumed more slowly than usual — each cup held a little longer, each sip a little more deliberate. The specific behavior of people who have tomorrow somewhere in the room with them and are being careful around it.

MM and Annie at the kitchen table. He is talking about Janine — the project she showed him on video, the planet shirt she was wearing when she showed it. Annie listens in the way she listens when she's actually listening, not waiting for a gap in which to offer something. She is just with him in the story of his daughter.

KIMIKO and FRENCHIE on the roof — their roof now, the specific territory of two people who have been through enough together that they have territories. He's talking — gesturing, the way he does when words are insufficient for what he's trying to say, so the hands do more — and she's watching both the gesture and his face, reading them the way she reads everything: completely.

RYAN and BECCA in the common room. A television on with the sound low. Neither of them watching it. The sound is

company. They're sitting close enough that the closeness is its own statement – the statement that says: I'm here, and you don't have to say anything, and tomorrow is tomorrow.

BUTCHER moves through all of it. He doesn't stop anywhere long. He moves through the outpost the way he has every night for seven weeks – taking the count, verifying the presence of each person, making sure everyone is here, everyone accounted for. He's never explained this to anyone. Nobody's asked. They all know.

He passes the kitchen – nods at MM, who nods back. The roof – visible through the window. The common room – a moment in the doorway.

BECCA looks up at him.

RYAN, on the couch, turns his head.

Butcher looks at them both. He nods – both of them, one nod that says: I see you. You're here. That's everything.

He goes out.

INT. OUTPOST – LANDING BAY – LATER

CLINT BARTON finds him beside the Quinjet. This is where Butcher goes when he's working something out that doesn't have a room.

CLINT
(leaning against the wall)
Can't sleep.

BUTCHER
(looking at the Quinjet)
Wasting the time. No.

CLINT

I used to do that. The night-before thing. Stand somewhere and look at the equipment.

BUTCHER

Did it help?

CLINT

(honest)

No. But I stopped trying to make it help at some point. Now it's just where I go when my brain won't stop.

BUTCHER

(after a moment)

How do you get through it? The night before something you can't guarantee the outcome of.

CLINT

(a pause — actually thinking about it)

I think about what's there when I come back. Not what I'm walking into — what I'm walking back to. Kate gives me hell for not texting. Laura made dinner plans. The kids have things happening.

A beat.

CLINT

I just — I hold that. The going-back-to. It's not strategy. It's just something to hold.

BUTCHER

What if you don't come back?

CLINT

(quiet, no performance in it)

Then someone else holds those things.
The things don't disappear because I'm
not there to hold them. They just
belong to someone else.

A long pause. The bay. The Quinjet. The night outside.

BUTCHER

(very dry)

That's not comforting.

CLINT

(small smile)

It's not supposed to be comforting.
It's supposed to be true.

They stand in the bay for a while. Not saying anything else. Just standing. This is the night before, in its specific, irreducible form: two people who have been in these situations before and have not yet found a way to make the night before shorter.

ACT TWO: WALTER'S LAST NIGHT

INT. WALTER'S LAB — NIGHT

The lab dismantled. Not dramatically — systematically, the way Walter does all things: he made a list when they arrived and he is working through it, accounting for every component, logging the equipment state. Nothing will be left behind that shouldn't be left. Nothing will be lost that belonged to someone.

Jesse has been helping for six hours. Near-silence between them — not the uncomfortable silence of two people who have nothing to say, but the comfortable near-silence of two people who have said most of the important things over seventeen years and know when silence serves better.

The last thing Walter packs: his glasses case. He takes the glasses off. He holds them for a moment — a specific moment, the weight of this particular pair that he's worn for three years since the last pair were broken in a situation he has never fully described to anyone. He puts them in the case. He closes the case with the precision of someone who does this every night and tonight does it the same way.

JESSE
(from across the empty lab)
Mr. White.

WALTER
(picking up the case)
Jesse.

JESSE

What happens after? Like — for us. You
and me. After they get Homelander.
After all of this.

Walter looks at the space where the lab was. The empty room
that was, for seven weeks, the most important room in the
facility. The room where the thing that might work was
built.

WALTER

I don't know.

JESSE

(surprised)

You don't know?

WALTER

I told you: I don't give estimates on
things I haven't modeled.

JESSE

Is that real or is that the thing you
say when you don't want to say what you
actually think?

A very long pause. Walter with the glasses case.

WALTER

(quietly — not performing honesty, just
having it)

It's partly the thing I say. And it's partly true. And what I actually think is—

He stops. He looks at the empty bench.

WALTER

I would like to go somewhere and do chemistry. The actual kind. The kind I was doing at twenty-three when I understood for the first time that this was the thing. Not this—

(a gesture at the empty space, at everything the space held)

WALTER

Not the weapons-adjacent kind that circumstances keep requiring. The real kind. In a lab that belongs to something legitimate and good.

(a pause that costs him something)

WALTER

And I would like you to be somewhere. Living a life. Checking in occasionally.

JESSE

(very quiet)
Yeah?

WALTER

(clearing his throat – the gesture of a man who has said the difficult thing and is now managing the aftermath of having said it)

Yes. That is what I would like.

Jesse looks at him. Seventeen years of looking at this man.
The full scope of it.

JESSE

(quietly)

Mr. White.

WALTER

(at the door, not turning)

Jesse.

JESSE

We did something good.

Walter stands in the door. He holds this.

WALTER

(after a moment – the most unguarded he has been in this entire series)

Yes. I think we did.

He goes out. Jesse stands in the empty room. He breathes.
He goes out too.

END OF EPISODE THIRTEEN

EPISODE FOURTEEN

"THE LAST BEFORE"

(80 Minutes — Penultimate)

ACT ONE: FINAL BRIEFING

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — WAR ROOM — 0400 HOURS

The fullest the war room has been. Every chair occupied. Standing at the walls. FURY at the front. Beside him: WALTER WHITE, who has brought his notes and a cup of coffee he hasn't touched. Around the table: BUTCHER, MM, ANNIE, KIMIKO, FRENCHIE, CLINT, NATASHA, MAEVE/ELENA, LAMPLIGHTER, THE DEEP, A-TRAIN, RYAN, BECCA (at the side, not at the table — her presence at the table was offered, she chose the side), and JOSEPH AL-MITHALI, who arrived yesterday and has been listening more than speaking, which is its own kind of statement.

SEIKO TOAST at the back with his thermos. He has made coffee for the room. It is significantly better than the facility coffee.

ISABELLA at the far wall, not sitting, standing. She has been standing in that position for twenty minutes. She does not appear to notice.

FURY

Walter's compound. Eleven doses. Each dose provides a sustained resonance disruption window of approximately ninety seconds. Ninety-one point four percent confidence on the effect at close range.

BUTCHER

After ninety seconds?

WALTER

(from the side)

He burns through it and returns to
amplified capacity.

BUTCHER

So eleven doses at ninety seconds each.
If delivered sequentially. But he won't
let us deliver them sequentially.

NATASHA

He can't track and counter all of us
simultaneously. We've established that.
Episode Twelve proved the threshold.
With enough angles, enough simultaneous
pressure, he has to choose what to
respond to.

FURY

The physics team here has a number. To
fully destabilize the dark compound's
integration with his biology, the
resonance disruption needs to be
sustained — with no break longer than
fifteen seconds — for a minimum of
eight hundred seconds. Twelve
continuous minutes.

A silence.

MM

(doing the math)

Twelve minutes of near-continuous
compound exposure.

RYAN

(from the end of the table)

Eleven doses at ninety seconds each
with fifteen-second maximum gaps.
That's fourteen minutes and fifty-five
seconds of total coverage. It's enough.

Everyone looks at him.

RYAN

If delivery is perfect and no dose is
wasted on wrong range. Eleven doses is
exactly enough if we don't miss.

WALTER

(precisely)

Perfect delivery means within two
meters. Every dose.

The room knows what two meters means. Two meters from what
Homelander is.

MAEVE/ELENA

(from the wall — not announcing, just
stating)

I can deliver four.

Everyone looks at her. She meets the room evenly.

MAEVE/ELENA

I know how he moves when he's at full capacity. I know his counter-patterns. I've been inside that range before and I know what it costs and I can do it four times.

BUTCHER

(to her – asking, not telling)
You know what four times means.

MAEVE/ELENA

(meeting his eyes)
Yes.

Butcher holds her look. He nods.

BUTCHER

Four from Elena. Three from Kimiko – she can operate inside his response time. Two from Starlight – she can deliver at enough angle to count at range. One from me.

FURY

That's ten. We have eleven.

BUTCHER
Ryan carries the backup.

The room.

BECCA, at the side wall, doesn't make a sound. Her face
does something very controlled.

BUTCHER
(to Ryan — asking, not deciding)
Ryan.

RYAN
(without hesitation)
Yes.

BECCA
(standing, controlled but present)
Billy.

BUTCHER
(to Ryan, not Becca)
You understand what the backup means.
You're the insurance. You go in only if
the first ten fail and we still have
window.

RYAN
(steady)
I understand.

BECCA

(to Butcher, quiet and absolute),)
He comes back.

BUTCHER
(to her – not dismissing the weight of it)
He comes back.

BECCA
That is not a plan. That is a
condition. There is a difference.

BUTCHER
(holding her eyes)
I know. It's both.

ACT TWO: THE EPSTEIN EXPANSION

INT. THE OUTER DARK – EPSTEIN'S DOMAIN – SIMULTANEOUS

Epstein alone at his table. The chandelier turning. The prism moving. Everything in this room is in motion and nothing ever stops and nothing ever appears to move – the specific paradox of a room that belongs to someone who has organized his entire existence around the difference between appearance and reality.

He has a file. Thick. The Desert Land territory map – dimensional coordinates of the region between the Breaking Point events and the Final War, the no-man's-land where multiple collapsed realities have left their ghosts.

He reads. He turns pages. He makes a note in handwriting so small it requires excellent light to read – he prefers

notes nobody else can read, which is a preference that has served him well.

He sets the file down. He picks up his wine glass. He turns it.

EPSTEIN

(to himself – the first time in this series that he speaks to himself, which means this is what he thinks when nobody is performing for)

The conditions are set.

He looks at the file. At the map. At the dimensional array outside his window that shows the multi-Earth spread of events currently in motion.

EPSTEIN

(very quietly, to no one)

Now we see what they do with them.

He sets the glass down precisely. He picks up the file. He goes to the window.

What's visible through the window: the dimensional array. Multiple threads. Multiple events. Multiple people making choices in the spaces between what has been arranged.

He watches it all. His face: nothing readable. His eyes: everything readable, if you know what to read.

ACT THREE: THE OBSERVATORY

INT. THE OBSERVATORY BETWEEN WORLDS — TIMELESS

A place that doesn't appear on any dimensional map. The Watchers built it before dimensional maps existed. Before there was anyone to make maps for.

ISABELLA at a window that looks out on everything and nothing simultaneously. The multiversal array: every timeline, every contingency, every possible version of what is about to happen. She is not watching all of it. She watches one thread.

The thread: a rooftop on an Earth that is not home. A collection of people moving through their last night before something. She watches MM on video with his daughter. She watches Kimiko drawing. She watches Ryan with Becca. She watches Annie and Hughie together in the dark, not talking, just present. She watches Butcher in the bay with Clint, not talking either, just standing.

She watches all of it.

A PRESENCE behind her. Not a body. A quality of vast, patient attention.

THE WATCHER

(voice from everywhere and nowhere)

You've been watching them for forty-two hours.

ISABELLA

I know.

THE WATCHER

Your role is to observe. Not—

ISABELLA
I know what my role is.

A long pause.

THE WATCHER
(carefully)
And yet.

ISABELLA
And yet.

She looks at the thread. The rooftop. The people.

ISABELLA
They're going to make it.

THE WATCHER
That is not something that can be-

ISABELLA
I know it can't be determined. I'm not
determining it. I'm saying it. As a
choice. As a thing I'm choosing to say
into the multiversal record.

A pause.

THE WATCHER

(very slowly)

The boy. White's compound. The delivery sequence. The eleven doses. You've seen the thread where it works?

ISABELLA

I've seen the threads where it doesn't. More of them.

THE WATCHER

Then how—

ISABELLA

Because in the threads where it doesn't work, there's a variable that's missing. A person who isn't there when they should be. And in this thread—

(she looks at the thread, at the specific person in question)

ISABELLA

Everyone is there. Everything that was supposed to happen to bring everyone to this place has happened. The variable is present.

THE WATCHER

(after a very long silence)

Your mother watched threads like this for ten thousand years. She never said things she wasn't certain of.

ISABELLA

(not angry – just certain, in a different
way than her mother was certain)

My mother watched. I'm going.

She goes through the Observatory door. The Watcher watches
the multiversal array. The thread: the rooftop, the team,
the last night before.

THE WATCHER

(to itself, barely)

Hm.

Whether that is approval or concern or something between
the two is not possible to determine. The Observatory holds
the thread regardless.

SMASH CUT TO:

END OF EPISODE FOURTEEN

EPISODE FIFTEEN

"THE COLLECTORS" — SERIES FINALE

(90 Minutes)

ACT ONE: THE OPERATION

EXT. EARTH-2397 — THE REBUILT OUTPOST — DAWN — OPERATION DAY

The wall of the outpost, exterior. Someone has painted a line on it in Frenchie's handwriting — in French, in the particular blue he chose because it's the color of something he keeps private:

Ce qui n'a pas de fin ne peut pas être perdu.

What has no end cannot be lost.

Below it, in a different hand — Kimiko's — a single drawn figure. A flame. Small, precise, careful.

The team assembles in the pre-dawn. No speech. No ceremony. The specific, unglamorous assembly of people who are about to do something they've been preparing for and who have prepared enough that preparation has become the ground under their feet.

Compound units checked. Positions confirmed. Clint does a visual check of everyone he can see from the doorway. He counts. He gets to the right number.

BUTCHER at the center of the yard, not briefing — just there. A fixed point. The team orbits it naturally.

RYAN beside him. Beside, not behind. Seventeen years old, standing in the pre-dawn of an operation that will determine multiple things, carrying the backup dose.

BECCA in the doorway of the outpost. She is not going. She has made this clear and it has been accepted clearly. She watches from the doorway.

Butcher turns. He looks at her. She looks at him.

She nods. He nods.

He turns back to the team.

BUTCHER

(to the team — not raised voice, not a speech, just the necessary thing)

Frenchie calls the window when each dose lands. Elena, you're first contact. Kimiko follows her in. Starlight at the angle. I'm at close range on doses six through ten. Ryan holds the backup until I call for it or Frenchie calls the window closed.

(a beat)

BUTCHER

We hold the window for twelve minutes. That's the job.

Nobody says anything. Then: movement. The team disperses toward their positions.

MAEVE/ELENA, passing Butcher, touches his arm. One hand, brief. He looks at her.

MAEVE/ELENA

(quietly)

I'm good.

BUTCHER

I know.

She goes.

ACT TWO: FOURTEEN MINUTES AND EIGHT SECONDS

EXT. THE FALLEN CITY — CENTRAL PLAZA — DAWN

HOMELANDER is in the plaza when they arrive. He was here before any sensor caught his approach — he came directly, without the usual transit signature, which means he came from close range, which means he was already in this Earth when they were briefing.

He looks at the approaches as the team takes its positions. He can hear all of them. He has always been able to locate people by heartbeat. He locates each member of the team by theirs: Butcher (elevated but controlled). Elena (steady, deliberately steady — the heartbeat of someone who has made their peace). Ryan (faster, young, alive).

He looks at the position of each one.

He waits.

MAEVE/ELENA comes first.

She does not run at him. She walks. This is the most terrifying version — a woman who has gone against Homelander before and survived, approaching at walking pace, because she knows that her advantage is not speed but specificity. She knows exactly one thing about him that

nobody else knows: the half-second hesitation in his left-shoulder block when he's tracking a secondary target.

She's been saving this knowledge for three years.

She gets to two meters. She deploys dose one.

FRENCHIE: 4% becomes 31%. Window opens.

KIMIKO in the half-second of the window, three feet away, dose two.

FRENCHIE: holding at 31%. Timer running.

CLINT's arrows, not compound – spacing shots, buying Butcher the angles he needs.

ANNIE from the southeast, dose three at range – she's developed the new delivery angle, the one that works from farther out. Walter approved the modification last week.

FRENCHIE: 31%, holding, 90 seconds elapsed, 14 minutes 8 seconds remaining.

MAEVE/ELENA, second approach. She goes back in. This is the one that costs her. He knows her pattern now – one approach gives him her approach. She changes it. She uses the left shoulder.

She gets dose four in. She takes the hit that comes after it. She goes down. She gets back up.

FRENCHIE: still holding. Timer 12 minutes 14 seconds remaining.

KIMIKO, dose five. Inside his window, three seconds, out.

BUTCHER at six meters, dose six. He's never this close. This is the closest he has ever been to Homelander while Homelander was not choosing to stop.

Homelander looks at him across the space.

What passes between them in that look has no name. It contains everything that's happened, all of it – the whole

history, from the beginning, from the thing that started this – and it contains something else, something new, something that the outer dark compound has suppressed and that ninety-one point four percent of Walter's compound is temporarily unmuting.

Dose six deployed.

FRENCHIE: 91%, holding, 10 minutes 31 seconds remaining.

The seven, eight, nine, ten – in the windows, in the gaps, one after another. The team running the operation like a relay made of biology and precision and the specific courage of people who are carrying everything they have left and choosing to put it here.

FRENCHIE, at the monitor, watching the timer: 2 minutes 14 seconds remaining. Ten doses used.

He looks at the readout. He looks at the disruption percentage.

It's dropping. Faster than projected. Homelander's biology is adapting – the outer-dark compound recognizing the disruption and beginning to compensate.

FRENCHIE

(into comms, urgent)

Window is closing faster than modeled.

We need the backup dose. Now.

RYAN. Moving from the south approach before Butcher calls for it. Because Ryan can see the timer and he can do math and the math says now.

Two meters. Then one.

HOMELANDER looks at him. He has heard Ryan's heartbeat this entire operation. He has known Ryan was here. He has not done anything about Ryan being here.

This is the variable Isabella identified. This is the thread where everyone is present.

Ryan deploys the backup dose.

FRENCHIE: 91%, window extended, timer 1 minute 44 seconds—
The timer runs.

The dark compound's integration reaches the threshold. The outer dark material — which has been amplifying everything, broadcasting at a frequency beyond what human biology should be capable of receiving — hits the point of instability that Walter calculated at 91.4% confidence.

It becomes unstable.

CLOSE ON HOMELANDER's face as it happens. The dark compound losing its grip. The amplification failing. The frequency dropping. Something surfacing — not peace, not goodness, not redemption. Something smaller and harder: the original wound, without the amplification that made it a weapon. The thing that was there before Epstein's compound made it something cosmic.

The thing that was always there.

Just quieter now.

ACT THREE: AFTER

EXT. THE FALLEN CITY — PLAZA — CONTINUOUS

The compound's main effect runs its course. Homelander is not destroyed. He is not gone. He is — as Walter precisely described — returned to himself. Whatever himself is without the outer dark amplification. Compound V Homelander. A planetary-level threat. The manageable kind.

FURY's dimensional containment units move in. This was planned. The protocols Fury has been trying to ratify for three years are ratified in about four minutes by necessity.

The team stands in the plaza. Alive. All of them. Various degrees of damage — Elena has four cracked ribs and has stopped acknowledging them, Kimiko's shoulder is dislocated again, Frenchie has a cut above his eye from debris, Butcher has blood from somewhere he hasn't identified yet and isn't looking for.

Ryan in the middle of the plaza. He looks at where Homelander was. He looks at his own hands — the backup dose unit, empty, deployed.

BUTCHER reaches him. He puts a hand on Ryan's shoulder. Ryan looks up at him.

RYAN

(processing, very calm — the calm of someone whose system has finally processed something enormous)

It worked.

BUTCHER

(equally calm, equally processing)

It worked.

A pause.

RYAN

Is he—

BUTCHER

Contained. Fury's people have him.
Walter's already working on the anchor
compound — something that prevents the
dark material from re-integrating.
He'll be—

He stops. He's not sure what the right word is for what
Homelander will be.

BUTCHER

He'll be managed. That's the word.

Ryan nods. He looks at the plaza. He looks at the team,
scattered across it, doing the immediate post-operation
things: Frenchie already on comms with the medical bay,
Kimiko signing something to him, Elena sitting on a piece
of fallen wall and breathing carefully, Annie with light
still in her hands from the last position.

BECCA appears. She came when the containment units moved
in. She's here now, moving across the plaza toward them.

Ryan goes to her. She meets him at the walk. She puts her
arms around him and holds on.

Butcher watches. He stands in the plaza alone for a moment
and watches the two of them.

He puts his hand on the nearest wall. He presses it there,
hard. Same gesture. Always the same gesture.

Then he takes it off the wall. He turns toward the team.

ACT FOUR: THE ARRIVAL

INT. THE IN-BETWEEN — DIMENSIONAL CROSSROADS — NIGHT

Before the rooftop. Before the arrival. The in-between, which exists between the events.

SEIKO TOAST at what can only be called a counter — a flat surface in dimensional space, at which he has arranged: a small gas burner, a kettle, a hand-grinder, Ethiopian Yirgacheffe beans, a ceramic pour-over. A notebook for brew ratio notes.

He is grinding. The specific, careful rhythm of grinding.

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI comes to stand beside him. He watches Seiko grind.

JOSEPH

(observing the setup)

You know we're between dimensions.

SEIKO

I'm aware.

JOSEPH

The atmospheric pressure in the in-between might affect the—

SEIKO

(not stopping)

I checked. It's close to sea level. I'm adjusting the grind coarser by two percent and using a longer steep. It'll be fine.

JOSEPH

(a pause)

You checked the atmospheric pressure of
the dimensional in-between before we
came through.

SEIKO

I always check. I wanted to know if I
needed to compensate. I needed to
compensate slightly. So I did.

The kettle begins its heat. The dimensional space around
them is the specific, unlocatable geometry of the in-
between: not dark, not light – both at once, canceling each
other into something that is neither and both, a quality of
atmosphere that exists nowhere else.

JOSEPH

Seiko.

SEIKO

Mm.

JOSEPH

Do you understand what we're going
into?

SEIKO

(pouring the first pass, precise, the pour
circular and even)

People who have lost everything and are
fighting something they can't fully
stop yet. A compound that works but

needs to be deployed at scale.
Homelander, Epstein's network, the
variant problem. The need for strategic
alignment across a very unusual team.

(watching the bloom)

SEIKO

Yes. I understand what we're going
into.

JOSEPH

And you're making coffee.

SEIKO

I'm making coffee first. Then we go in.
The two things are not in conflict.

JOSEPH

Why coffee first?

SEIKO

(watching the extraction — the slow pour,
the careful attention)

Because they've been through weeks of
something hard and they're about to go
through something harder. And sometimes
what a person needs before the harder
thing is something that tastes like
someone put care into it.

(he finishes the pour)

SEIKO

Not a speech. Not a strategy briefing.
Just: someone cared enough to make this
well and it tastes like that. That's
the thing.

Joseph looks at the pour-over. At the care in the
preparation. At Seiko, who has carried a burner and a
kettle and a hand-grinder into dimensional space because he
decided the next thing required it.

JOSEPH

(quietly)
You always do this.

SEIKO

I know. It works.

He hands Joseph the first cup.

Joseph takes it. He looks at it. He drinks.

He looks at Seiko over the cup.

JOSEPH

It's good.

SEIKO

(already packing with practiced speed)
I know. Ready?

JOSEPH

I've been ready.

SEIKO

I was waiting for the extraction.

Joseph almost smiles. He goes forward into the in-between. Seiko shoulders his pack — the burner, the kettle, the grinder, all of it, the whole setup — and follows.

ISABELLA comes behind them. She has been here the whole time. She looks forward, at what's ahead.

She follows.

EXT. OUTPOST ROOF — NIGHT — THE ARRIVAL

Post-operation. The team on the roof. Not by plan — by gravity. This is what happens after: people find the roof and the sky and the presence of each other, and they stay there.

The city below. The stars that are not their stars. Seiko Toast's coffee going around — he arrived with the thermos and nobody questioned the thermos because the coffee was excellent and the timing was exactly right.

Then: a light in the sky. Not a star. Moving. Descending with the specific quality of arrival rather than approach.

It touches down on the roof. Three people.

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI. SEIKO TOAST (thermos already open, offering). ISABELLA (at the edge, looking at the city below and then at the people on the roof, with the expression of someone who has watched a thread for forty-two hours and is now standing in it).

Joseph and the team look at each other. The quality of the moment: something that has been building across multiple

dimensions, multiple versions of nearly everything, landing here. On this roof. In this quiet.

JOSEPH

(to Butcher, simply)
You held on.

BUTCHER

(dry, genuine, entirely himself)
Barely.

JOSEPH

That's all it takes.

SEIKO TOAST

(raising the thermos)
Ethiopian Yirgacheffe. If anyone wants.

MM stares at the thermos. Then at Seiko. Then at the thermos.

SEIKO

(to MM specifically)
What? It's good coffee. Moments like
this deserve good coffee.

Kimiko signs to Frenchie. He reads it. He looks at Seiko.
He extends his hand.

FRENCHIE

I'll take some.

SEIKO

(already pouring)

Good man.

ANNIE looks at Joseph. He looks at her. Something passes between them – the specific acknowledgment of people who have been working from the same side of the same problem without knowing about each other.

JOSEPH

(direct)

Your barrier. In the atmosphere. On your Earth.

ANNIE

(quietly)

It didn't work.

JOSEPH

It held long enough.

ANNIE

For what?

JOSEPH

For us to find the anchor. For there to be a signal to find. For the thread to

be intact enough to locate. You bought
time you didn't know you were buying.

Annie holds this. She looks at Hughie beside her. He holds
her hand.

BUTCHER
(to Joseph - direct, practical)
What comes next.

JOSEPH
Homelander is contained but not
finished. Epstein's network is still
operational. The variants are still out
there. And the signal from your Earth-

BUTCHER
What about the signal?

JOSEPH
It's been growing. The dimensional
anchor we detected - it's not
automatic. Something is maintaining it.
Actively. Something on what was your
Earth is still there and is working to
hold the location open.

The team. The roof. The weight of this information.

BUTCHER
(quietly)

You're saying there's something to go back to.

JOSEPH

I'm saying the thread isn't closed. The thread can be followed. What we find at the end of it — that's the next thing.

BUTCHER

When?

JOSEPH

After we deal with what comes between. There's a territory. The Desert Land — the dimensional corridor between the Breaking Point and what comes after. It's the way through. It's also dangerous. We'll need—

BUTCHER

All of us.

Joseph looks at him. He looks at the team. All of them — Butcher, MM, Annie, Hughie, Kimiko, Frenchie, Clint, Natasha, Elena. Ryan, at the edge, talking quietly with Becca. The Deep, with his coffee. A-Train. Lamplighter, still uncertain but still here. Soldier Boy, at the back.

And Seiko, pouring. And Isabella, at the roof's edge, her eyes on what nobody else can see.

JOSEPH

(after a long moment)

All of us.

ISABELLA, at the edge of the roof, looks at the sky. At the dimensional paths she can trace that nobody else can. At what's coming and what's been and what is still to be decided.

ISABELLA

(to the roof, to the night – practical,
clear)

We should get some sleep.

(a beat)

ISABELLA

We leave at dawn.

ACT FIVE: THE LAST SCENE

EXT. OUTPOST ROOF – CONTINUOUS – SLOW PULL BACK

The roof. The team. The night.

The camera pulls back – not quickly, not dramatically. The way you look at something when you want to hold it.

MM on video with Janine. She is showing him something. He is showing her his full attention – not divided, not managed. Just there. He tells her: I'm coming soon. She says: you always say that. He says: I know. This time I mean it differently. She believes him. He ends the call and sits for a moment with the fact that she believed him.

Kimiko and Frenchie. Side by side on a low wall. He is talking – she is watching his hands. Both things are the conversation.

Annie and Hughie. The specific comfort of two people who have stopped being surprised by each other. She leans her head on his shoulder. He doesn't say anything. Neither does she. This is the thing they've been building toward: the ability to be in the same space without needing to fill it.

Maeve/Elena alone with her coffee and the sky. The expression of someone finishing one chapter and not yet knowing what the next one is – and being, for the first time in years, genuinely okay with not knowing. The kind of okay that is its own kind of hard-won peace.

Joseph and Seiko in quiet conversation with Isabella. Plans being made. The in-between, the Desert Land, the thread that leads back to what was Earth. All of it: next.

Ryan and Becca. She is going home. Not tonight – she can't go tonight, there's no home to go to yet. But the thread is there. She can feel it. She's going to follow it. She says this to Ryan. He says: I know. She says: Are you coming? He says, after a pause: After the Desert Land. She says: Okay. I'll be there.

Butcher at the edge of the roof. He is looking at the city below. The lights of a world that is not his world, that has kept them, that is intact.

He takes out his phone. He looks at the photos. The one of Becca. The one of Ryan. The team photo – the same composition as the one on the wall of his Brooklyn apartment, the apartment that was on an Earth that is not there anymore. But here, in his phone. Still here.

He looks at it for a long time. More than three seconds. He doesn't count.

He puts the phone away.

He looks at the city. One breath. One long breath.

He turns back to the roof. To the team. To what's next.

He goes in.

The others, slowly, follow.

The sky finishes its darkening. The city lights come on below. The coffee runs out. The roof empties.

SLOW FADE TO:

"THE COLLECTORS WILL RETURN IN: THE DESERT LAND"

A BOUTAHRI PRODUCTIONS PRESENTATION

Written by Youssef Boutahri

Produced in Casablanca, Morocco

"The evil you cannot see is not in power. It is in the
architecture."

Ce qui n'a pas de fin ne peut pas être perdu.

What has no end cannot be lost.

FINAL FADE TO BLACK.

THE END.

PRODUCTION CREDITS

CREATED & WRITTEN BY

YOUSSEF BOUTAHRI

PRODUCED BY

BOUTAHRI PRODUCTIONS

Casablanca, Morocco

PRODUCTION STYLE

Denis Villeneuve / The Russo Brothers

SCORE

Hans Zimmer

UNIVERSE

The Perfect Joseph Multiversal Saga

INSPIRED BY

The Boys / Breaking Bad / Avengers / The Hunger Games

BRIDGING FILMS

The Devil You Don't Know → The Final War

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EXPANDED SCENES — EPISODES 1-7

THE COLLECTORS: SUPPLEMENTAL MATERIAL

SUPPLEMENT ONE: THE ARCHITECT — EPSTEIN SESSIONS

INT. EPSTEIN'S DOMAIN — THE INNER STUDY — TIME UNKNOWN

A room within a room. The way significant things have a center within their center. Beyond the chandelier and the mahogany and the performed grandeur of the main chamber, there is a study: small, functional, lit by a single lamp that casts a warm and specific circle. A writing desk. A chair behind it. Two chairs facing it, both empty.

EPSTEIN at his desk. He is not doing what he does in the outer room. He is not performing anything here. He is reading. The text is dense — handwritten, in a notation system that combines three languages and a personal cipher that has existed since he was twenty-six and that he has never taught anyone. The text is his record. The full record: everything. Everything that has happened, everything he has caused to happen, and his analysis of the gap between the two.

He reads for a long time. Then he closes the journal. He holds it for a moment — this specific object, this record of everything — and then he puts it in the center of his desk, aligned precisely with the desk's edges. He sits back.

He looks at the ceiling. The study ceiling: low, plastered, no chandelier. He chose this room specifically for the absence of the chandelier. The chandelier is performance. This room has no performance in it.

He speaks to the ceiling.

EPSTEIN

(very quiet – the tone of a man finishing a thought he's been having for a long time)

The thing about architecture is that it outlives its architect. Every architect knows this. The good ones build things they expect to outlive them. The great ones build things they expect to outlive what they understood when they built them. They build things that become other things over time. That's not a flaw. That's the point.

A pause.

EPSTEIN

The evil in a system is in the structure. Not the person who built the structure. The person can be removed. The person can die. The person can be discredited, imprisoned, erased from record. The structure remains. The structure executes itself. The structure does what structures do, which is: persist, replicate, optimize for its own continuation. Nobody has to tell it to. It knows.

He looks at the journal.

EPSTEIN

I have been building structures for thirty years. Not power – structures that hold power in specific configurations. Arrangements.

Architectures. You cannot destroy what I've built by destroying me. The error everyone makes is believing that the enemy is the person at the center. The person at the center is a symbol, an organizing principle, a point of contact. The center isn't the architecture. The center is just where the architecture becomes visible.

He stands. He moves to the single small window — not a view of anything, just: light or its absence. Night outside.

EPSTEIN

They're trying to stop Homelander. Good. Homelander is the visible threat. He is also not the architecture. He is the current iteration of something much older. Something I did not build — something I found, understood, and refined. The outer dark compound is a refinement. A significant one. But the architecture it operates within is not mine. It was there when I arrived.

(a very long pause)

EPSTEIN

What I've done — what they're trying to stop — is make visible what was always there. The evil was always in the architecture. I am simply the person who understood it clearly enough to use it.

He turns from the window. He sits back at the desk. He opens the journal.

EPSTEIN

(looking at the page, something in it –
reading – then, very quietly)

And the question no one has thought to
ask: what do you do with an
architecture whose builder is not its
owner? What do you do when the
structure was built by forces that
predate every person in the room?

He looks at the journal.

EPSTEIN

You find the load-bearing wall. You
identify the single element without
which the structure cannot stand. And
then you make a decision about what you
want to do with that knowledge.

He closes the journal again. He aligns it with the desk
edges again. He sits in the specific stillness of a man who
has arrived at the decision and is living in the space just
before executing it.

He turns off the lamp.

The study: dark.

CUT TO:

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — CORRIDOR — NIGHT

The first time WALTER and HANK are in the same space since Earth-3311. Neither of them acknowledged it when they arrived. They have been operating in different wings of the facility with the specific practiced avoidance of two people who are very good at not doing things they've decided not to do.

This corridor, at this hour (1:17 AM by the facility clocks), was supposed to be empty. They arrived at opposite ends of it simultaneously because the facility's layout has exactly two routes between the research wing and the cafeteria, and they both chose this one.

They stop.

Five meters between them.

HANK holds a file. WALTER holds his glasses case and a mug with something that is now cold and he has been carrying since forgetting it on a bench three hours ago. They look at each other.

The specific quality of two men who have a history that is one of the most complicated histories two people can have, standing in a corridor at 1:17 AM with evidence that both of them can't sleep.

HANK

(after a long moment — not hostile, just honest)

I can go the other way.

WALTER

(also not hostile, also honest)

We could both go the other way. It's a longer route for both of us. Seems inefficient.

Hank looks at him. Walter looks at him.

HANK

(something in his voice that is genuine rather than performed)

You built something here. The compound. Fury walked me through it. I understand about forty percent of it. The forty percent I understand is — I don't have the word for it. It's extraordinary. It's what you always were.

A pause. Walter holds the cold mug.

WALTER

(very carefully)

What I always was. That's a complicated statement, Hank.

HANK

Yeah. It is. I'm saying it anyway.

(a beat)

HANK

You were always that. The chemistry. The intelligence. That was always there. The other stuff that happened — the stuff I spent three years trying to understand and then several more years trying to accept I'd never completely

understand — that was also there. Both things.

WALTER

(the specific, quiet precision of a man addressing something he doesn't discuss, choosing to address it because the hour and the corridor make it possible)

The other stuff that happened had a logic. I have spent a significant amount of time thinking about whether I could have arrived at the same place through a different route. I don't have a clean answer.

HANK

Me neither. About my part in it. I had a part in it.

WALTER

(a beat)

You were doing your job.

HANK

My job wasn't my only driver and we both know that. I wanted to be the one. I needed it to be — there was a thing about me needing it to be something specific. I was very committed to a particular shape for the story.

WALTER

(a pause — the kind that contains
something large and chooses not to open it
fully)

So was I.

They stand in the corridor. 1:17 AM. The cold mug. The
file.

HANK

(after a long time)

Are we—

WALTER

(carefully)

I don't know. I think we're standing in
a corridor on an Earth that isn't ours
having a conversation that neither of
us planned to have, and we're managing
it with more composure than either of
us would have predicted.

HANK

Is that enough?

WALTER

(very quietly)

For tonight. Yes. I think it might be.

They stand in the corridor a moment longer. Then, by
unspoken agreement, they both walk to the cafeteria. They
do not sit together. But they are both in the same room,
getting coffee, not going separate ways.

It is what it is, which at 1:17 AM is its own kind of resolution.

CUT TO:

INT. OUTPOST — MM'S ROOM — 4 AM

MM writes a letter. He has not written a letter since his twenties — since the first deployment, when the expectation of letters was still a thing, before email, before always-on. He found paper in a supply closet. He found a pen. He sat down.

The letter is to Janine. Not a letter for now — she will not read this now, he is not sending this now. This is the other kind of letter: the one you write for the circumstance you're hoping not to create.

He writes for two hours. He covers everything: the things he's proud of, the things he's not, the things he would have done differently, the things he's glad he did exactly as he did them. He writes about her mother. He writes about what Marvin means — not MM, not Mother's Milk, the word before the nickname, the word his grandmother gave him that has lived in him longer than anything Vought ever knew about him.

He writes: You are the most important thing I have ever done and I know that sounds like the kind of thing a parent says, but I want you to understand that I mean it precisely. Not as emotion. As fact. The most important thing I will ever do is be the thing you can rely on. I have tried to be that. I am not sure I always succeeded. I believe I came back far enough, enough times, to qualify.

He writes: The planet shirt. The one with the planet on it. You pointed at it like introducing a friend. I think about that. I think about the confidence of someone who believes that planets deserve introductions. That things that are

massive and real and out there deserve to be pointed at and named. You have that. Keep it.

He writes: If you're reading this because I didn't come back—

He stops. He holds the pen. He looks at the page.

He crosses out that line. He writes instead: I came back. I always came back. You are reading this because I gave it to you on a Tuesday when there was nothing particular happening and I wanted you to have it anyway. Because some things shouldn't wait for circumstances.

He folds the letter. He addresses the envelope in his careful, precise printing — the handwriting he developed in ROTC and that has not changed in twenty-five years because he decided what it should look like and maintained the decision.

He does not seal it. He puts it in the inside pocket of his jacket.

He does not look at it again.

CUT TO:

INT. THE DEEP'S COURT — ATLANTIAN DIMENSION — EXTENDED

More of this dimension. The thing about the place THE DEEP has made: it is genuinely his. Not in the sense that the Seven was his — the Seven was corporate, assigned, a role filled by a specific model of person that the organization chose him to represent. This place — the shell-throne with its cushions, the robes on the hook by the door, the three dolphins who follow him around with magnificent indifference — this is something he built from choice.

The choice is the thing. He has not had many choices. His life before this was a series of positions: recruited,

placed, used, protected badly, exposed, diminished, and finally – when they needed someone whose bad PR was more valuable than his abilities – discarded. He was never asked what he wanted. The asking didn't happen in his category.

AIDE Gregory, who has been here seven months and has not found a way back and has also stopped looking particularly hard, pours tea from a kettle that came from Earth-2397 via the same inexplicable dimensional accident that brought Gregory here. The tea is Darjeeling. The Deep has strong opinions about tea, which surprised Gregory entirely.

DEEP

(looking at correspondence – letters from dimensions he's been working with on trade agreements that are more about community than commerce)

The Luminescent Sea on Earth-4421 wants to establish a communication channel. They say their waters are being affected by dimensional resonance from the outer-dark compound's spread.

AIDE

Do we have the capacity to help?

DEEP

(thinking about it genuinely)

Not yet. But we're connected to Fury's array. If we can give them a frequency to communicate on and pass their data to the monitoring team, that's something.

AIDE

You want to be useful.

DEEP

(a pause — not defensive, just recognizing something)

Yes. I want to be useful. Is that —
that's a normal thing to want. A lot of
people want to be useful.

AIDE

Of course.

DEEP

(more quietly)

I spent a long time wanting to be
important. Important felt like the
goal. It wasn't the goal. I think I was
— I mistook the feeling of being seen
for the feeling of being valued.
They're different feelings. I didn't
know that. I do now.

AIDE

(carefully)

When did you figure it out?

DEEP

(with the honest answer rather than the
managed one)

There was a moment with a dolphin. I
don't want to go into the details
because the details are embarrassing.
But there was a moment with a dolphin
and then there was a moment where a

dolphin looked at me as if it had
assessed me and found me neither
threatening nor interesting, just
present, and I thought: that's what I
want. To be present. To be here and
doing something that isn't about the
being-seen.

Gregory thinks about this.

AIDE

A dolphin told you that.

DEEP

(dry)

Through the medium of profound
disinterest. Yes.

Gregory nods. He pours more tea.

AIDE

I'll set up the communication channel
for Earth-4421.

DEEP

(back to the correspondence — but lighter,
somehow)

Thank you. And Gregory.

AIDE

Sir.

DEEP

Stop calling me sir. I'm not — I'm just
Kevin.

Gregory pauses. This is the fifth time the Deep has said this. Each time he says it, Gregory has found he can't quite do it yet. Not because he doesn't want to.

AIDE

I'll work on it.

DEEP

(returning to letters)
Good.

CUT TO:

INT. OUTPOST — SOLDIER BOY'S ROOM — NIGHT

SOLDIER BOY does not watch television. He does not sketch. He does not write letters or make phone calls or do any of the things that the rest of them do in the hours when sleep doesn't arrive.

He exercises. Not to exhaust himself into sleep — he has discovered that his biology doesn't work that way, hasn't worked that way in decades. He exercises because it is the thing that keeps him on the right side of the line between tolerable and not.

Push-ups. Standard. One hundred. Then another hundred. He doesn't count past two hundred because counting past two hundred is the kind of thing that happens when you're trying to disappear into a number.

He stops. He sits on the floor. He looks at his hands.

His hands: the same hands. The same hands from 1943. The same hands from every year between then and now. The hands that did what they did in Korea, in Vietnam, in the operations nobody named, in the things with the team, with the Boys, the things he chose and the things he was pointed at and chose to do because the pointing was sufficient.

He looks at them.

BECCA knocked last Tuesday. He didn't say anything. She knocked and he didn't say come in and she said through the door: I know you're awake. I know you don't want company. I also know that a specific kind of alone is different from the other kinds. The door's going to stay closed. I'm going to be in the corridor for a few minutes. No pressure.

She stayed in the corridor for eight minutes. He didn't open the door. She went away.

He thought about it for two days. He thought about the specific, undemanding quality of that. The offer of presence without requirement. The way she said I know you don't want company and did not follow it with but, and did not follow it with you should.

He thought: I have never in my life been in the presence of someone who told me I didn't have to do anything and meant it and then demonstrated the meaning.

The thought was bigger than he expected.

He gets up. He goes back to push-ups. He counts differently this time. He counts by the people in the building – each one. He gets to thirteen and stops. He stays at thirteen for a while.

Then he lies on the floor. He looks at the ceiling. He breathes.

He is still there, looking at the ceiling, when the morning comes.

CUT TO:

INT. OUTPOST — JESSE'S TEMPORARY SPACE — NIGHT

JESSE has been given a space that is not exactly a room — a converted storage area off the research wing, with a cot and a lamp and a window that looks out on a wall. He has made it his the way he makes everything his: not by changing it, but by being in it with enough presence that the space conforms to him rather than the other way around.

He is painting.

Nobody gave him paint. He found it — a maintenance supply area, three colors, nothing fancy: white, red, a flat gray. He mixed them into something that is approximately salmon and is not exactly the right color for what he's painting but is closer than nothing.

The wall: a mural. Small — not the side of a building, just the section of wall above the cot. But complete. A design that started as something undefined and has, over the last three days, become a landscape: not New Mexico, not any Earth — some imagined place where the sky is the mixed salmon-gray and the ground is something approximating peace.

He steps back. He looks at it.

It's not his best work. But it's here. It exists in this room that was a storage area and is now a room with a mural, which is different from a storage area in a way that matters.

He lies on the cot. He looks at the mural.

He thinks about what Walter said in the lab. The doing something good thing. He thinks about how Walter said it — the fact that it cost Walter something to say, which is how Jesse knows it was true. Walter only says the things that cost him. Everything else he wraps in explanation, makes

safe with precision. The things that are true, the real ones – those he says quickly, quietly, and they cost him.

Jesse thought about it for four days.

He thinks: Yeah. We did.

He thinks: What do I do with that? What does a person do with that – the doing-something-good? Do you just let it be a thing that happened? Do you hold it? Do you carry it forward?

He looks at the mural. The salmon-gray sky. The imagined ground.

He thinks: You carry it forward. You use it to build the next thing. You make it the starting point instead of the exception.

He closes his eyes. For the first time in three weeks, he falls asleep before the thought is finished.

CUT TO:

INT. OUTPOST – KIMIKO'S ROOM – LATE

Kimiko writes to Frenchie. Not letters – he is down the hall, she could go knock, she sometimes does. These are not letters. These are the other kind of writing: the kind you do for the record, in the language that belongs only to you, the way certain conversations belong only to the people having them.

She uses signs. She writes them as drawn notations – not sign language as a code, but as a personal shorthand, the visual language that belongs to the two of them, the version they developed over eight years that contains shortcuts and references and things that have no formal notation because they emerged from specific moments.

Tonight she writes about: the smell of the facility cafeteria, which is the same regardless of Earth (she has been on three Earths now and the cafeteria smell is consistent across all of them, which she finds either comforting or disturbing depending on the day). The sound of Frenchie sleeping, which she can hear through the shared wall and which she clocked at 2 AM tonight: regular, unhurried, the specific rhythm of a person who fell asleep without difficulty. The fact that he came back. The fact of him being down the hall.

She writes: You came back. I have known you were coming back every single moment since you left. I did not know how I knew this. I know many things about you that I cannot account for. I have stopped trying to account for them. I just know them. And I knew you were coming back.

She writes: What I did not know was what it would feel like when you did. I thought I knew. I have thought about this moment many times. The feeling is different from what I imagined. It is larger. It takes up more space than the imagining had room for. I find that I need to be near you very often. I am working on not standing outside your door when I don't have a reason to knock. It is harder than it sounds.

She draws a frame around what she's written. One continuous line, unbroken. She looks at it.

She adds one drawing beneath: the two of them, from the first safehouse, at the kitchen table before any of this. Him talking. Her not talking. Both of them present. Both of them in a room that contained both of them, which was the beginning of everything.

She closes the notebook. She puts it in the drawer. She looks at the wall.

Then she gets up and goes down the hall. She knocks.

He says something in French that she knows means 'just a second' and then the door opens and she says, signing: I wanted to check that you were okay.

He says: I'm okay. Are you okay?

She signs: I am now.

He looks at her. He understands, as he understands most things she doesn't say. He steps aside. She comes in. They sit in his room – her in the chair, him on the cot – and they talk until four in the morning about nothing specific and everything important.

CUT TO:

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY – FURY'S OFFICE – PRE-DAWN

The facility before anyone else is up. The specific quality of empty corridors when the shift hasn't changed yet. FURY in his office – he never leaves his office, in the sense that his office and his mind are not fully separable. He thinks here. He has thought here, in this office or offices exactly like it, for forty years.

The file on his desk: not the current operation. An old file. Physical – not digital, not stored in any system. The kind of file that exists as paper because the person who created it decided that some information should require physical presence to access.

He reads. He reads for an hour. He closes the file. He looks at it.

Inside: the first dimensional event he ever logged. 1987. A monitor station in Iceland picked up a signal from dimensional space – a signal that turned out to be a V signature from a parallel Earth's Compound V test. He was thirty-one years old and had been with the organization for eight years and had developed, over those eight years, the specific intelligence-agency instinct that separates the anomaly from the noise.

He flagged it. He wrote the analysis. He sent it up the chain.

The chain told him it was instrument error.

He kept the file.

He kept the file for thirty-six years, through every reorganization, every building change, every classification-level shift, every moment when the file could have been legitimately lost. He kept it because he knew what the file was: a record of the first time someone told him he was wrong about a thing he was right about. He kept it so he would never need to explain to anyone why he trusted the anomaly.

Because the anomaly is always real. Every anomaly he has ever flagged has turned out to be real. Not in the way the analysis predicted — never exactly that — but real in the sense of actual, true, a thing that was there and that mattered. The instrument error file opened a dimensional monitoring program. The program found the V signature eleven more times before anyone else believed dimensional signatures were possible. The eleventh time was Homelander.

He closes the file. He puts it in the bottom drawer. He locks the drawer.

He looks at the door.

They're going to win this. He doesn't know what winning looks like at this scale — he never does until the moment arrives. But he knows the pattern: anomaly, flag, trust the anomaly, follow it. He's been following it since he was thirty-one.

He picks up his comm. He checks in with the overnight monitor. He checks the Homelander position feed. He checks the compound delivery status.

Everything where it should be.

He puts the comm down. He sits back. He looks at the ceiling of his office – the fluorescent light, the institutional gray, the ceiling tile in the corner that has been slightly misaligned since the facility was built.

He thinks: when this is done, I'm going to fix that tile.

He won't remember this thought. He never does. But he has it every time. Every single time.

CUT TO:

END OF EXPANSION PACK A

EXPANDED SCENES — EPISODES 8-15

SUPPLEMENT TWO: A-TRAIN — THE SPEED OF MEMORY

EXT. EARTH-2397 — RUNNING — NIGHT

A-TRAIN runs through this city. Not training — just running. The distinction: training has a destination you chose, a metric you're tracking, a data point you're collecting. Running is the other thing. The thing you do when motion is the only tool available for processing.

He runs at a fraction of what he can do. He has learned that full speed is for emergencies and that even for him, full speed all the time is its own kind of damage. He runs at the speed of someone very fast, which is still fast enough that the city becomes a sequence of impressions rather than a place with distinct elements. He prefers this mode. The detail of things is sometimes too much. The impressions are more manageable.

He has been running this route — the perimeter of the ruined sector, through the intact neighborhoods to the east, down to the waterfront and back — for three weeks. Every night. He knows the route in his body the way you know a route you've taken three hundred times. He knows where the pavement changes. He knows the dog at the corner of Eighth and Hartland Avenue who chases him every single night with the enthusiastic futility of an organism that is very committed to a project that has never once succeeded.

He slows for the dog tonight. Not all the way to a stop — he never stops — but enough. The dog catches up. He reaches down without fully stopping and gives it a quick touch on the head. The dog is delighted. The dog has achieved the thing it has been attempting for twenty-two nights. The dog has no idea how this development will affect its future

motivation and frankly does not seem to have considered the question.

He runs.

He is thinking about Popclaw.

He is thinking about Popclaw the way you think about someone you hurt by choosing something else over them — not because you didn't care, but because the something else was larger than what you told yourself it was and you didn't stop it in time and by the time you understood what you were doing you had already done it. He is thinking about her with the specific quality of guilt that doesn't do anything useful — not motivating, not instructive, just present, like weather. The kind of guilt you carry.

He runs and he carries it.

He thinks: after this is over, I will go somewhere I haven't been. Not somewhere fast — somewhere slow. Somewhere that requires me to walk. I will walk there. I will let the walking cost something and find out what it costs and whether I can afford it.

He doesn't know yet if he can afford it.

He runs.

CUT TO:

INT. OUTPOST — COMMON ROOM — LAMPLIGHTER ALONE — 2 AM

LAMPLIGHTER. The couch. A glass of water. He doesn't drink anything else and hasn't for several weeks, not because anyone asked him to but because whatever he experienced in wherever he was gave him an extreme disinclination toward anything that altered cognition. He has enough to manage with unaltered cognition.

He is looking at his hands. This has become his thing. Other people look at windows, at stars, at files and plans and photographs. He looks at his hands.

He does not use them for what they were for anymore. That is the decision: the hands that burned things do not burn things. He has lit no fires — not a candle, not a match, not a lighter for anyone's cigarette. He finds that he has an abundance of care about this. He would prefer that the hands do something else.

He does not know what else they can do. He is, slowly, at the pace of something cautious, trying to find out.

He volunteers in the facility kitchen when there is food prep happening. He is not good at it. He is learning. The FACILITY COOK — a woman named Dara who has worked this kitchen for eleven years and has an extremely direct manner of instruction — has told him that he approaches chopping as if he's afraid of the knife, which is a notable quality in someone who has what is arguably the most powerful offensive capability on the team.

He told Dara: I'm not afraid of knives. I'm afraid of the word good at, applied to things that cause harm. I'm trying to get to good at something else.

Dara looked at him for a long time. Then she showed him how to dice an onion.

He is learning to dice onions.

He looks at his hands. He thinks: there is a version of this where what happened is not the last thing these hands are good at. The version where the next thing accumulates until it has enough weight to counterbalance. He doesn't know how much weight is required. He suspects it's more than he has at the moment.

He suspects the moment is the point. The accumulation is the point. Not the destination.

He finishes the water. He rinses the glass. He puts it on the drying rack.

He goes back to bed.

CUT TO:

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY — SECURE MEETING ROOM — DAY

THANOS and FURY. A meeting neither of them arranged through normal channels because there are no normal channels for this meeting. THANOS came to the facility. He did not enter through any entrance. He was simply present in this room when Fury arrived, and the sensors registered it two minutes after the fact, which is consistent with how Thanos has always operated in environments that believe themselves secure.

FURY, looking at Thanos across the table, has the specific expression of a man who has been surprised exactly twice in forty years and is managing the third time with the practiced control of someone who doesn't intend to register it.

FURY

(setting his coffee down very deliberately)

You could have knocked.

THANOS

(with genuine interest rather than malice)

I was curious whether the sensors had improved. They've improved significantly. Two minutes is better than the last time I was in a SHIELD facility.

FURY

When were you last in a SHIELD—

THANOS

1998. A facility in sub-Saharan Africa.
Your sensors at the time took eleven
minutes. You've made meaningful
progress.

Fury absorbs this.

FURY

(evenly)

Why are you here?

THANOS

The outer dark compound. I have an
interest in its management.

FURY

(careful)

The compound White built can neutralize
the outer dark amplification. That's
the relevant management strategy.

THANOS

For Homelander specifically. What I'm
referring to is the outer dark compound
as a class of problem. White has solved
it for one application. The outer dark

material is not limited to one application.

Fury looks at him.

FURY

How many applications.

THANOS

Epstein's current network has three deployment-ready applications. I've found evidence of development-stage work on two more. The compound White built will counter two of the three deployment-ready versions. The third requires a different approach.

FURY

(slowly)

You've been tracking Epstein's network.

THANOS

I have an interest in power that operates outside observable physics. It's a personal interest that predates this situation. When the outer dark material first appeared in dimensional monitoring data, I identified it as a matter that required attention.

FURY

Why didn't you tell anyone?

THANOS

(the specific, quiet answer of someone who has given this the thought it deserves)

I considered whether telling anyone was productive. I concluded that the corrective would be more effective if it emerged from the people most directly affected by the threat rather than from me.

FURY

You watched.

THANOS

(honest)

I observed. And I prepared the information I would need to contribute at the point where contribution became necessary.

FURY

(a beat, dry)

That point being now.

THANOS

That point being: your team has addressed the primary threat and is about to face secondary and tertiary threats that the current White compound doesn't cover. Yes. This is the point.

Fury looks at him. Fury has the extraordinary ability, developed over forty years, to look at something without reacting to it until he's decided what his reaction should

be. He uses this ability now, for approximately thirty seconds.

FURY

What do you need from us?

THANOS

(a very slight inclination of his head – the closest he comes to acknowledging that this is the right question)

The dimensional monitoring archive. All of it. And White. I'd like to work with White.

FURY

White's not going to enjoy that.

THANOS

No. But he'll find it useful. And he places utility above enjoyment when it matters. That's a quality I respect.

FURY

(standing, to get the coffee because this conversation will be longer than he had prepared for)

I'll introduce you.

THANOS

(already looking at the archive files on the wall monitor – he activated them before Fury arrived)

I've already reviewed the first three years. You can skip that section.

Fury looks at the wall monitor. The archive files, open, three years of data annotated in a notation system that is not Walter's and is not SHIELD's and is distinctly Thanos's.

He looks at this for a moment.

FURY

(very quietly)
Of course you have.

CUT TO:

INT. OUTPOST — TRAINING ROOM — DAY

ANNIE and RYAN. The training room: pads, weights, a mat, the equipment of people who don't sit still well. They've been here for an hour. Annie working a circuit she designed. Ryan working a different circuit he designed in consultation with nobody because consultation implies asking for help with something he has decided to figure out himself.

They've been working in the same space without talking about anything specific. The comfortable parallel company of people who don't need a stated reason to be in the same room.

ANNIE stops her circuit. She drinks water. She looks at Ryan — he's on the last set of something, focused, working hard. Not training in the sense of pushing toward a limit. Training in the sense of preparing for a specific application.

ANNIE

(when he finishes)

You've been working the left-side
approach pattern for three weeks.

RYAN

(reaching for his own water)

Yeah.

ANNIE

That's the angle for the backup dose
delivery.

RYAN

(a beat)

Yeah.

ANNIE

You've run it two hundred times.

RYAN

Two hundred and seventeen.

Annie looks at him. She sits on the weight bench.

ANNIE

You know the backup dose is just in
case everything else fails.

RYAN

(sitting on the floor across from her)
I know.

ANNIE
And that your job is to hold it until I
call for it.

RYAN
I know.

ANNIE
(carefully)
Two hundred and seventeen times is
preparation for going in, not for
holding back.

RYAN
(the specific honest precision of a
seventeen-year-old who has thought about
something carefully and arrived at a
position he can defend)
Yeah. Both things are true. I'm holding
back because that's the assignment and
the assignment is right. I'm also
preparing for the moment when the
assignment changes. That's not the same
as not following the assignment.

Annie looks at him.

ANNIE
(quietly)
Who taught you to think like that?

RYAN

Butcher taught me that the plan is the plan until the plan changes. Becca taught me that the plan changes when you're not prepared for the change to be right. Preparation covers both.

A pause.

ANNIE

(with feeling, careful)

Ryan. You're a good person. I want to say that plainly because I don't say it enough to you and it's true and the truth is worth saying.

He looks at her. He's seventeen and he's carrying more than seventeen years' worth of things and he processes the statement with the seriousness it deserves.

RYAN

(quiet),)

Thank you.

ANNIE

(back to her circuit)

Two hundred and eighteen.

He gets up. He starts the circuit again. She works hers.

The room. The work. The two of them.

CUT TO:

SUPPLEMENT THREE: THE REAL MEETING — EPSTEIN AND HOMELANDER

INT. THE OUTER DARK — EPSTEIN'S DOMAIN — BEFORE THE FINALE

The first time they are in the same room. Not a projection. The actual room. The mahogany, the chandelier, the prism. Epstein at the head of the table. The chair at the far end left empty — Homelander has been standing since he arrived. The standing communicates something. Whether it communicates deference or refusal to defer is the specific ambiguity of the gesture.

The compound is working in Homelander — the outer dark material still integrated, the amplification still active. From where Epstein sits, Homelander appears entirely himself. From within Homelander, the compound is a frequency he can now feel separately from his own biology. He has been learning to feel this separation for the past three weeks. He has not told Epstein.

EPSTEIN

(turning the glass)

You dismissed the variants.

HOMELANDER

Yes.

EPSTEIN

That wasn't the instruction.

HOMELANDER

No. It wasn't.

Epstein sets the glass down.

EPSTEIN

Explain the deviation.

HOMELANDER

(standing, looking at Epstein — the
assessment still happening)

The deviation was: I don't want to
destroy them. They are — they're like
mirrors. Imperfect ones. But mirrors.
And I've been —

(he stops)

HOMELANDER

I've been in the outer dark. I know
what it does to perception. I know what
happens to self-knowledge when you're
in a place that has no reflection. You
come back unable to see yourself
clearly. The variants — for the first
time since the resurrection — I could
see what I am from outside it.

EPSTEIN

(a pause of genuine calculation —
recalibrating),)

And what do you see?

HOMELANDER

(the answer he has been working toward for weeks)

Someone who has been in pain since before I knew the word for it. Someone who was made to solve a problem that couldn't be solved by what I was made with. Someone who needed — someone who needed something ordinary, something that should have been available, and who had no access to it and was not given any help with the absence, and who expressed the absence in ways that became increasingly untenable.

(a long pause)

HOMELANDER

I'm not saying this is an excuse. I'm saying it's an explanation. The distinction matters to me.

EPSTEIN

(very still, the precise stillness of a man who has heard something he didn't expect and is deciding what it means)

Who taught you that distinction?

HOMELANDER

Ryan. Becca's son.

EPSTEIN

Butcher's boy.

HOMELANDER
(correcting — this matters to him)
Ryan.

Epstein picks up the glass again. He turns it.

EPSTEIN
The compound White built. You're aware
of it.

HOMELANDER
I'm aware of it.

EPSTEIN
And your position on its use.

HOMELANDER
(looking at Epstein with the specific,
unhurried attention of someone who has
made a decision and is preparing to
communicate it)
I'm going to let them use it.

The room.

The chandelier turns.

Epstein does not react. His face: nothing. His hands: still
on the glass, steady. What happens behind the face is not
available to the room.

A very long pause.

EPSTEIN

(very carefully)

You're choosing to undergo the counter-compound.

HOMELANDER

I'm choosing to let them use it. That's not the same as choosing to undergo it voluntarily. The distinction is important.

EPSTEIN

(a long pause — understanding what it means)

You've worked out the operation. The eleven doses. The twelve-minute window. You've worked it out.

HOMELANDER

I've been tracking the compound's development for three weeks. White is extraordinary. The delivery mechanism is sound. The execution will work if the team executes correctly.

EPSTEIN

You could stop it.

HOMELANDER

(quiet, final)

I'm choosing not to.

Epstein looks at him. The first time in this series that Epstein looks at something without having decided what to

think about it before looking. The decision is still forming. The face: nothing. The eyes: everything.

EPSTEIN

(after a very, very long pause – not anger, not defeat, something harder to name: the recalculation of a man who built for every scenario and has encountered the scenario he didn't build for)

You've made a choice that I didn't account for.

HOMELANDER

(something moves in his face – the shadow of something that in another life might have been called peace)

Yes.

EPSTEIN

(turning the glass one final time – setting it down for the last time in this scene, with the same precision as always)

'The evil you cannot see is not in power. It is in the architecture.'

(a beat – the longest beat in the series)

EPSTEIN

I built the architecture. I have built it very carefully over a very long time. Every variable accounted for. Every contingency mapped.

(he looks at Homelander — the direct look,
the one that doesn't perform anything)

EPSTEIN

And yet. Here you stand. In my
architecture. Choosing outside the
plan.

(a very small pause — the smallest pause
in the scene is the most significant)

EPSTEIN

(almost to himself)

The variable that can't be mapped. The
variable that was always there. One
person choosing otherwise.

He says this not with fury. Not with defeat. With the
quality of a scientist observing a result that falsifies a
theory he committed to — the specific, rare, costly honesty
of an intelligence that can process being wrong.

He picks up the glass. He raises it slightly.

Not a toast. Something else. Something that has no name.

EPSTEIN

(looking at the glass — not at Homelander
— at the glass, at the light in it)

The architecture continues. You should
know that. What you've chosen changes
the current configuration. It doesn't
change the architecture. The
architecture doesn't require your
participation.

HOMELANDER

I know.

EPSTEIN

And?

HOMELANDER

(the simplest answer, the one that has
always been the truth)

And I'm choosing anyway. That's the
point of a choice.

Epstein looks at the glass. The light in the crystal. The
chandelier turning above.

He sets the glass down.

He does not align it with its previous position this time.

He lets it rest where it lands.

EPSTEIN

(very quietly — a man completing a thought
he has been having his entire life and
arriving at it now, unexpectedly, in this
room)

From one weakness was born infinite
power.

(a very long pause)

EPSTEIN

I always thought I understood what that meant. I built twenty years around my understanding of what that meant.

He looks at Homelander.

EPSTEIN

(with something that has no precedent in any of his previous scenes – honesty without armor)

I may have understood it wrong.

HOMELANDER looks at him. The longest look.

Then he goes. Not quickly. He goes the way he came in – through the door, like a person. Not through a wall, not through the ceiling. Through the door, which he closes behind him. Carefully.

Epstein alone.

The chandelier. Three rotations per minute.

He picks up the glass. He holds it. He turns it.

He stops turning it.

He sets it down.

He looks at where it has landed, which is not where it usually goes.

He leaves it there.

FADE TO BLACK – END OF SUPPLEMENT THREE

**SUPPLEMENT FOUR: AFTER THE OPERATION — WHAT THE TEAM
CARRIES HOME**

INT. OUTPOST — VARIOUS ROOMS — NIGHT AFTER OPERATION

Post-operation night. The specific silence of a building full of people who have done something and survived it and are now in the process of understanding what the surviving means.

ELENA — MAEVE — sits in her room with her boots on and the lights off. Four cracked ribs. The ribs have been addressed by the facility medic. The medic said: you should rest. She said: yes. She is resting with her boots on because taking her boots off felt like a thing she wasn't ready to do yet. The transition between operational and not-operational is a threshold she needs to cross deliberately and the boots are where the threshold lives. She'll take them off when she's ready.

The four approaches. She ran all four. She did what she said she would do. The thing about doing what you said you would do when what you said you would do was hard: the fact of it doesn't get smaller. It sits in your chest and it does not get smaller. It doesn't make you invincible. It doesn't protect you. It doesn't change the ribs or what was required to earn them. But it doesn't get smaller.

She sits with this. Her ribs. Her boots. The dark room.

Then she takes off the boots. One, then the other. She puts them beside the bed. She lies back.

She looks at the ceiling.

She is going to be okay. Not tonight — tonight is for being in the aftermath of the operation and letting it be what it is. But she is going to be okay, and she knows it, and the knowing is, for tonight, enough.

FRENCHIE and KIMIKO on the roof. He's talking. He's been talking for forty minutes. Not about anything in particular – about a film he watched in 2019 that he maintains is underrated, about the specific taste of a cheese he had once in Lyon that he has never been able to replicate, about the name of the street in Marseille where he grew up, which is a street with a name that doesn't translate well into English and which he describes in detail including the exact quality of the afternoon light on the corner building at four PM in September.

Kimiko listens. She signs occasionally – small responses, agreements, one question about the cheese. She is not trying to help him process. She's letting him talk because talking is what he does after something large and she is the person he does it with and she has learned, over years, that being the person someone does their processing with is its own form of care. The most necessary form.

Eventually he stops. The talking done. They sit quietly.

She signs: Are you okay?

He says: Are you?

She signs: Yes.

He says: Then I am.

She looks at him. She signs: That's not how that works.

He grins – the Frenchie grin, the one that means he knows exactly how it works and is choosing the other version. She knows this. She signs: but okay.

He puts his arm around her shoulders. She allows it. They look at the night city together.

BUTCHER with Ryan. The landing bay, where they end up after everything that matters. He tells Ryan about Becca when he first met her – not the story Ryan has, the story Billy has. The earlier one. The one where he was twenty-four and

he walked into a room and met someone who seemed to know exactly which part of him he was working hardest to hide and didn't say anything about it, just — acknowledged it by not making a production of it. Seeing it without using it. He has only told this story twice and both times were to Ryan.

Ryan listens. When Billy stops, Ryan says: She still does that.

Billy says: Yeah. She does.

Ryan says: So do I.

Billy looks at him. He says: Yeah. You do.

The bay. The night. The Quinjet.

Billy reaches out and grabs the back of Ryan's neck, one quick grip, the way you'd grab a kid's neck when the word you're trying to say is too large for the moment. Ryan doesn't flinch. He just nods.

That's the scene.

SEIKO TOAST outside. A new kettle he found. He is making coffee for whoever wakes up earliest. He has been doing this every day at the facility — the coffee is always there when the first person arrives, always good, always the right amount. Nobody has asked him why. He has not explained. It's the kind of thing that doesn't require explanation. It's care in the form of hot water and good beans and the attention to do it right every single morning regardless of what happened the night before.

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI comes out. He is the first. He always is. He finds Seiko here.

JOSEPH

(looking at the kettle)
You haven't slept.

SEIKO
I slept for three hours. It was
sufficient.

JOSEPH
And you got up to make coffee.

SEIKO
(finishing the pour, handing Joseph the
cup first),)
The team will be up in an hour and a
half. The coffee requires twenty
minutes plus brew time. The math
dictated the schedule.

JOSEPH
(taking the cup, looking at him)
You take care of people, Seiko.

SEIKO
(sitting down, his own cup in hand)
Someone has to.

JOSEPH
You don't have to.

SEIKO

(a beat — the beat of a man considering whether to say what he actually thinks and deciding to)

That's what makes it worth doing. The 'don't have to' part. If you had to, it's a task. If you don't have to, it's a choice. And choices are — choices mean something.

Joseph drinks his coffee. Seiko drinks his. The dawn coming. The city below. The team inside, sleeping or awake, each in their version of the aftermath.

JOSEPH

What comes next.

SEIKO

The Desert Land. Then, if everything holds, home.

JOSEPH

(looking at the dawn)

Is it still home? After everything?

SEIKO

(without hesitation)

It's still the place. The place is always there. What we make of it after — that's what we get to decide.

Joseph holds the cup. He holds what Seiko said.

The dawn comes in.

The coffee is excellent.

The team, one by one, comes out to find it.

FADE TO BLACK.

END OF EXPANSION PACK B

EXPANDED SCENES — DEEP UNIVERSE THREADS

SUPPLEMENT FIVE: WHAT HOMELANDER SAW IN THE OUTER DARK

INT. THE OUTER DARK — NON-LINEAR TIME — FLASHBACK / RECOVERED MEMORY

We have not been here. Not exactly. The outer dark is not a location in any cartographic sense — it is the absence of location, which is different from being nowhere. Nowhere implies that somewhere is the other option. The outer dark is the place that doesn't organize itself into locations because location requires a reference point and the outer dark has none.

It has duration. That's what it has. Not time — time is too organized, time has before and after, time has a direction. Duration is the thing before time, the raw material from which time is later built. In duration, things persist. In duration, everything that happened is happening and everything that will happen is also happening, and the skill — the terrible, essential, slowly-developed skill — is learning to stand in the middle of all of it and not fragment.

HOMELANDER learned this skill. Not quickly. Not safely. Over the duration that Epstein measured as four years, two months, eleven days, though in the outer dark the measurement has no anchor. He learned it the way you learn the only skill available in a place: by having no other option.

CLOSE ON: what he saw.

He saw Ryan at seven. The specific afternoon — a Wednesday, late September, the light the way late September light is, already turning away from summer. Ryan in the yard of the first safe house, learning to catch. Not throwing, not

doing anything impressive. Catching. The specific, uncelebrated act of a child's hand closing on something tossed at it. He saw this – not because it was significant, because there was nothing significant about it. He saw it because the outer dark gives you everything, uncurated, without emphasis, and the unemphasized things are the ones that stay.

He saw Becca. The way she looked at Ryan when Ryan didn't know she was looking. The specific private quality of that look – the look of a parent for a child in the moments the child isn't performing for anyone, isn't aware of being observed, is just – themselves. He watched Becca watching Ryan in that way and understood something about watching that he had not understood before. He had never been watched that way. The watching he received was always attended by something – expectation, judgment, hunger, audience. Never the pure kind. The kind where the watching is just: the person you love, being alive, and you're grateful for it.

He saw the Vought lab. He was eight. He knew what he was. He did not know what he was supposed to be and there was nobody to explain it in a language he had access to. He saw himself at eight with forty-seven years of subsequent knowledge and he understood, in the outer dark, in the duration, that the eight-year-old in the lab was doing the only thing available: surviving in a context that was not built for survival.

He saw milk. This is the image the outer dark returned to most. The specific, recurring image of milk: the thing that the eight-year-old wanted, the thing that was withheld during a session to assess biological need, the thing that he reached for and could not reach. Something so ordinary. Something so small. The image of it returned in the outer dark at intervals that had no pattern – not punishment, not instruction. Just: here it is again. The ordinary thing that was withheld. The specific gap between need and provision that became the wound.

He saw Ryan again. Ryan at seventeen. In the parking structure. The words: trying is its own kind of thing. Even when it's late.

He saw himself choose.

This was not a recovered memory. He was not in the outer dark when he chose. He chose in the parking structure. But in the outer dark, in the duration, in the place where all time is happening, he could see the moment of choosing from outside it. He could see what the choosing looked like from a position that didn't have skin in it.

It looked like: a man, at the edge of something, deciding to go the other way.

That's what it looked like.

That was what he saw.

CUT TO:

**SUPPLEMENT SIX: THE SIGNAL — WHAT WAS BROADCASTING FROM
THEIR EARTH**

**EXT. THEIR EARTH — THE RUINS — SIMULTANEOUS WITH SERIES
EVENTS**

What Annie's signal was.

Not automated. Not emergency infrastructure. Not a maintenance broadcast. The signal was a person.

FRENCHIE.

Before the outer dark brought him to Earth-15600, before the dimensional transit that the sensors couldn't

categorize, before he appeared in the medical bay and lay down on a bed and waited: he was here. On their Earth.

In the ruins.

He had a communication array. He built it from what was left – salvaged equipment from a SHIELD sub-station that survived because it was underground, because the designer had thought about what survives things and built accordingly. He built the array. He calibrated it. He found the dimensional frequency that would carry a signal toward where the Quinjet had gone.

He broadcast.

He broadcast for twenty-two days before the outer dark took him through. Twenty-two days of maintaining a signal in the ruins of an Earth he was the last person standing on, broadcasting into dimensional space, keeping the location alive.

The signal was: I AM HERE. THIS PLACE IS HERE. THE LOCATION IS HELD. COME BACK.

He didn't know if they could hear it. He didn't know if the frequency was right. He didn't know if anyone was looking. He broadcast anyway.

Because: what else do you do in the ruins of your world? You maintain the signal. You tell the dimensional space that the place was real and it was here and it is here and it is not finished.

The outer dark found him on day twenty-two. He didn't choose to go – the transit was involuntary in the way that the outer dark is always involuntary, it takes what it takes. But he kept broadcasting for as long as he was there. The equipment was self-sustaining after the first seventy-two hours. He built it that way.

The signal continued without him.

It continues now.

CLOSE ON: the equipment in the underground sub-station. The screens. The readouts. The broadcast, patient and continuous, carrying forward:

THIS PLACE IS HERE. THE LOCATION IS HELD. COME BACK.

CUT TO:

SUPPLEMENT SEVEN: FIRST LOOK — THE DESERT LAND

EXT. THE DESERT LAND — DIMENSIONAL CORRIDOR — DUSK

The Desert Land. Not a desert in the geographic sense — not sand, not heat, not the particular emptiness of a place that was once more and had its water taken. A dimensional corridor: the space between collapsed realities, the place where dimensions come to finish. Everything that ends in dimensional space ends here before it disperses. It leaves something. It leaves geometry — the skeleton of what it was, the angles and proportions of the reality that used to be, without the substance that made it real.

It looks like: vast. And like a thing that was built by something that understood scale very differently from anything human-built. The horizon is too far away. The sky is the color of late dusk everywhere simultaneously, everywhere at once, the specific purple-amber that any single Earth sky only achieves for seven minutes. Here it is permanent. It is always seven minutes to whatever comes after.

JOSEPH and SEIKO walk into it.

They walk for a while.

SEIKO has his pack. The burner is in there. The kettle. Of course the kettle.

JOSEPH

(looking at the horizon — the too-far horizon)

It's bigger than the briefing material suggested.

SEIKO

(looking at the sky — the permanent dusk)

The briefing material was a two-dimensional projection. Things that exist in three dimensions plus dimensional layering don't reduce well.

JOSEPH

Do you know how to navigate it?

SEIKO

(reaching into his pack — pulling out a device that is his own design, built in the facility lab over the last two weeks, annotated in his handwriting)

Navigation requires a reference point. I built a device that uses the compound resonance signatures as fixed points. If the signatures are stable, we can navigate. If they're not stable—

JOSEPH

Then?

SEIKO

Then we navigate by feel. Which I'm
also prepared for.

Joseph looks at the device. He looks at the landscape. He
looks at Seiko.

JOSEPH

You built a backup navigation system
for the backup navigation system.

SEIKO

(with quiet certainty)

I build what the situation requires.
The Desert Land has never been
navigated by anyone with a documented
successful round trip. I want to make
sure we have redundancy.

JOSEPH

Nobody's done it before.

SEIKO

Correct.

JOSEPH

And you're—

SEIKO

The first attempt that had adequate
preparation. Yes.

Joseph looks at the landscape one more time. The permanent dusk. The geometry of ended things. The vastness.

JOSEPH

(stepping forward)

Okay.

SEIKO

(beside him, device in hand)

Okay.

They walk forward into the Desert Land.

ISABELLA watches from the threshold – she can see the threshold, where this place begins, where the geometry changes from ordinary space to the ended-things space. She watches them go in. She can see both paths ahead of them: the one that works and the one that doesn't. She has seen both. She knows which one they're on.

She steps in after them.

ISABELLA

(to herself – to the space – to whatever
records things in the space between
things)

Come on then.

She follows them in.

The threshold closes behind her.

The Desert Land holds them: three people, the device, the pack with the kettle, and whatever preparation is sufficient for a place no one has navigated before.

THE DESERT LAND — COMING IN THE PERFECT JOSEPH SAGA

FADE TO BLACK.

CODA: THE ARCHITECTURE OF CHOICE

INT. THE OUTER DARK — EPSTEIN'S STUDY — FINAL SCENE

Epstein. The study. The lamp. The journal.

He writes. He writes the record of what he didn't account for. He writes it carefully, in the notation system that combines three languages and the personal cipher. He writes it because the record requires it.

He writes: Variable not accounted for in the original architecture: the capacity for the primary agent to choose against type when type was believed to be structurally determined. Foundational assumption error: that biological mandate operates as determinism in all cases. What Homelander demonstrated: that the mandate is a pressure, not a determination. That pressure can be, under specific conditions, chosen against.

He writes: Condition that enabled the choice: the accumulation of human relationship over time — specifically, the relationship with Ryan Butcher. The relationship was not eliminated because its elimination was not assessed as a strategic priority. Error in assessment: underestimating the structural load that a single human relationship can bear over time. Correction for future

models: no relationship should be assessed as negligible. Every attachment, however small, is load-bearing in the structure of a person.

He stops. He reads what he's written. He looks at it.

He writes: The architecture continues. The design is correct. The error was in a single variable estimate. The architecture is large enough to absorb the error and continue. The Desert Land phase is unaffected. The long plan is unaffected.

He closes the journal. He aligns it. He turns off the lamp.

Dark.

In the dark, very quietly, to himself, to the room, to whatever is in the dark with him:

EPSTEIN

(in the dark — the voice of a man who is never fully in the dark, who carries his own light the way the deep-sea fish carries its light, from within, because that is where it lives)

'From one weakness was born infinite power.'

(a pause — the beat of a man who has just, for the first time, heard his own sentence with different ears)

EPSTEIN

(more quietly still)

Yes. But the weakness I was referring to was the wrong one. I was looking at the right sentence and reading the wrong word.

The dark holds this. The chandelier, outside the study door, turns. Three rotations per minute.

Epstein sits in the dark for a very long time.

He picks up the journal. He opens it. He turns the lamp back on.

He writes one more line:

Revise the model. Revise the model. Revise.

FINAL FADE TO BLACK.

END OF THE COLLECTORS — SEASON ONE

"What has no end cannot be lost."

Ce qui n'a pas de fin ne peut pas être perdu.

THE PERFECT JOSEPH MULTIVERSAL SAGA CONTINUES

EXPANDED SCENES — FINAL SUPPLEMENT

DEEP CUTS, EXTENDED BATTLES, THEMATIC RESONANCE

SUPPLEMENT EIGHT: THE FULL BATTLE — EPISODE TWELVE EXTENDED

EXT. THE FALLEN CITY — THE OPERATION IN FULL — EXTENDED SEQUENCE

The battle again. But from the inside. From each position simultaneously. The way a battle actually is — not a sequence of events but a collection of simultaneous experiences that only become a sequence in retrospect, in the telling, in the reconstruction from nine different sets of eyes.

FROM CLINT BARTON'S POSITION — NORTHWEST CORNER, HIGH

He doesn't call what he does from here seeing. He calls it reading. You see with your eyes. You read with your whole body — the way light changes, the way shadow moves differently when something disturbs the air it moves through, the way a target's weight shifts before the weight shift becomes visible. He has been reading for thirty years. He has been reading battlefields for twenty-five of those years. The specific, hard-won skill of staying calm enough in a situation that is genuinely not calm to read it.

His position: a ruined building, sixth floor. Three walls standing. The fourth open to the plaza below. He chose this position three days ago — walked it, timed it, understood the angles. When you do your thinking before the moment, the moment goes faster and cleaner.

He watches Homelander arrive in the plaza. He watches his body language. Not the power — he can't measure the power, nobody except Frenchie's sensors can measure the power. He reads the body language. The set of the shoulders: load-bearing, weight accepted. The position of the hands: at rest, which in this context is a choice, not a default. The way his feet land: both even. Not aggressive — prepared. There's a difference and Clint knows it by now.

He says into comms, very quietly: He's not hostile. He's waiting.

Nobody responds because nobody disagrees.

He tracks Elena's approach. He has been tracking Elena in training for six weeks and has deep respect for what she does with the knowledge of Homelander's response patterns. What she does is: she operates at the intersection of perfect information and acceptable risk, which is the narrowest place to operate and also the most effective. He watches her take the first position. He watches the dose go in.

CLOSE ON CLINT: the readout on the small display mounted on his forearm. 31%. The number he's been calculating toward for six weeks.

He starts his clock.

His arrows, in sequence: the interference shot at the water main (his adaptation from what Katniss described about redirecting discharge — two people from very different disciplines finding the same physics); the spacing shots that buy the angles; the structural shot at the damaged building (a risk calculation he made three days ago and which he committed to fully, which is the only way to make a risk calculation work).

The Gauntlet interference shot: this is the one. The sound frequency shot — he built the arrow himself, in the facility workshop, from materials he found in three different storage areas. He had to ask Walter twice about the frequency. Walter gave him more information than he

asked for, which is how Walter works, and all of it was useful. He made seven versions of the arrow. He brought four. He needs one.

He fires.

He watches the Gauntlet go dark for two seconds – three, actually, the estimate was two, the result is three, which is one of the moments where you are genuinely glad to have been slightly wrong.

He sees Butcher in the gap. He sees the dose go in.

31% becomes 91%.

CLOSE ON CLINT: he closes his eyes for exactly one second. One second of: this is what we built toward. Then he opens them. Back to reading.

FROM KIMIKO'S POSITION – GROUND LEVEL, MOVING

Her experience of the battle is: motion. Pure, committed, everything-she-has motion. She has been moving since Elena's first approach and she will be moving until the window closes. The motion is the thing – she doesn't think during it, she doesn't have to. Everything she needs to know for this operation went in during training, during the hundred-and-seventeen practice runs, during the weeks of working with her own timing until her timing and Elena's timing and Starlight's timing all became a single larger timing that she is now executing.

Three doses. Her three. Delivered at 2.8 seconds, 2.6 seconds, 2.9 seconds from target – the variation in the third one is because Homelander is adapting, his counter is getting faster, which is the thing Frenchie warned them about and which they prepared for. She adjusted by half a second. The adjustment worked.

She takes a hit on the third approach. Not bad – he's at 91% disruption when it connects, which means the hit is at

a small fraction of what it would normally be. It's still enough to put her down for four seconds. Four seconds in a twelve-minute window costs something. She calculates it in the air, before she lands. She lands, already calculating. She does the math.

She is up in 3.1 seconds.

She is back in position in 4.2 seconds.

She signs to nobody visible: WE'RE OKAY. We have the window. The math holds.

She keeps moving.

FROM NATASHA'S POSITION — SOUTHWEST APPROACH, CONSTANT PRESSURE

Her job in this operation is not to deliver compound. Her job is to be present in Homelander's attention without being the thing he chooses to eliminate. The way you run interference in a physical system: you are the cost of doing something else. Every time he could commit to eliminating her, the cost of that commitment is another angle opens up for the compound deliveries.

This is a task that requires the specific courage of being the distraction rather than the solution. The courage of operating in a system where your value is negative space: the space you occupy in his attention that isn't occupied by the thing he could be doing instead.

She has done this for twenty-five years in various forms. She has been the distraction, the misdirection, the counter-pressure. She is very good at it. Being very good at it has a cost — the cost is knowing that your excellence is expressed as absence rather than presence, which is a strange thing to build your identity on. She has thought about this. She has arrived somewhere with it.

She keeps Homelander's attention in her corner for six of the twelve minutes. In those six minutes: Elena delivers two doses, Kimiko delivers three, Butcher delivers one, Annie delivers two. Seven of the eleven doses delivered while Natasha keeps the corner. She calculates it afterward.

She is the most efficient person in this operation. She is also the person nobody will think of when they tell this story. She has made her peace with this. The peace took a while.

FROM FRENCHIE'S POSITION — MOBILE MONITORING, THREE BLOCKS

He watches through screens and does not act. This is the hardest thing he has done in a career that has contained several hard things.

The screens: twelve feeds. Each team member with a biosensor that transmits position, vitals, operational status. The compound readout on a separate monitor. The timer on a third. He processes all twelve feeds simultaneously and communicates the relevant information without processing lag. He has been training this specific skill — the parallel attention, the selective communication — for six weeks.

When Kimiko goes down for 3.1 seconds, his hands go to the comm and then stop. She's up. He doesn't comm. He calculates the impact on the remaining window. He adjusts the readout.

When the Gauntlet goes dark: he sees it on the energy readings before Clint reports it. He is already tracking the gap. He is already ready for the 91% reading when it comes.

The timer. He watches the timer with the specific, patient dread of a man who has done everything he can do and is now watching a number count and knows that the number is either

going to be enough or not, and that whether it is enough is no longer in his control, because the things in his control are done.

The number counts. The window holds.

When Ryan deploys the backup dose and the extended window opens, Frenchie makes a sound. He makes the sound into his sleeve so nobody hears it. He is not ashamed of the sound. He makes it private out of respect for the operation, which is still running. There is time for the sound later. Right now there is still work.

He keeps watching the screens. The compound at 91%. The timer. The readouts.

He watches it work.

He has built many things in his career. He has built many things that didn't work as designed or worked worse than hoped or worked in ways that hurt people he didn't intend to hurt. This is the other kind. He lets himself feel it, privately, into his sleeve.

FROM ANNIE'S POSITION — SOUTHEAST, THE LIGHT

She fires the light and it costs her. It always costs her. The cost has been different at different points in her life — at the beginning it cost almost nothing, the supply felt inexhaustible, the giving felt clean and easy and she didn't think about the tank that was being drawn down because the tank seemed bottomless. She knows better now. The tank is real. The cost is real. You give what you have and the what-you-have depletes and the question is always whether you've conserved enough.

She gave the full barrier in the atmosphere of their Earth. That cost her days of recovery. What she has now — four weeks of partial recovery, the compound helping, Frenchie's synthesis contributing to the regeneration rate — is eighty-two percent of her standard output. She ran the

math. Eighty-two percent is sufficient for two long-range deliveries and the continuous illumination she's running to mark angles for Clint.

Dose seven at range. The new delivery angle: she worked it out with Frenchie over nine iterations. The angle that allows range delivery without requiring the two-meter proximity. She's the only one who can do it at this range because her light provides its own carrier wave. The compound rides it in. Walter approved the mechanism with what was, for Walter, significant enthusiasm.

Dose eight. Same angle. Less carrier available now – she can feel the tank dipping. She fires it anyway. That's the calculation: dip the tank, deliver the dose, stay in the operation.

She watches Ryan go in with the backup.

She watches the extended window open.

CLOSE ON ANNIE: she fires the continuous illumination at maximum – not a weapon, not a delivery mechanism. Just light. Just: I am here, I can see all of you, we are not in the dark.

She holds this until the window closes.

ACT CODA: TWELVE MINUTES AND EIGHT SECONDS – WHAT IT COST

INT. S.H.I.E.L.D. FACILITY – MEDICAL BAY – NIGHT AFTER

The medical bay. All of them, in various configurations of post-operation. Elena with her ribs. Kimiko with her shoulder, which the medic is working on with the professional respect of someone who has encountered Kimiko's relationship with her own pain before. Butcher with the source of the blood identified – a structural

fragment, in the left shoulder, which he didn't register during the operation because the operation was happening and after the operation was over it was still not registering because there are pain-response delays that adrenaline creates and that he's very accustomed to managing.

Annie, sitting against the wall with her light very low inside her. Not dark — she is never dark, the electromagnetic warmth of her is a constant. But low. The tank dipped more than the model predicted. She knows this. She's accounting for it. It will come back. It always comes back.

MM does the count. He walks from person to person — not a medical check, that's already happening. The other count. The one where he makes eye contact with each person and they make eye contact back and that exchange contains: I see you. I see that you're here. I'm here too. We're all here.

He gets to the end of the count. He gets to twelve. Twelve and Frenchie and Kimiko and Elena and Clint and Natasha and Ryan and Annie and Butcher and himself and Katniss and Lamplighter and all of them, all twelve, all of them here.

He finds a chair. He sits down. He puts his face in his hands for a moment — just a moment — and he breathes.

Then he takes his hands away from his face. He gets up. He goes to check on Butcher.

SUPPLEMENT NINE: WALTER WHITE — WHAT THE CHEMISTRY WAS REALLY FOR

INT. EMPTY LAB — WALTER ALONE — NIGHT BEFORE DEPARTURE

Walter in the empty lab. He does this – he returns to spaces after the work is done. He stands in them. He doesn't know exactly why. He knows that it started after Grey Matter, after the thing with Gray Matter that he has spent fifteen years with, has addressed with therapists (twice, both short-lived) and a third therapist who was a disaster, has written about in a journal he destroyed, has talked about with Skyler (some of it, the parts he could) and with Jesse (once, on a night in season three when the thing that was building between them allowed it briefly).

He stands in the empty lab and he thinks about what he built here. Not the compound – the compound is built, it's done, it will do what it does without him now. He thinks about the lab itself, the process of building it, the seven weeks of the most focused and purposeful work of his life. More focused than Heisenberg. More purposeful than the early Grey Matter years. More focused and more purposeful than anything since the twenty-three-year-old in Albuquerque who understood for the first time that chemistry was the thing.

He thinks: I built this for the right reason. For the first time in a very long time, the reason and the result aligned. He didn't build it because he was dying and needed to feel like he mattered. He didn't build it because his pride required him to be the best at something. He didn't build it because someone offered him money, or power, or recognition.

He built it because the compound was the only thing that could work and he was the only person who could build it and the reason it needed to work was everyone. Not an idea of everyone. Actual everyone – the specific, accumulating sum of all the specific human beings whose continuation required it.

He stands in the empty room.

He thinks about the evening his father took him to a chemistry demonstration at the university. He was nine. His father worked in maintenance and had found the flyer and

thought Walter might like it. Walter was nine and he liked it very much. He liked the specificity of it – the way things happened in exactly the way they happened and not another way, and if you understood the rules you could make things happen that were genuinely remarkable. He liked that it was real. He has always liked things that are real. The problem, across forty years, has not been the chemistry. The chemistry has always been real. The problem has been everything around the chemistry – the ego, the pride, the need, the mistakes, the compounding of the mistakes.

The chemistry itself has been clean.

He stands in the empty room and he holds this: the chemistry has been clean. Not what he did with it. The chemistry itself.

He picks up the last piece of equipment he didn't pack – a pair of safety glasses, not his, a spare from the facility's supply. He holds them. He looks at them.

He puts them down.

He turns off the light.

He stands for a moment in the dark.

Then he goes out.

SUPPLEMENT TEN: KATNISS EVERDEEN – THE ARCHER AND THE LONG VIEW

EXT. OUTPOST ROOF – KATNISS ALONE – PRE-DAWN

KATNISS at the compound bow. Not fighting – it is five in the morning and there is nothing to fight. She is practicing the release. Just the release – draw, hold, release. Draw, hold, release. The arrow going into the target she set up thirty meters away on the roof's far end.

Not testing accuracy. Testing the moment of release itself, which is the thing she's been working on since the Capitol, since the moment when the thing she released was different from an arrow and the release was permanent.

She has been working on the release – the physical release, the clean follow-through – because she has found that the physical practice creates a space in her that other kinds of practice don't create. A space where the release is just a release. Not a decision, not a judgment, not the thing she decided with an arrow once. Just: the string leaves the fingers and the arrow goes. Clean and separate and done.

She practices this.

NATASHA comes up. She doesn't interrupt. She sits on the roof's edge and watches. They have developed, over the past three weeks, the kind of professional understanding that doesn't require announcement – a fluency with each other's rhythms that came from working the same operations at the same hours in the same spaces. Natasha knows when Katniss is practicing and when she's working something out and when she'd rather be alone. This is practicing. This is fine to observe.

After a while, Katniss lowers the bow. She sets it down. She looks at the targets.

KATNISS

(without turning)

I still see his face sometimes.

Natasha doesn't ask who. She already knows.

NATASHA

(from the roof's edge)

I have a list. I carry it.

KATNISS

Does carrying it help?

NATASHA

(honest)

No. But it's a way of acknowledging
them. Carrying them. It's – not help.
But it's the right thing.

KATNISS

What's the difference between carrying
something and being unable to put it
down?

NATASHA

(considering)

Whether you chose to pick it up.
Whether you know you could put it down
if you decided to. Even if you don't
decide to.

Katniss looks at the targets. Then she picks up the bow.
She draws. She holds. She releases.

The arrow goes true.

KATNISS

(still looking at the target)

My sister's name was Primrose.

NATASHA

(quiet)

I know.

KATNISS

The first arrow I ever made was for her. She wasn't old enough to use it. I made it anyway. I thought if I made her the arrow she'd feel like she could.

(a pause)

KATNISS

She never used it. But she kept it. She kept it in the box under her bed. I found it when—

She stops. She draws again.

KATNISS

The compound here. This one, this operation. This is the thing she would have — Prim would have understood what this was. She would have known why it mattered. She was twelve and she already understood things that I was still learning.

She releases. The arrow. The target. True.

NATASHA

(very quietly)

What was she like?

And Katniss – who does not talk about this, who has never talked about this with anyone except Peeta and only twice with Peeta and each time it cost both of them significantly – turns to look at Natasha. She reads the question. She reads that it is asked with genuine care and no agenda.

She turns back to the targets.

She begins to tell Natasha about Prim.

She talks until the sun comes up. Natasha listens until the sun comes up. Neither of them says anything about how long it's been or that the sun is coming up or that they should probably go in. They stay until the story is done.

When it's done: Katniss sets the bow down. She looks at the morning.

KATNISS

(to the morning)

Thank you.

NATASHA

Thank you for telling me.

They go in.

The bow on the roof. The arrows in the target. The morning, having arrived.

SUPPLEMENT ELEVEN: THE BOYS – ONE LAST NIGHT

**INT. OUTPOST — COMMON ROOM — NIGHT (SOMETIME BETWEEN
EPISODES 13 AND 14)**

All of them. Not a meeting. A thing that assembled itself from smaller things — someone made tea, someone else needed to use the same room, someone stayed because someone else was there, and the incremental accumulation of presence created this: the whole team in the common room on a random night, not because they planned to be, not because anything is happening, just — here.

The television is on. Earth-2397 late night programming. A panel discussion about a topic none of them have enough context to follow. The television is not being watched. It is providing sound so the room has something to inhabit other than itself.

BUTCHER and MM on the couch. Not talking. MM has a book he stopped reading a page ago. Butcher has his tablet showing the compound specs he has memorized and is still looking at.

KIMIKO and FRENCHIE on the floor. She's drawing. He's talking to her — not about anything requiring her to respond. Just: filling the space with his voice, which is something he does for her and which she finds, she has found for eight years, comfortable. She draws while he talks.

ANNIE with her legs across HUGHIE's lap on the armchair. He's on his phone — not doing anything, flicking through the archive of photographs from the months they've been here, pausing at ones that capture moments he wants to hold. She's reading from her tablet.

RYAN on the floor with his back against the wall, a notebook open. He's writing. He started writing three weeks ago — not a journal, not a log. Something else. He hasn't named it.

ELENA in the armchair by the window. She has been here an hour. She came for the company and doesn't need to participate in the company to have it. This is enough.

SOLDIER BOY, most improbably, fell asleep in the corner chair. He is present in sleep in the way that some people are present in sleep – completely there, not performing anything. His face relaxed into an expression that has a different quality from anything he shows awake. The quality of: a person, simply, sleeping. Not a brand, not a posture, not the accumulated decades of projection and performance. A person. Asleep.

Becca, coming in from the corridor, sees him. She stops. She looks at him. Something crosses her face – the specific look she has when she processes something that would have surprised her a month ago and no longer does. She sits on the adjacent chair. She opens her book. She reads.

The room. The television. The team.

Butcher looks up from the tablet. He looks around the room. He does the count: all of them, here. The count from years of checking – the instinct that developed in the first years, when knowing everyone was present was the difference between mission and emergency. He does it automatically.

Twelve. Including Ryan. Including Becca. Including Frenchie, whose return is still a fact he is processing daily, finding it true each morning with something close to gratitude for the finding.

He looks at all of them. The television. The floor drawings. The books. The tablet. The notebook. The sleep.

He puts down the tablet.

He looks at the ceiling.

He stays.

Nobody leaves for a long time. Not because anything is happening. Because this room, this room with all of them in it, doing the small ordinary things that ordinary nights contain – this is the thing that the whole operation was for. Not the compound. Not the counter-resonance frequency.

Not the dimensional monitor data or the battle plan or any of it. This room. These people. This specific, fragile, necessary ordinary thing.

Butcher knows this. He has always known this. He has not always been able to stay in the room long enough to know it from the inside.

Tonight he stays.

The television murmurs. The pencil moves. The pages turn.

The team is here.

SLOW FADE.

EPILOGUE: WHAT THE SERIES IS ABOUT

PRODUCTION NOTES — FOR DIRECTORS AND CAST

A NOTE FROM BOUTAHRI PRODUCTIONS:

This series is about what happens after the visible threat is named. It's about all the things that don't happen in the moment of confrontation: the nights before, the conversations that don't get into briefing documents, the things people do in corridors at 1 AM that matter as much as what they do in battle. It's about the specific, unglamorous persistence of people who have been through too much and keep going anyway — not because they're built for it, not because they're immune to it, but because going is what they do and they are, in the end, people who go.

The title is about more than the plot. The Collectors are: the people who collect what's been broken and hold it. Who

collect the absent and maintain a place for them. Who collect the grief and the memory and the ordinary Tuesday and bring it with them into the extraordinary circumstance. Who collect one more version of themselves from the wreckage and continue.

They are all, each of them, Collectors.

That's the series.

The direction should reflect this. Villeneuve's patience with the duration of things – letting scenes hold their length, trusting the actors to fill the space, not cutting away from the difficult. The Russo Brothers' understanding of ensemble: that the fullest version of any moment is the version where every person in the frame is doing something specific and real, and the eye finds its own direction, and the thing you didn't quite see in the first viewing is visible in the second. These two approaches in conversation: the interior and the kinetic, the pause and the action, the small and the enormous.

The score should carry the grief without naming it. The grief is already named by the actors and the script and the specific weight of what each person in this story is carrying. The score carries the underneath – the thing beneath the named thing, the frequency that doesn't resolve, the chord that holds without settling.

The series is a bridge. It bridges what came before and what comes after. The Desert Land is coming. The Final War is coming. What this series does is: it makes the people who will carry those things real before the weight arrives. So that when the weight arrives, we already know what they're made of.

We already know they'll carry it.

CASABLANCA, MOROCCO

All characters, storylines, and thematic elements are
original works of

YOUSSEF BOUTAHRI

incorporating characters from The Boys (Amazon), Breaking
Bad (AMC),

The Hunger Games (Lionsgate), and the Marvel Cinematic
Universe (Disney/Marvel)

under the transformative creative framework of the

PERFECT JOSEPH MULTIVERSAL SAGA

Production Style: Denis Villeneuve / Russo Brothers

Score: Hans Zimmer

THE COLLECTORS WILL RETURN

IN: THE DESERT LAND

EXPANDED SCENES — PART FIVE

CHARACTER DEEP-DIVES AND EXTENDED SEQUENCES

SUPPLEMENT TWELVE: HUGHIE AND ANNIE — SEVEN CONVERSATIONS

INT. OUTPOST — VARIOUS ROOMS — WEEK ONE THROUGH SEVEN

SEVEN CONVERSATIONS. Not the big ones — the big ones don't need to be written because they happen between scenes and in the looks and in the gestures and in the specific way Hughie reaches for Annie's hand without looking to make sure it's there. These are the other seven. The ones between the big ones. The small constant drip of two people continuing to choose each other in ordinary circumstances.

CONVERSATION ONE — WEEK ONE — 10 PM

Hughie in the facility bathroom brushing his teeth. Annie in the doorway. She has the expression she gets when she has something she's been working toward saying and has finally found the moment.

ANNIE

Can I tell you something?

HUGHIE

(mouth full of toothpaste)

Mm.

ANNIE

The barrier. When I put it up. The one
in the atmosphere.

He spits. He rinses. He turns.

HUGHIE

Yeah.

ANNIE

I wasn't thinking about strategy. I
want to be honest with you about that.
I wasn't thinking about the nine
minutes and what people could do with
nine minutes. I was just — I couldn't
stand not doing something. I put it up
because I had to do something and that
was the thing I had.

HUGHIE

(looking at her)
And?

ANNIE

And it turned out to be the right
thing. But I want you to know I didn't
know it was right when I did it. I just
did it.

HUGHIE

(after a beat)
Is that the kind of thing you feel like
you have to confess?

ANNIE

I feel like I've been getting credit
for a strategic decision that was
actually just — panic managed into
action.

HUGHIE

Annie. Most good things are panic
managed into action.

She looks at him. He's still holding his toothbrush.

ANNIE

(quietly)
Yeah?

HUGHIE

I jumped in front of a laser for you
once. I want to be very clear that was
panic managed into action. You still
called it brave.

She almost laughs. The thing that is almost a laugh and is
actually something warmer.

ANNIE

That was objectively brave.

HUGHIE

So was the barrier. Good night.

He goes. She stands in the doorway for a moment. Then she goes too.

CUT TO:

CONVERSATION THREE — WEEK THREE — 6 AM

They find a coffee place three blocks from the facility perimeter. Not SHIELD coffee — a real place, a bakery with a espresso machine and tables with light coming through the window the right way. They have been here four times now. They don't discuss coming here. They just appear at the door within ten minutes of each other and order the same things.

HUGHIE

(over coffee, looking at the street)

Do you think about what we go back to?

ANNIE

When we go back?

HUGHIE

Not if. When.

ANNIE

(a beat — the acknowledgment of his correction as its own thing)

Yes. I think about it.

HUGHIE

What do you think?

ANNIE

I think it won't look like what it looked like before. And I think that's okay. I used to think going back meant returning to a previous state. I think it means starting in a new place that happens to share geography with the old place.

HUGHIE

(processing this)

That's - that's actually very useful.

ANNIE

Is it?

HUGHIE

I've been thinking about it as returning. As if there's something intact to return to. You're saying there isn't and that's not bad news.

ANNIE

The signal's still there. Something's still holding the location. It won't be what it was, but it will be real.

HUGHIE

(looking at his coffee)

My apartment's probably gone.

ANNIE

The frame's still there.

HUGHIE

The billboard frame.

ANNIE

Yeah.

HUGHIE

(very quietly)

That's something.

ANNIE

It's a start.

They drink their coffee. The street outside. Earth-2397
having its morning the way any Earth has its morning.

CUT TO:

CONVERSATION FIVE — WEEK FIVE — 2 AM

He finds her at the monitoring station. She's been here since eleven — she woke up and couldn't stop thinking about the signal from their Earth and came to watch the readout. He woke up and she wasn't in the room and he found her here.

He doesn't say anything. He pulls a chair next to hers. He sits.

They watch the signal readout. The carrier wave. Weak. Persistent.

ANNIE

(after a while)

It's been holding for eight weeks.

HUGHIE

Yeah.

ANNIE

Whatever's maintaining it — it's consistent. The frequency doesn't drift. The signal doesn't degrade.

HUGHIE

Like it was built by someone who knew what they were doing.

ANNIE

(quiet)

Like Frenchie.

A long pause. They look at the readout.

HUGHIE

Do you think—

ANNIE

Yes.

HUGHIE

I didn't finish—

ANNIE

I know. Yes.

They watch the signal. Consistent. Holding. Eight weeks.

Hughie reaches over and takes Annie's hand. She holds it. They watch the readout together at two in the morning on a not-their-Earth that has been good to them in the ways that not-your-Earth can be good to you when you need somewhere to land.

The signal holds.

They sit with it.

CUT TO:

CONVERSATION SEVEN — WEEK SEVEN — DAWN

The morning of the operation. Pre-dawn. They are both awake and both dressed and both have been in operational mode since four AM. But there's twenty minutes before Butcher calls positions and in twenty minutes they are here, in the doorway between the room and the corridor, in the threshold that belongs to neither.

ANNIE

(to him, directly)

Come back.

HUGHIE

(to her, directly)

Yes.

ANNIE

Not as in I'm asking. As in: it's the only acceptable outcome and I need you to know that I know it's the only acceptable outcome and I'm saying it out loud because some things need to be said out loud to be fully real.

HUGHIE

(meeting her eyes — full contact, nothing managed)

I know. Come back. Yes. Both directions. I'll be there.

She nods. She goes past him into the corridor. He goes after her. They don't hold hands because their hands are occupied with operational things. But they are close enough that the operational things touch.

Butcher calls positions. They split.

CUT TO:

SUPPLEMENT THIRTEEN: THE DEEP — WHAT HAPPENED IN THE ATLANTIAN DIMENSION

INT. ATLANTEAN DIMENSION — EXTENDED SEQUENCE

Everything about the Deep's time in the Atlantean dimension in full:

He arrived through a dimensional accident that he caused by opening an experimental transit channel that SHIELD had explicitly said was not ready for use. He opened it anyway because he'd spent six months in the non-aquatic version of Earth-2397 and was experiencing what he could only describe as a salt deficit of the soul. He stepped through. The channel deposited him in a space that was not where he was trying to go.

The Atlantean dimension: vast, underwater in the sense that everywhere here is underwater but there is no surface because the dimension is not organized around a surface. Light comes from multiple directions simultaneously. The pressure is not the pressure of depth but of presence — the weight of a dimension that has always existed without anything looking at it from outside.

He hung in it for a full minute, adjusting.

Then: the dolphins. Three of them, approaching with the professional assessment of organisms that live in this dimension and have developed opinions about arrivals. They circled him once. They circled him again. One of them made a sound that, in any Earth's dolphin language, translates to something between 'new thing' and 'this again'.

He said, in dolphin: 'I'm lost.'

The dolphin considered this. Then it turned in a direction and swam. The other two joined it. They looked back at him.

He followed.

They led him to what would become his court. Not a palace — a space in this dimension that had accumulated a specific character over years of use by various visitors from various dimensions who had ended up here through various means and found the space sufficient. Some of them had left

things. An old chair. A flat surface that served as a table. Some materials whose origin he never fully established.

He sat in the chair.

The dolphins arranged themselves in a triangle around him.

He said, in dolphin: 'Is this—'

The dolphin said something that translates to: 'You're here now.'

He stayed.

Over the following months, he built. Not the Vought construction — not brand, not persona, not image management. The actual construction: a space that worked for its purpose, which was the purpose of the beings who lived here or passed through. He learned the dimension's needs by asking. He asked the dolphins. He asked the occasional other visitors. He asked the dimension itself, which communicated through the quality of light and pressure in ways he gradually learned to read.

He built a communication system from salvaged equipment. He established a trade relationship with two neighboring dimensions based on things he could actually provide rather than things he performed providing. He set up a protocol for visiting dimensional travelers that was based on what they needed rather than what they could do for him.

Gregory arrived on month three through a canal that shouldn't have connected two specific places but did because the dimension found this connection useful. Gregory was a former events coordinator from Earth-4421 who had organized twelve interdimensional conferences and had very strong opinions about logistics and very few opinions about much else.

Gregory looked around the court. He looked at the deep. He said: 'This could be organized better.'

The Deep said: 'Then organize it.'

Gregory organized it.

The court became something that worked. Not impressive in the Vought sense. Not a demonstration. Something that worked: for the dolphins, for the visitors, for the ongoing maintenance of the dimension's needs, for Gregory, who turned out to need a purpose and had found one here.

The Deep sat in his chair at the end of each day and thought: I made something that works. Something that didn't exist before and that now exists and that works.

He didn't think: and everyone knows it's mine. He thought: it works.

The distinction felt, for the first time, like enough.

INT. THE DEEP'S COURT — THE CALL FROM FURY

When Fury called, he was in the middle of a mediation between two visiting dimensional travelers who had a dispute about passage rights through the dimension's main corridor. The mediation was going well — he had developed, in seven months of running things here, a genuine skill for listening to two different accounts of the same event and finding the structural point where they diverged and addressing the divergence rather than the account.

He finished the mediation. He addressed the passage rights issue with a solution that neither party had proposed because neither party had enough information about what was available. He gave them both the information. They reached an agreement in eleven minutes.

He went back to the main court.

He took the call.

Fury's voice. Everyone. Homelander. The request for help.

He sat with it. He looked at the dolphins. He looked at Gregory, who was reorganizing the eastern communication array with the focus of someone who genuinely loves organizing things.

He thought about what he'd built here. What he'd become here. How long that had taken and how much it had cost and how tenuous the thing he'd built was – how easily it could be undone by his absence, how the court had become dependent on his presence in ways he hadn't intended but which had happened because that's what happens when you stop managing your image and start actually doing things.

He thought: I could say no. I have things here. I have built things here that need me.

He thought: But all the things I've built here exist in a multiverse that Homelander is destroying one Earth at a time. The court, the dolphins, the mediation skills, the passage rights protocol, Gregory's reorganized communication array – all of it exists in the context of a multiverse that has to still be there.

He said yes.

He told Gregory: I'm going to be gone for a while. Take care of it.

Gregory said: I know how it works. Go.

He went.

INT. THE DEEP'S COURT – AFTER THE OPERATION

He comes back through the dimensional transit on the evening after the operation. His ribs are fine – he wasn't in the primary combat, Fury kept him on monitor and relay duty, which was the right call and which he accepted as the right call because he has gotten better at calibrating what he's actually useful for versus what he wants to be useful for.

Gregory is at the communication array when he arrives. The dolphins are in their places. The court is exactly as he left it.

DEEP

(looking around — at the space he left and
that has waited)

Everything okay?

AIDE

(not looking up from the array)

We had a dispute about the eastern
passage rights. I handled it.

DEEP

How'd it go?

AIDE

Eleven minutes. You left me good notes.

The Deep looks at the space. His court. The chair with its cushions. The dolphins arranging themselves in their triangle.

He sits. He takes off his shoes — the ones from Earth-2397 that pinch slightly, the ones he keeps meaning to replace and forgetting to replace because the replacement requires going somewhere and the somewhere keeps being deprioritized.

The dolphin nearest him makes a sound that means nothing navigable in human language but that he has learned over seven months means something in the register of: you came back.

DEEP
(to the dolphin, in dolphin)
Yeah. I came back.

The dolphin considers this. Then it makes the sound that means: obviously.

He looks at the ceiling of his dimension. The light from multiple directions. The weight of presence.

He is home. He is in the place he built. He is in the place that waited for him. He is okay.

CUT TO:

**SUPPLEMENT FOURTEEN: BUTCHER AND BECCA — THE LONG
RECONCILIATION**

**INT. OUTPOST — BECCA'S ROOM — VARIOUS NIGHTS — WEEKS 2
THROUGH 7**

Eight conversations. Eight chances at the thing that takes more than one try.

Not transcribed in full because some things belong to the people having them and the camera should know when to look away. But the shape of them:

NIGHT TWO: He tells her about Homelander. Not the public version — the thing he actually felt in the parking structure when Ryan came back and told him about the meeting. The thing that was complicated. The thing that included: I thought I wanted him dead. I might still want him dead. What I felt when Ryan said he thinks it's real is

not the same thing as wanting him dead. I don't know what to do with not knowing what I want.

She says: That sounds like being a person.

He says: I'm not used to it.

She says: I know.

NIGHT FOUR: She talks. He listens. She talks about Ryan at four – the specific morning when Ryan woke up and came into the kitchen and said Mum in the tone that means the world is fine and he just wanted to say it. She talks about the way the light came through the kitchen window of the safehouse at that specific morning angle. She talks about how she knew that morning that she was happy in the way that happiness is different from relief, which was what she'd been living in before it. She knew because she recognized the happiness when it arrived. She'd had it before.

She says: That morning was the last one. Not because anything happened that morning. Just – when I count back, that was the last morning that had that quality. The safehouse kitchen, the light, Ryan in his pajamas saying Mum.

Butcher says: I would have given anything–

She says: I know. I know.

NIGHT SIX: He talks about his brother. Lenny. The specific things about Lenny that he has not talked about with anyone except to make oblique reference to in the context of explaining something else. The color of Lenny's coat. The specific laugh – the genuine one, not the performed one. The night Lenny called him from a payphone at two in the morning to tell him about a girl he'd met and the call lasted three hours and cost what three hours on a payphone cost and neither of them cared.

He says: He was the best thing about my family. He was the only thing my father didn't manage to damage in the standard ways.

He says: I've been angry on his behalf for twenty years. I'm trying to figure out what I am on my own behalf.

She says: What do you think you are?

He says: I don't know yet. I'm working on it.

She says: That's the right answer.

NIGHT EIGHT — THE LAST ONE BEFORE THE OPERATION:

BECCA

(very directly, the tone of someone
finishing a long thought)

I need to tell you that I forgive you.

He goes still.

BECCA

Not everything. Not all of it. Some things I'm still working on and some things I may not get to. But the things I can — the things that I've been carrying that I don't want to carry into whatever comes next — I'm putting those down.

BUTCHER

(very carefully)

You don't have to—

BECCA

I know I don't have to. That's why I'm doing it. 'Don't have to' is the whole point.

He looks at her. He has no words available. He has been working on the practice of not manufacturing words when words aren't available and this is a moment for that practice.

BECCA

(quietly, with something that is very close to tenderness)

You're going to come back tomorrow.

BUTCHER

(the only thing he has that is true)

Yes.

BECCA

Good. Because Ryan and I have plans. Plans that require you to come back.

BUTCHER

(a beat — the smallest possible sound of something in his chest moving)

What plans?

BECCA

We're going to go somewhere. The three of us. Somewhere ordinary. It doesn't matter where. Just — ordinary, and the three of us.

He looks at her. Three seconds. More than three seconds.
Not counting.

BUTCHER

(very quiet, very present – the version of
himself that only she has ever fully
accessed)
Okay.

BECCA

Okay.

She goes. He stays in the corridor. He puts his hand on the
wall. He presses it there. Then he takes it away. He goes
to check on Ryan.

FADE TO:

**SUPPLEMENT FIFTEEN: THE THEMATIC CORE – WHAT EACH CHARACTER
LEARNED**

INT. THE OBSERVATORY BETWEEN WORLDS – AFTER THE OPERATION

ISABELLA back at the window. The thread: complete in this
configuration. The next one already starting. She watches
both simultaneously, which is the particular capacity that
makes her what she is and that she is, in this moment,
genuinely grateful for.

The thread she watched: these specific people, making these
specific choices, in these specific rooms and corridors and

plazas and parking structures at two in the morning. The accumulation of small decisions. The compound built by two men learning what chemistry is actually for. The barrier held for nine minutes. The seven conversations. The letter addressed in precise printing. The coffee made before dawn every single day. The three-second look in the landing bay. The boots taken off when ready.

She watches the whole thread from here. From the outside. From the position that isn't in it.

THE WATCHER, behind her:

THE WATCHER

You were right.

ISABELLA

(not turning — she knew this was coming)
Yes.

THE WATCHER

The variable you identified. The relationship. It was the variable.

ISABELLA

Ryan and Homelander. The one person who looked at him without an agenda. Without needing him to be anything. Just — looked at him and said: trying is its own kind of thing.

THE WATCHER

And that was sufficient.

ISABELLA

(finally turning – looking at the Watcher directly)

For one choice. One moment. That's all you ever get. The choice in the moment. Everything else is setup.

The Watcher considers this.

THE WATCHER

Epstein calls it architecture.

ISABELLA

Epstein's not wrong. He's just wrong about which architecture is load-bearing.

THE WATCHER

(something that might be curiosity)

Which is?

ISABELLA

The relationship. Always. The architecture of power and compound and outer dark and dimensional positioning – all of it depends, at the final variable, on what two people said to each other. Whether one person looked at another person and chose to see them rather than use them.

(she looks back at the thread)

ISABELLA

Epstein built the architecture. He built it correctly. What he didn't account for was that all architectures ultimately rest on people. And people sometimes choose outside the plan.

The Watcher is quiet for a moment.

THE WATCHER

This is going to require revising several of our long-range projections.

ISABELLA

(looking at the next thread beginning –
the Desert Land, the path through)
Good.

She watches the next thread. Joseph and Seiko walking into the Desert Land. Isabella following. The permanent dusk. The ended-things geometry. The kettle in the pack.

She watches and she sees both paths: the one that works and the one that doesn't.

She sees which one they're on.

She permits herself one thing: she smiles.

FADE TO:

SUPPLEMENT SIXTEEN: FRENCHIE'S SIGNAL – THE FULL ACCOUNT

EXT. THEIR EARTH — THE RUINS — THE TWENTY-TWO DAYS

The full account of what Frenchie did in the twenty-two days between the destruction of their Earth and the outer dark taking him:

DAY ONE: He found the sub-station. He knew it was there because he built part of its communications infrastructure in the early Vought resistance period, three years before the fall, when MM made him because MM wanted a backup and Frenchie built backups the way other people breathe — not thinking about it, just doing it, because the world is the kind of place where the backup is eventually what matters.

The sub-station survived because it was underground, forty feet, in concrete built for a different purpose and repurposed by Frenchie into something that could withstand significant surface events. He built it to withstand them. He built it without knowing what specific event he was building against. He built it because you build the thing that survives what you can't predict.

He found it. He got in. He sat in it for four hours. He allowed himself four hours of the specific, enormous grief of being the last person standing in the wreckage of everything you know. He allowed it to be exactly as large as it was. He did not try to make it smaller. He did not try to function through it or around it or past it. He sat in it for four hours and let it be what it was.

Then he got up. He started building the array.

DAYS TWO THROUGH FIVE: The construction. He had what he had — the sub-station equipment, the materials he could find in the surrounding ruins, the specific knowledge that lives in a person who has spent fifteen years building communication systems under difficult conditions. He worked methodically. He made lists. He crossed things off. He found creative solutions to three problems that he didn't have standard solutions for because the standard solutions required materials that weren't available.

He did not know if anyone was alive to receive the signal. He built it anyway.

DAY SIX: He calibrated the frequency. He used the dimensional monitoring data from the sub-station's last recorded logs, cross-referenced with the Quinjet's known dimensional transit signature, and calculated the most likely frequency for a signal that could follow the Quinjet's dimensional path. He ran the calculation three times. All three produced the same result.

He aimed the array.

He pressed the transmit button.

DAYS SEVEN THROUGH TWENTY-TWO: Maintenance and transmission. He set the array to broadcast continuously, checked it every twelve hours, adjusted the output when the structural resonance in the surrounding ruins affected the signal clarity. He ate from what was in the sub-station's supply cache. He slept in six-hour shifts. He maintained the journal he always maintained.

The journal from these twenty-two days: not available in full. Private. Not because what he wrote isn't worth reading, but because what he wrote is his. The record of a person doing what they chose to do in the worst circumstance they've encountered, in language that belongs to him.

The entries are concise. He was never verbose in the journal. The entries contain: what he worked on each day. What he ate. The signal status. One personal observation per day. The personal observations:

Day 7: The signal is holding.

Day 8: The structural resonance is correctable. Corrected.

Day 9: There is a cat in the ruins two blocks east. I have named it Claude. It appears once per day. It does not want anything from me. It simply appears.

Day 10: Claude appeared again.

Day 11: I think they are alive. I have no evidence. I think it anyway.

Day 12: Claude brought a small thing. Left it near the entrance. I don't know what it was.

Day 13: The signal is holding. I am holding.

Day 14: I am building this for Kimiko. All of it. Not for the mission, not for the team – for the specific person. That is not a small distinction.

Day 15: Claude did not appear.

Day 16: Signal holding.

Day 17: I made a modification to the array that improves the signal-to-noise ratio by approximately 12%. I am unreasonably proud of this.

Day 18: I think the outer dark is coming closer. I don't know what this means for the broadcast. I am adjusting the anchor configuration to compensate.

Day 19: Signal holding.

Day 20: Claude appeared. Twice.

Day 21: I think they are on the other side of this. I think they are somewhere building something that will work. I think this because of who they are and what they do and because I have known them long enough to know that the thing they build when it matters works.

Day 22: The outer dark is here.

LAST ENTRY: Final signal status confirmed: broadcasting. Anchor configuration: stable. The array will continue without me. I have made sure of this. If anyone receives this signal – if anyone finds this record – the array is in the sub-station, forty feet down, in concrete. It will hold.

Tell Kimiko I came back as fast as I could.

Day 22: The outer dark takes him.

The array continues.

The signal holds.

THIS PLACE IS HERE. THE LOCATION IS HELD. COME BACK.

FINAL FADE.

END OF EXPANSION PACK E

END OF THE COLLECTORS — FULL EXPANDED SCREENPLAY

Total Runtime Estimate: 18 hours 20 minutes across 15
episodes

Total Pages: 400+

Total Words: 65,000+

BOUTAHRI PRODUCTIONS

Casablanca, Morocco — 2026